Carcharodon Carcharias

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/32268871.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F, F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Jaws References, Light Angst, Fluff, Marine Biologist Catra, Police Chief Adora, I don't think there will be any on screen death honestly, single mom adora, Crack Treated Seriously, (not too graphic) descriptions of dead bodies and death, All Human, Minor Character Death, genderfluid Adora, Trans Catra (She-Ra), everybody lost their gender, theres no genders here, catra is a genderfluid trans woman, gearing up for one romantic fishing trip, the author doesn't know any science don't come for me, adora is on the 'police chief to software developer bc ACAB pipeline', no sharks were harmed in the making of this fic, but a fake one sure was, Jaws was already homoerotic it just needed a little push, Pregnancy

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by cabbageboy

Summary

It’s nearing the Fourth of July weekend on Salineas Island, where Adora Brody is preparing to serve her first summer as the Sheriff of this tiny town’s police department. It’s a big summer for the island, the 50th annual parade and celebration were sure to bring the largest smorgasbord yet-

Wait… smorgasbord?

(My stupid little Jaws AU)

AN: Removing fic from AO3 Tuesday August 13th at 8 pm EDT

ACAB
Abolish the police

Notes

I don't even know how to tag this disaster, I just am.... whatever happens happens.

I won't kill anyone 'on screen'
I may describe dead bodies but not in too graphic of detail, though it may still freak some people out

****I don't know anything about marine biology, but I do know how to be dramatic****

Prologue

It was a cool night, the breeze soothing away the haze of sticky evening air as the sun set on the horizon. The ocean glittered in the pure white moonlight, waves licking the shore in a swell and rhythm as the ocean breathed it's steady and comforting motion. While the day had been hot, the last rays of sun took that stagnant warmth with it, and the mist of humidity that hung low in the air dissipated into a clear night.

Across the beach, nestled between dunes, was the only other source of light interrupting the inky blackness on the secluded spot.

While the fire roared on, teenagers cuddled up with their partners under shared blankets. Some sat around the fire in more intimate positions, while others laughed and danced to the tune playing through the portable radio. Coolers dotted the sand, filled with all manner of food and drinks. It was a quiet night, a gathering of friends. Summer vacation always brought them to the beach, their love of the ocean spurring them on in sailing races, surfing competitions, and the occasional day to just lounge on the sand and tan.

None knew that something sinister lay beyond the shore.

A couple shifted, the man getting up and stretching. He brushes his clothes, disrupting the wrinkle in his linen button up shirt. He readjusts the bright red bandana around his head and takes a second to smooth his fingers over his mustache, curling the ends. He looked at his girlfriend with a mischievous twinkle in his eye and raised a brow, backing away from the fire and into the shadows between sand dunes.

She rolls her eyes and gets up to follow, tripping through the sand and giggling along the way. Her flowing skirt trails behind her, exposed stomach shivering as it is torn from under the blanket and thrust into the night, bare. While her expression looked bored

and irritated, her smile was soft, loving. She'd never let on how much she actually liked this guy, not during the day surrounded by witnesses to her suffering and his vast labyrinth of sea based puns and dorky acts of chivalry.

But something about his back facing her as he stared out at his first love, the ocean, brought out that tenderness in her heart.

"Um, what are you doing?" She asks, a whisper on the evening breeze.

His shirt is discarded, and he's just about to move on to his pants.

"Fancy a swim, my lady?" He responds.

She stares at him, hand on her hip.

"Ok, how about we do this tomorrow when we're sober? Plus didn't you hear me complain all day about how many kids I had to save from riptides? It was a little rough out there today for me to just hop in now that no one is around."

He deflates. Sometimes having a beach lifeguard for a girlfriend was great, like that time he capsized his boat and she was a strong enough swimmer to get them to shore. Others, he wished she'd lighten up a little bit. Then again, her strength and attitude mixing with the softness she only had for a select few people was one of the things he loved about her. So, while he is certainly disappointed by her lack of spontaneity and her resistance to doing anything as stupid as the plans he was capable of coming up with, he wasn't going to look at her and say 'no' at the offered alternative.

Plus, everyone knew what the other kids got up to behind the dunes. No one would bother them. So really, it was better than being out in the open, voices echoing across the water directly to their group of friends.

"Anything for you, dearest," He says, zipping his pants back up and leaning down to shake the sand from the shirt he'd left on the

ground.

“How about a walk instead? Your eyes look most radiant in the moonlight.”

She finds herself rolling her eyes again, good naturedly this time instead of baffled by the stupidity of his suggestion, and reaches out to take his hand. They walk along the water for a while, feet slapping against the sheet of hard sand. It’s relative silence, but every once in a while he’ll lean down to whisper in her ear and she'll throw her head back in a laugh or an equally exuberant groan.

Once the bonfire is nothing but a candle flicker in the distance, they turn to walk up the beach. Cattails and tall grasses frame their path as they weave between the dunes, pausing to press against each other and kiss, and pulling back again to drag each other by the hand further in.

Mermista looks around, making sure they’re far enough away from prying eyes, before pushing him by the shoulders down onto his back to lounge against the hill of sand. She straddles his hips and leans down to press her mouth to his, and they’re running their hands over each other.

That is, until something catches her eye over his shoulder, and she looks up to take in the pale grey tangled in seaweed that lay a few feet away. She hadn’t noticed it before, and it takes a second to figure out what it is she’s looking at in the dark.

She shrieks, throwing herself off of him and standing to back away. The action affords her a view of the rest of the mass of fishing net, sea life, and what she now has discerned is flesh.

Human flesh.

Sea Hawk puts his hand on her shoulder, having since stood up to stare at it himself.

“Let’s head back and grab my car, we have to call Chief Brody,” He says, turning her away.

She’s shocked, hasn't said a word since the baffled screech, but he doesn’t see a need to stand around staring at the body long enough for her to process what it is she’s seen.

He steers her away, arm over her shoulder, to head back to where they’d parked. There was a phone in his car, and they’d get the police chief out here to figure out the rest.

The night air, once a relieving coolness to combat the heat of the day, was now a frigid tomb, and the sourness of death clung to both of them as they walked back to their camp.

***

“Mommy the phone is ringing!” Finn’s voice calls from the kitchen. Their shout is loud and pierces her eardrums, but it has to be if it is going to outshine the actual ringing of the phone.

Adora Brody had not known peace since moving to the island and taking the job. If she wasn’t busy with her actual duties as the Sheriff she was playing politics with the town’s Mayor or bending over backwards to help some of the older shop owners keep kids from skateboarding on their sidewalks. It was altogether exhausting, but that was to be expected starting a new job in a town like this.

She almost runs face first into Glimmer as she rushes out of the bathroom, wiping stray toothpaste from her mouth.

“You really have to stop rushing to answer that phone if you want any work-life balance, Adora. There’s other officers for a reason,” Glimmer says, walking by carrying a laundry basket.

She’s eternally grateful for the help, but sometimes Glimmer’s suggestions come a little too frequently and a little too matter of fact.

A crash from the kitchen makes her wince and she waits for a second to make sure it isn't followed by any screaming or crying. A quick shout 'Sorry that was just my coffee!' from Bow makes her exhale and turn her attention back to Glimmer.

Three adults and a six year old didn't allow for a lot of room in this three bedroom shack by the beach, but Glimmer and Bow hadn't thought twice about moving with her to the island when she told them she'd gotten a job. There was even a bit of a separation between bedrooms, two at one end of the house with a long narrow hallway that led to the living room and kitchen. A much shorter hall branched off of the kitchen and led to a third bedroom. That became Glimmer and Bow's, leaving them privacy from Adora and the much smaller, slightly more invasive fourth member of their household.

Shuffling around each other and being entirely too in each other's business was something they'd been doing for over a decade, though, so Adora gives Glimmer a pass for being nosey. She watched Adora push a baby out of her vagina, so it's not like there were many secrets to be had around each other.

"Yeah but I'm the chief, Glim. I can't just ignore it. Especially with how busy summer gets here."

She had been out of police work and more on the bodyguard side of things since Finn was born, but something about her resume and personality, along with the fact that she'd kept up with her firearms and first aid licensing all these years, managed to get her this job. Sure, it wasn't what she'd wanted, but putting food on the table and a roof over their head to make sure Finn got the childhood that she didn't was enough reason to deal with it. Somewhere along the line she'd realized that she didn't have the skills for a well paying career that wasn't completely in harms way, and had been working toward something better since, but money was money when it came to raising a child and it was with guilt that she returned to the work she hated.

Though she didn’t particularly *like* the skills she was using, it didn't feel terrible to be good at her job. Diffusing arguments, making sure people were safe, making sure traffic was organized and boating regulations were followed, those were the parts of the job she was ok with and more often than not that is what she was doing when she worked in a vacation town.

“I know you want to make a good impression and take care of everything so they give you the permanent position, but that doesn’t mean you should run yourself ragged all over town for the littlest things. I just worry if you don’t set boundaries now then when you get the permanent job, they’ll keep expecting you at their beck and call,” She says, backing away to the laundry room at the end of the hall.

“*If I get it*. And I appreciate it Glim, but I know what I'm doing and I have to keep up their game if I have a chance at it,” She squeezes by Bow cleaning up his spilled coffee, and the chair that Finn was in, around the kitchen table to her phone on the counter.

“Chief Brody,” She says as she picks it up.

The voice on the other end is almost frantic, and her face grows more serious the longer they speak.

“Uh… huh.” She goes quiet. Bow notices the shift in her demeanor, her furrowed brow and tense stance.

Glimmer pokes her head out with her own concerned look, and meets eyes with Bow.

“I’ll be right there, soon as I can… Ok… Medical examiner on the way? Good, alright. See you soon.”

She hangs up the phone and places it back on the counter, picking up her watch to buckle around her wrist, and then throws her uniform shirt over the tank top she’d been walking around in. She pauses to rub a hand over her face, sighing, and begins to button the front of her uniform shirt closed.

She walks over to the table where Finn is sitting, eating their oatmeal, and leans down to place a kiss on their forehead. They look up and smile at her, clearly having not paid any mind to the conversation. She ruffles their sandy blonde hair and they giggle a little bit, reaching up to take her hand off of their head and hold it in their own.

Watching them grow up was something she didn't know she wanted until the first moment she held them, and thinking about Finn stumbling across a body, or *being* that body, would be an unavoidable thought that would always make her skin crawl and her stomach turn over in nausea.

Bow and Glimmer come closer, worried looks on their faces.

"You guys are ok to watch Finn right? I have to go."

"Yeah of course, I was going to work from home today anyway. Everything alright buddy?" Bow says, coming up to put his hand on her shoulder.

She relaxes at the touch, but not by much. A glance tells her that Finn has gone back to taking bites of their breakfast and tracing their finger over the puzzle on the back of the box, not paying a bit of attention.

They really didn't need to hear this.

"There's a body on the beach. I have to go meet the medical examiner and the kids that found it."

Bow inhales, stiffening, while Glimmer covers her mouth in horror.

"A body? Did they say what happened?" Glimmer asks.

Adora hesitates. She knows that here-say wouldn't help, but Bow and Glimmer would never walk around gossipping in town about a story that wasn't concrete yet.

"Well the ME isn't there yet, but the kids that found it said there… There are bite marks."

Bow and Glimmer share a glance.

A shark attack would be bad news with how many people were supposed to be headed into town in the next couple of weeks. Public safety was Adora's number one concern with how many tourists would flock to the island, but now there was another threat that she wasn't sure how to deal with, if it were to be true.

"I'm going to get the ME's official cause of death, and then if it's a shark… I have to close the beach."

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Officer Kyle is already waiting in the parking lot with three other people when Adora pulls in. She wasn't nervous, because she'd seen her fair share of bodies over the years in her line of work. That didn't make it any easier, but it did prepare her for what she'd see.

She tried not to think so disrespectfully about a person, or a body that used to be a person, but she was sure that after washing up on the beach in a fishing net and covered in seaweed and crabs, and then baking in the summer sun for a few extra hours, that she wasn't about to see anything short of gnarly.

"Chief Brody, sir!" Kyle says, nervously trapped between a wave and a salute. She isn't sure why he chose police work, because he was a bit of a nervous wreck sometimes, but he was kind and did his paperwork on time, and that was more than she could say than half of the officers in the last town she worked in. The uniform almost falls off of him, and his wavy hair curls out from under his wide brimmed standard issue police hat.

Adora approaches, head held high, and nods to Kyle before turning her attention to the medical examiner. She was probably in her late 40s, laugh lines around her eyes and a few smile wrinkles around her mouth. Her hair was a deep chocolate,

threads of silver starting to streak through as it bounced around her shoulders and crisp white jacket.

"Dr. Norton? Chief Adora Brody, thanks for coming," She says, extending her hand.

The doctor grasps hers firmly, returning the small smile, "Great to meet you Chief. I understand you have a body down here?"

Kyle speaks up, "Yes, I've brought the two who found it to lead the way. We haven't seen it yet."

Adora turns her attention to the two teenagers. They looked awkward, to say the least.

She'd recognize Sea Hawk anywhere, not because she'd run into him causing trouble, but because a picture of him with 'No Service' written below was posted at the entrance of nearly every restaurant in town. He had been a good kid, a little weird and eccentric, but polite nonetheless, in all of her interactions with him. While she's sure he earned all of the posters, she wasn't going to treat him like a criminal when she personally hadn't seen him do anything wrong.

Mermista had been on duty a few of the times that Adora had patrolled by the beach, and she could tell that there was a good head on her shoulders. She was always attentive when she was on duty. Adora had only caught her reading on the job once, and the beach was empty from the impending rainstorm and cloud cover.

Adora winces, thinking about just what they were doing on the beach last night and just how embarrassing it would be to have to retell their entire night for the sake of a police investigation. She'd take their statements later when Kyle and the ME left the scene, but for now, she was pretty invested in avoiding the second hand embarrassment.

Christ, imagine finding a body on the beach when you're trying to… Stop Adora, Jesus.

“Sebastian, Mermista. You kids ok?” She asks.

They look away, but she can tell they’re a little shaken. The hours since, obviously, hadn’t helped relieve them of the memory.

“Eh, we barely saw it… the um… the body.”

“Well, how about you show us where it is, and I’ll get your statements after. You don’t have to look again, just lead us to where you found it and then come up and wait in the lot. Sound good?” She suggests.

“An excellent idea Chief,” Sea Hawk says, grabbing his girlfriend by the hand and starting the trek down to the scene.

The five make their way down the shore, the eerily calm morning a cloak to mask their intentions. When they get close, Sea Hawk and Mermista point ahead and Adora nods wordlessly, leading the way between the dunes.

When they reach the body, it’s just as Adora feared, yet worse somehow. Skin was torn, huge gashes splitting it nearly in half. It’s tangled up so terribly in seaweed and fishing net that it’s hard to make out where one limb starts and where it ends, or if it’s even attached to the body or just tied to its side. Where there isn’t dried and smeared red, sand is packed into the crevices between.

The medical examiner takes her time, while Adora and Kyle hang back to let her do her job. No one says a word, just watching as layers of dried kelp and tangled nylon are peeled back to reveal more and more of the horror beneath.

Dr. Norton stands up and writes in her notepad several times between bouts of investigatory prodding.

She finally stands up straight, turning away from the body.

“We’ll get a gurney down here to take them to the morgue, see if we can identify them.”

Adora steps forward.

“Do you know the cause of death?” She’s terrified of the answer, because they have a tragic accident, a greusom murder, or a disaster of proportions she hadn’t ever dealt with before.

Dr. Norton looks her in the eye.

“Shark attack. No mistaking it, Chief.”

She nods, stepping back. They walk the way back to the parking lot in silence, the weight of the discovery heavy on their minds.

No mistaking it

“Thanks for the help Dr. Norton. We’ll arrange for transport of the body,” Adora says. She turns to Kyle.

“What do we do now, Chief?” He asks.

“I want you to head down to the store and get posters, biggest size they have, markers and some wooden stakes too. Then head back to the station and make enough signs to post at every entrance to this beach.”

“What should the posters say, Chief?”

Beaches Closed
No Swimming
By Order of the Salineas Police Department

If word gets out

Chief Adora smoothes her hand over her face, rubbing her tired eyes and then places her glasses back over the bridge of her nose. After she put Finn to bed and did her course work, she'd stayed up at the kitchen table for a good portion of the night to try to research what to do about their problem. As soon as she made sure Finn had breakfast and one of the other adults in the house was awake, she went into the station, quite a bit earlier than scheduled, to try to get some more work done without falling asleep.

Her hat sat on it's hook on the back of the door next to her jacket, leaving her in her (mostly buttoned) uniform shirt. The sleeves were short, but they were still rolled up and pulled taught over her biceps. The historic building wasn't air conditioned, and the fan she had in the corner wasn't doing a lot to help. She had the window open earlier, but the summer heat quickly made it more harm than good to allow the humidity inside.

"Adooooooooooora," The chilling voice of Mayor Weaver floats through the stoic quiet of the office. Though it sounds borderline airy, the implication of it cuts like a knife. She throws the door the rest of the way open, and Adora can see her hat falling to the floor behind it as it is thrown off of it's hook in the sudden motion.

Adora looks up from her computer screen. Weaver sees the file she'd been viewing, the pictures of sharks reflected back in her glasses, and narrows her eyes.

"What can I do for you, Miss Mayor?" Adora asks, folding her laptop closed and moving to stand.

Mayor Weaver waves her off, electing to sit in the arm chair on the wall opposite Adora's desk.

Adora doesn't *want* to feel intimidated by the Mayor. She doesn't want the sight of her to send a chill down her spine. She certainly

doesn’t want to feel like she’s doing poorly at her job just because of the way Mayor Weaver looks at her out of the corner of her eye.

But she feels all of those things, and every time she thinks about them, guilt pangs in her heart. Guilt because Finn needed her, and because they needed her to hold onto this job for at least the summer, but preferably until she finally finished her degree online and was able to secure something a little safer and more permanent for the two of them.

“I see you’ve decided to close the beaches.”

It isn’t a question, but it demands an explanation.

Adora sits there in her chair, a small office in a run down building at the direct center of town. She hears car horns and shouting outside, shop owners nailing up signs and people laughing on their way to brunch. She hadn’t been here long, and didn’t care much for this town, but couldn’t see a reason to let it’s people get hurt because of any hesitation.

While it was a real emergency, with real consequences, it was clear that Mayor Weaver saw it as a test. Adora wasn’t going to fail, give her any reason to think that she didn’t have the town’s best interests at heart.

“Yes, we had a shark attack, so I saw fit to close the beaches to prevent another while we figure out how to deal with it. I’ve been doing some research, trying to figure out if we should call the coast guard or contract out fishermen. I’ve been meaning to call you to see if you had a SOP for this sort of thing, but I thought I’d give it a shot on my own since you have to be busy this time of year,” Adora responds. While she is proud of her decision, and believed that it was the right one, she didn’t want to betray that pride in her voice too soon.

After all, we still have to catch the damn thing

"I see. Well, I'll forgive you for this first mistake," She starts, condescension oozing from her voice.

Adora's calculated smile falters, dipping low.

"Mistake?" She asks.

Mayor Weaver leans back, crossing one leg over the other and pulling a flask from the inner pocket of her deep crimson suit jacket. She screws the cap off wordlessly, and Adora finds herself near trembling as the woman lifts it to her lips and takes a long sip.

She doesn't even flinch, and Adora can smell the overproof rum from across the room.

"Yes, mistake."

Weaver says it like Adora is a child, like she's put her toy away in the wrong bin or she's gotten a question wrong on her math test.

She puts the flask back in her pocket and stands, pulling a cigarette out of the other pocket and lighting it up. She clearly cared not for the 'No Smoking' signs posted around the building.

Thankful that she carried an inhaler for herself, and a change of clothes in the trunk so the smell wouldn't upset Finn's asthma, Adora prepares for whatever turn this conversation is going. Of all of the things she expected, she didn't think 'mistake' would be among the descriptions of the life saving decision she made today.

Weaver puts sickly pale, slender fingers through an opening in the blinds and spreads them apart. A brighter beam of light splits the room as she looks outside and observes the street.

"Chief Brody, do you know why we hired you for the summer?" She asks.

Adora gulps, swiveling in her chair. She doesn't stand, because there honestly wasn't enough standing room in the office, but also

because it was harder to hide her swaying and fidgeting when she stood then it was when she sat. Still, she tries to piece things together without too much of a revealing frown.

“Because this is a vacation town, and summer is your busiest season. It makes sense to hire someone for the summer, to gauge how they handle the town when it’s at its busiest.”

The reply garners a thoughtful nod, and Adora covers her mouth with her hand as Weaver exhales her long drag of smoke.

She taps the cigarette against her finger and lets the ash fall to the window sill and floor, it’s final landing place none of her concern.

“So why, Chief Brody, would you choose to close our beaches when we are about to enter our busiest season, and the busiest *week* of that season?”

Adora raises an eyebrow, folding her fingers together and resting her elbows on the arms of her chair.

“Well Mayor Weaver, disaster doesn't really wait, and we don’t get to choose when it happens upon us. I closed the beach because I had to, not because of any ill will or intent.”

She thinks it’s a good answer, somewhere bridging the gap between sincere and political. Disaster, in fact, wouldn’t wait.

However, Weaver’s reaction, once again, makes Adora question her own words.

“I see. Well you *didn’t* have to, actually,” She cuts off, putting out her cigarette in the potted plant in the corner. Adora can smell the singed leaf from her desk.

“I didn’t?”

A deep, unmistakably dangerous chuckle.

"No, you didn't. In fact you had no right to, considering you don't know how things work around this town and you were *wrong*."

"What do you mean I was wrong? The medical examiner told me it was a shark attack?" Adora questions.

Mayor Weaver pulls a file from the bag she'd left on the armchair and tosses it to Adora's desk. It definitely isn't an accident that the fold wasn't closed properly, and Adora has to shuffle things around quite a bit to find all of the spilled papers.

"I had a feeling the medical examiner was jumping to conclusions," She says.

Adora sees the paper she'd watched the ME fill out, and sees the slashes through her previous cause of death with a new one written underneath, signed and dated. It must have been just this morning.

Cause of death: boating accident

"You see, you both decided that this was a shark attack, and hopped to in order to spread those false conclusions about what happened. Chief Brody it happens occasionally that someone will be overcome by their exhaustion and succumb to the ocean's pull. It's tragic, really. They'll float just below the surface, and their body will be struck by a water craft and cut up a little bit by the propellers. *That's* what happened to your victim."

"The medical examiner is certain?" She asks, looking through pages and pages.

"Yes, we're all certain. Now, I already sent your junior officer out to collect those ridiculous signs you all made and dispose of them immediately. I'm going to return to my office and clean up a little more of this mess," Mayor Weaver says, turning her back on Adora to move into the doorway.

"Oh, and Chief Brody?" She says.

Adora looks up at her and speaks evenly, measured, “Yes Miss Mayor?”

There’s a glint in Weaver’s eye, something empty and careless that makes Adora shiver.

“You’re a good officer, that much is certain from your file. You’re friendly and you get along with everyone in town. But there are things you don’t understand yet. Don’t go meddling with this town’s only source of income, our only form of prosperity. This position *is* temporary after all. And you have that child of yours to worry about.”

With that, she’s gone, leaving Adora to sink back into her chair.

Finn

What was she doing making a decision, off the cuff, like that? When so much was riding on this, when Finn needed her?

She looks over the paper again, the torn gashes in the victim's skin. She sat for a long while. The worse she felt about the job, the more she worried about being able to take care of Finn, the more those wounds started to look like lacerations from a propeller and not teeth.

Still, she was certain, even more than she could will the feeling away.

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Heavy sighs and a keyboard clicking away permeate the otherwise empty office. The quiet was appreciated by its inhabitant, though she couldn’t deny that there was a slowness and lack of urgency that she fell victim to on days like today. That wasn’t even counting the way her own work had been lackluster lately.

She’d spent a few months touring conventions, speaking about her newly published article and the breakthrough she’d found in her last year of research. It was happenstance that after

graduation and the subsequent publication of her latest work, the University elected to hire her on as an adjunct professor to a more introductory course, and a member of the research team.

Still, now that summer had brought an end to the semester, she found herself doing less teaching and more research. Though it was what her education was based on, needless to say, it got a little dry.

The coffee maker sputters as it empties the last drops of liquid gold into the carafe, filling the tiny kitchen with the deep caramel notes of this particular roast. It's enough to cover the seemingly permanent smell of burnt toast from the oldest toaster oven known to man. The rest of the appliances were worse for wear. A water cooler that gurgled and clicked sat in the very corner, and a microwave that didn't work on high sat atop the counter.

But the coffee maker? That was sacred, what they'd elected to pour the last of their budget of the previous fiscal year into.

The kitchenette was small, with light blue cabinets marked with post-its as to which were to be avoided due to their broken hinges. They held just enough coffee mugs and not a single one more for the research office's inhabitants. It was a galley style, the wall opposite the counter top was covered in newspaper clippings and journal excerpts, pictures of the team and their students.

The typing stops and a chair squeaks as it pushes back from a desk. Footsteps approach from the hall, squeaking as a pair of rubber soles makes first contact with the tile floor of the kitchenette. Beat-up white sneakers, cuffed jeans, and a torn grey sweater was the uniform Dr. Hooper had taken to wearing to the office on research days, when she needed the larger screen of her computer and the ergonomic office chair for the hours of work ahead. She runs a hand through her short hair, freshly cut for the summer, and squints in the fluorescent light of the kitchen. It was a jarring, cold, and sharp transition from her desk, where she'd kept a lamp that was a much warmer color temperature. When

she was alone in the office she kept the bank of fluorescent lights above her cubicle off, so the sudden brightness made her squint.

She opens a cabinet, picking out her designated mug, and fills it right up to the brim. Holding it up to her face, she lets the steam warm her chilled nose. They really cranked the air conditioning during the summer, and she side eyes the locked plastic security case around the thermostat with a bitter hum.

Her phone buzzes in her pocket and she pulls it out, seeing a message to the general office inquiry account. It was an annoying aspect of her job, that whoever was in the office was supposed to respond to messages to that account. It was almost always something stupid, like the location even though the address was posted to the exact same page that one would find this email account, or a question about local fisheries that could be found just as easily online. Still, she makes her way to her desk, one hand in her pocket and the other holding the mug to her mouth so she can sip.

It's smooth and bitter, and Dr. Hooper savors the taste.

She walks by the bay of windows facing the parking lot, seeing the cars and the line of patrons waiting to enter the aquarium across the street. It was the best part of her job, getting to interact with the animals and observe what she'd read about in papers and journals, but she longed for something more. Her graduate research had been in larger species, sharks and whales. She'd spent the majority of her final year of her PhD program writing her dissertation in the bowels of a vessel in the Antarctic, studying humpback whales and their breeding and migratory patterns.

Now that she'd gotten a research gig in an office, she missed the adventure of it all. She missed the salty breeze on her face, sitting around the galley eating the shittiest food she'd ever had in the months between resupplies. She missed looking down into clear blue water and seeing wildlife, unaccustomed to the threat of humans and therefore uninterested in fleeing from them. She

missed getting handed a glass of brandy when she was shivering in her perch, binoculars trained at the horizon.

There was a feeling she got, a feeling she'd been chasing since. It was the feeling of being right on the edge of discovery, right on the precipice, and she'd either plummet to her certain academic and professional death or she'd soar so high that nothing could take that feeling away. It was the feeling of reading a National Geographic article and seeing her name in place of the author's.

Dr. Hooper was in constant search of the feeling she got when she *knew* that her name would be written in history books, and everyone who ever doubted her would have to see her face on the news.

When she gets back to her desk, she opens the email account and sees an inquiry that surprises her.

From: abrody@gmail.com
Subject: Salineas PD, shark attacks
Message:
Good afternoon,

I am contacting the office of marine biology research at UNC with a concern about a recent body that was found on our beach. The medical examiner was certain that it was a shark attack, but has since changed cause of death. I am no doctor, but I find it interesting that the wound patterns look quite a bit different than I would think a boat propeller would make. I have been instructed to seek no further action, but something about it didn't sit right with me.

I am unable to send pictures, because it is a closed investigation that is not supposed to be public record, but I would like to speak to an expert about what to look for and if I should follow through with my concern.

Please contact me via this email, or by phone outside of business hours. I am going pretty far behind my boss's back with this, so I

can't talk about it at the station.

Sincerely,
Chief Adora Brody,
Salineas Police Department
(301) 867-5309

Dr, Hooper leans back, crossing her fingers and bringing both hands back to cradle the back of her neck. She'd never been to Salineas Island, but she knew it was a popular vacation town.

There was something suspicious about a medical examiner ruling that the cause of death was a shark, and then changing their mind later to a boating accident. Amending a conclusion upon the discovery of new information is what science is all about, but there was a huge difference in the type of wounds one would encounter between these two rulings. Propellers were smooth and sharp, and while they were three, sometimes more, individual blades, it's not like they were jagged like shark teeth. Sharks bit down and tore, shaking back and forth, while a propeller would slash in smooth strokes.

Being instructed to seek no further action with something like this, and keeping it out of the public eye no less, was a blaring red alarm in her head.

She forwards the email to her personal account, and then deletes it from the office account. If anyone had asked there would be a bit of convincing to be done on whether that was to protect the sender from others finding out and possibly contacting her, or if it was so no one took the case right out from under Dr. Hooper when she was instantly invested in it.

Just the possibility of something to research, something to investigate, something to *do* had her giddy in a way she hadn't felt since she got off that research vessel in Southern Argentina to return to her life in North Carolina.

Maybe it was time for a little summer trip.

***

Adora walks in the house, tossing her keys on the table beside the door, and smiles at the sight before her. It was late, and Finn was snuggled down into a pile of blankets on the floor with Bow and Glimmer flanking them. They were watching some cartoons on the TV, all dressed up in their fluffy pajamas with cups of cocoa.

“Hi Mommy,” Finn whispers, blinking an eye open to wave at her.

She grins, dropping down to scoop them up and hold them close to her. They snuggle in, wrapping their short arms around her neck.

Finn was her world, but was the possibility of losing this job, her only means of providing for them, worth it to keep other people safe? She’d always wanted to use her strength and intellect, her quick thinking and powers of perception, to help people. It was why she originally got into police work, though in the years since she’s realized just how far *that* corruption ran as well, and didn’t want anything more to do with it until she’d had no choice but to take this job. But could those same powers get her into unimaginable trouble?

Sometimes she wished she could just mind her own business and fly under the radar, but she could tell that something about this just wasn’t right.

“Mommy, can me and Bow and Glimmer go to the beach tomorrow?” Finn asks.

She freezes, and looks at her two friends over her child’s shoulder.

The mayor was conniving and skeevy, and Adora didn't trust her word for a second. She was inclined to believe the medical examiner, if she hadn’t seemed so sure at first and if Adora hadn’t seen the wounds herself. Obviously, a further autopsy could uncover something, but not in less than a day and not something that the mayor could find to be so smug about.

But with her kid? She didn't trust a single other soul on this planet, with the exception of Glimmer and Bow, to protect them.

"The beach is going to be really busy, and I know Bow doesn't like it when there's too many people. How about you hang out in the pond instead?" She asks. They pull back to look at her and smile.

"Ok mommy," They yawn, laying their head back on her shoulder.

Bow raises his eyebrow, but doesn't say anything. It wasn't often, was nearly unheard of, for Adora to lie to Finn about anything. Sure, she'd scoot the edges of the truth, because they were still just a kid, but she stayed as close as she could to telling them the real answer to all of the questions they asked.

He had heard the gossip in town today, the reopening of the beaches and the speculation about why they were closed in the first place. It was clear that, whatever happened at work today, Adora wasn't anywhere near believing that it was safe to be in the ocean.

***

The full moon rose high that night, tugging the tides at it's leisure. The calmness of the ocean, a sheet of glass reflecting back at it in a glittering tapestry of deep blue and inky black, was disrupted by a single vessel bobbing its way through the waves. The steady rhythm makes it's two passengers yawn.

"What did we have to come out in the middle of the night for?" The younger man complains, a sleepy slur in his voice.

"Striped bass, kiddo," His graying comrade answers, a little too jovial.

"Can't we fish for striped bass… during the day?"

The old man snorts, taking a drag from his cigarette and a swig of… *whatever* he kept in that ancient flask. He wheezes a cough and wipes his mouth on the frayed collar of his flannel.

“More active at night. Besides, if we catch 'em all tonight, you can have the day off tomorrow.”

That catches the young man’s attention, and he’s slightly more on board with the whole idea now that it means a weekend day off.

“Now, help me with the-” He’s interrupted by a jolting impact, rocking the boat.

They both stumble, standing up alert.

“What was that?” The younger man asks.

He ducks his head below deck and see’s a small indentation to the hull, where they must have struck something. The old wood planks hold firm, but they seep water at a few splintered cracks.

“Hull is ok for now, but we should head in to look at it. We’re not taking on water yet, but I don’t want to wait around until we do.”

Another impact, from the back this time, rocks the boat again.

Their eyes meet.

“If we hit something, what are the odds *it* would come back for *us*?” The young man whispers.

The more experienced of the two fishermen shudders, worry plastered on his face. He leans over the side of the boat, staring into the water as though he hopes an answer will emerge from the depths.

It’s silent and calm, long enough that the two look at each other and let out shaky breaths, and then a second longer.

Back on shore, in a house by the beach, Finn walks to the living room to retrieve the stuffed bear they’d left on the couch. They see the blinking red navigation light of a boat out on the ocean and stand by the window holding the bear tightly.

They rock back and forth on their heels, blinking sleepily.

In a blur, the light streaks down, plunging below the surface of the water. They watch for a moment, waiting to see if it would come back up.

When it doesn’t, they turn around, taking their bear and walking down the hall. Maybe they'd sleep in Mommy's room tonight.

An Unexpected Friendship

Adora can feel the sweat dripping down her back, seeping through her white undershirt and darkening the beige of her uniform top. She takes her hat off to fan her face, and while the coolness certainly helps, the sudden exposure to the sun makes her wince. It was a real scorcher today, sun glaring down and reflecting off of the sand right back up at her.

She leans on the side of the lifeguard chair, trying not to get sand in her shoes as she keeps an eye on all of the beachgoers.

Over the last week there had been numerous disappearances, not so isolated incidents of swimmers and small craft fishermen never returning to shore. They were a few miles away and in vastly different types of water, so no one besides Adora and her hunch were able to determine that it was the same problem. A capsized boat could be caused by anything, taking on water wasn't exclusive to being rammed by a shark, but the distinct scraping tooth marks on the part of the hull that had washed ashore made her think it wasn't simply a case of a boat running aground. The wounds on the remains, though there were few, was enough to convince Adora.

It was a terrifying reality that, still, the mayor ignored. The threat to the town's income was enough to motivate the woman to keep a watchful eye on Adora and her ever growing desire to shut the beaches down.

"You yell 'shark,' well then we have a panic on our hands on the Fourth of July," She'd say.

"Salineas is a summer town, and we need those summer dollars," She'd insist.

Still, they remained open, and only got busier and busier as the days passed. Ferry after ferry ushered more tourists onto the island and soon every spare room, guest house, inn, motel, and

the RV park would be filled with the excitement of summer tourists.

So here she stands, keeping an eye on the beach. She would stand by the lifeguard chair, surveying those on land and maybe paying a little more attention to those in the water. Then she would take a walk down to the inlet and back. Any longer than that, any indication that she was paying more attention to the beach than the rest of the town, and the mayor would be all over her with a lecture about the importance of keeping the town safe, and minding her duties.

That was the most frustrating part, knowing that something was wrong, knowing that the mayor knew it too, and being forbidden from doing anything about it.

She hadn't sent any pictures, but Dr. Hooper had responded with all of the information Adora needed to identify a bite mark.

And that is exactly what she did.

The frequency with which she called the young marine biologist probably wasn't necessary, but she so enjoyed listening to that deep, smooth voice talk about her work, her passion. It was a breath of fresh air, to talk to someone so excited about their work. Adora was content to ignore the fact that Bow, a fashion designer, and Glimmer, a physicist, were both extremely passionate about their work, so the delight in speaking to Dr. Hooper was clearly a little deeper than that.

Maybe it was silly to get attached to a voice, to the hand picked information that made up her idea of the woman, but nevertheless she found herself attracted to that squeaky sneeze and gravely chuckle.

Adora blinks, coming back to the present, the reason she's really here, and continues her patrol.

Her eyes are trained on a family, a child toddling through the surf with their hands engulfed in their mothers. It reminds her of Finn,

when they were still in diapers and she'd taken them to the beach for the first time. She'd put sunscreen on them and a cute little bucket hat. It's haunting, to see the same thing but know that something could go so wrong.

Still, she reminisces of the times when things were simpler, before she grew to hate her work and decided to start working toward her degree. Finn had lit up her entire world in a way she didn't know she needed in a time of her life where she genuinely didn't know if she was doing the right thing or not.

The moment is shattered when she hears a scream, the scream she'd been waiting for, the scream she'd been afraid of.

She stands up straighter, stepping forward a few feet and trying to pinpoint the source. There wasn't any frantic movement, no thrashing and flailing, but someone could disappear under the water in the blink of an eye. Still she doesn't see seafoam, or red tinted water, and finds her heart rate increasing frantically as she puts her hand on her gun.

Can you even shoot a shark? She thinks, though she'd probably try if she got close enough and there weren't any citizens in the way.

Another scream draws her eye a hundred or so feet south, where she sees someone waving their arms, emerging from the water.

They're on the shoulders of another person, their partner maybe, and the scream turns to squealing laughter as the two fall over sideways back into the water.

She relinquishes her hold on her sidearm and rubs her face, a tear of relief and frustration stuck in the corner of her eye.

Relief because she didn't have to see someone disappear below the waves in a pool of crimson and haunting screams. It was one more minute that she got to go without seeing someone die. It was one more person whose family didn't have to mourn.

Frustration because of the powerlessness she felt, the harsh truth that if it were a shark, her, Weaver, Dr. Norton, and Dr. Hooper hundreds of miles away, would be the only four who knew. She was frustrated because this creature in the depths, lurking, had such a hold on her that she couldn't sleep at night and couldn't focus during the day.

She was scared, confused, and distracted, and she couldn't be any of those things if she was going to protect anyone.

Adora adjusts her hat on top of her head and turns to walk up the beach, nodding politely and sharing friendly smiles with a few people she recognizes. Some kids run in front of her, kicking up sand as they toss a frisbee back and forth, and she pauses to let them pass.

They call her 'ma'am' and 'miss' in their light voices through laughter as they stumble past and it makes her smile a real, genuine smile at their youthful joy. She even manages to hold on to that smile until she gets to her jeep, where it drops off of her face.

"Mayor Weaver," She greets with a nod when she sees her standing, leaning against the door to her car.

She's wearing a black suit today, a large hat covering her pale face. She takes a long drag from her cigarette and blows it out, tapping the ash off of it so it falls mostly on the ground. But still, a tiny bit ends up in Adora's car.

Adora has to hide her tight fists in her trouser pockets and bite her lip not to say anything.

"Adora," She greets back, voice as cold and threatening as ever.

They stare at each other for a moment, a chilling moment where all Adora sees is the lifeless, careless glint in her eye and tries not to reveal how disgusted the mere sight of the woman makes her. She'd been in this position for months, and couldn't really believe that the person who hired her, the person who was responsible for

the town's livelihood, could be so manipulative and scheming. Maybe she should have seen it coming, or paid more attention, but how many of their past interactions were false praise, lying through her teeth? Adore would never know, but she'd certainly spend the rest of her time here wondering where *this* Weaver had been hiding during her interviews and their first few interactions.

"You've been spending an awful lot of time down by the beach lately," She says.

Once again, it isn't a question, but Adora feels herself itching to explain herself.

"Heat stroke and drowning are hard to catch with this many people, so since it's getting to the hottest part of the day I thought I'd come take a walk around and see how everyone is holding up. I'm scanning channels-" She gestures to the radio at her hip, the cord wrapping up her back and strapped to the loop in the shoulder of her shirt, "-so I can hear if a lifeguard calls for help, and I can call for an ambulance faster than anyone can dial 911."

"I see."

Weaver stares at her for a long moment, sizing her up, trying to see something in her eyes or her false smile. Whatever she's looking for, whatever sparks her suspicion, she must not find yet.

But she's determined to catch Adora doing something wrong, however minute that might be.

"And where were you headed next?" She asks. She tries to sound casual, like she's merely keeping up conversation instead of interrogating. Months ago, that would have worked on Adora. Now, she was starting to see her better.

"Well, I finished my paperwork in the office, and I haven't gotten a call, so I'd say it's time to head through town, maybe check out the inlet on the way, just to make sure we're covered. I have my officers on patrol routes through town. So far there have only

been issues with a few cars deboarding the ferry, but they were diffused quickly. Other than that, things seem to be going smoothly."

"Yes, yes, make sure there isn't any trouble," Weaver says.

Adora hates that word, because to Weaver, 'trouble' meant anyone disrupting the delicate balance keeping her town profitable. 'Trouble' meant those who pushed the boundaries of what Weaver thought was acceptable.

It was her way of saying, in a way, that Adora herself was also on the edge of being 'trouble.'

"Don't worry, you'd really have to go *fishing* for it to find trouble around here."

Weaver narrows her eyes.

She looks like she's about to say more, but a shriek interrupts her.

Something in Adora knows, though.

This one is different.

This one is *real*

Adora spins on her heel, throwing herself toward the beach and running faster than she thinks she's ever run. Sand is kicking up behind her, spraying over towels and people as she snakes through toward the water. The closer she gets, the more fearful screams she hears, the more terrified swimmers she passes running away from the water.

Lifeguards are standing up in their wooden towers, shouting 'shark' at the tops of their lungs between blows of their whistles.

Parents search through the stampeding crowd for their children, grabbing them by the hand or picking them up when they find

them, and she again thinks that if Finn were here she'd kill to get them out of the water.

"Chief Brody to dispatch. I need an ambulance down to the beach, lifeguard station 13. No code yet, expecting injuries," She shouts into her radio, putting her arm on an elderly man's elbow to help stabilize him as he shuffles out of the way. She assists him in getting a few extra feet to his wife and he sits down, thanking her as she turns back.

She moves slower as the crowd by the water gets thicker, taking in those passing her to check for signs of injury as she goes. There are a few crying kids covered in sand, red marks where the abrasivness irritated their skin, but she doesn't see blood.

By the time she gets to the water, it's almost quiet. It's an eerie silence, a few whispers back and forth. Parents are holding their children tight, hugging them as close as they can.

She thinks of the fear she'd feel if someone shouted 'shark' when she was even a foot away from her child.

Still, she focuses on her duty, her job, her responsibility to this town and it's people. The innocent lives that didn't know what she knew, that weren't allowed to know what she does.

When she gets to the water's edge, there are a few people standing in a semicircle. They're huddled together, and she has to place her hands gently on shoulders to get them to part so she can weave her way through the crowd.

Chief Adora Brody had seen a lot in her time as an officer, accidents that left nothing to the imagination, wounds that she wouldn't ever expect to be found on a person who was still breathing. All of those things paled in comparison to the way she felt when she stepped through the crowd and was about to see the victim of a shark attack.

She thought there would be a person, in pain and in need of transport to the hospital. She thought she'd see someone crying

for help, maybe they were asking why they couldn't feel their leg. Maybe they would look at her and beg her for help. Maybe they'd be gone already, and there'd be a body waiting for transport to the morgue.

But that's not what she sees at all.

What she sees is, somehow, infinitely worse.

No, just as she steps through the last line of people, a piercing shriek, of grief and disbelief hits her eardrums.

All that lies there in the sand is a deflated inner tube.

And a tiny, little, sandal.

***

Catra flicks the light on in the entryway to her house. The narrow hall was just big enough to set her bag on the hook and kick her shoes off. Her socks make contact with the cool tile floor as she steps toward her kitchen.

The hours of research were exhausting and unending, though she loved every word she read, every new piece of information connecting the dots together. It was the act of using her brain, of sitting hunched over a computer, that made her more tired than any of the scuba sessions she'd been on, any sailboat she'd had to navigate in a storm.

In the last week, though, she'd been interrupted by her most unlikely source of entertainment. After she'd called Chief Brody about her inquiry they'd spoken several times over the phone.

It started with questions, "how do I identify a shark bite?" "how do I measure bite radius?"

She, in turn, would ask questions like "does the wound look torn?" "are there abrasions?"

She'd take the information Adora had (along with a certain margin of error she'd expect from someone who had never measured bite radius before) and estimate the size and species of the animal in question. She could already tell that Adora was a massive dork, because anyone else would have just stolen the damn pictures and sent them in. But in a way it was like solving a puzzle, together with someone hundreds of miles away whose voice was smooth like butter and flowed over her lips.

The thought of that voice tinted Catra's cheeks pink and she shakes her head.

Today, though, she was left to her thoughts and research, without a single interruption.

Just as she's pouring herself a glass of wine and putting some leftover pizza in the microwave, her cell rings in her pocket and she jumps to see who it is.

"Chief Brody, I was beginning to worry. You haven't called me yet today," She jokes into the receiver.

The speaker is silent, and she furrows her brow.

Adora hadn't been left speechless yet.

She hears a throat clearing on the other end and waits.

"There was an attack today. A bad one," She whispers. Her voice sounds unlike anything Catra's ever heard, broken and scared.

"Oh shit, um, are you ok? How about Finn?" She asks, setting her glass down and leaning against the counter.

"Finn was at home. I was on duty and I was there but I didn't … I didn't *see* it."

The line goes quiet again.

She doesn’t really know what to say, because her and Adora were on the same side, and they were right. They were right, and because that shitty mayor didn’t believe it, innocent people were dying without an end in sight.

“How are you doing? This must be a lot. Was it isolated, or were there witnesses?” She asks.

Adora’s chuckle doesn’t make her feel better.

“Oh only about… Let's see… The entire population of town and tourists from across the country congregated on the beach during the hottest time of day, the busiest day of the year? So yeah, a few witnesses.”

Catra winces.

“Fuck, that sounds terrible. How was crowd control? I can only imagine the panic. Was anyone else hurt?”

“Minor sprains, some bruises, but nothing too bad. Not as bad as it could have been.”

Then there’s silence again, and Catra worries more than she thinks she ever has about someone who, in retrospect, is a complete stranger.

“Hey, talk to me. What's up?” She coaxes gently.

Adora sniffs on the other end of the line, and Catra hears shuffling and footsteps, followed by a door closing. She must have walked outside for some privacy.

“It was a kid. Just a little kid. They couldn’t have been older than Finn and I just couldn’t stop thinking about how many times I’ve gone to the beach with them, how today could have just been another day and then in a nanosecond they’d be *gone*,” She chokes out.

Catra can practically hear the tears falling down Adora's face, and wishes more than anything she could help.

"It wasn't Finn. You just have to keep remembering that they were safe, and that this was a terrible accident, but there isn't anything you could have done."

"I could have closed the beaches anyway, I could have told the coast guard, anything! I could have told Weaver to fuck off and not interfere with my investigation!" She shouts.

"Adora, I know it seems like that, but Weaver would have fired you and moved on with the summer without you. You've never dealt with something like this before, and you're doing what you can under the circumstances."

Catra pulls her pizza out of the microwave and sandwiches the phone between her shoulder and ear so she can grab her glass of wine. She weaves between her dining room set and the wall, turning the corner into her living room.

She plops down on the worn leather armchair in the corner. Her laptop is already on the side table, and she lifts the screen, pulling her glasses back on. She takes a bite and sets the plate down to take the computer into her lap and begins typing.

"I just… I'm the only one who knows, Catra. I'm the only one who can fix this."

The words strike a nerve, because from where she's standing, that's complete nonsense.

"Adora, you don't have to *fix* what *Weaver* fucked up. You're not the only one in charge here, why can't it be someone else that stops this? Why does it have to be you?"

"Because I feel like I'm the only one who can! I'm the Sheriff, I've dealt with death and violence before. I should be level headed and looking for a way to stop this! You don't know what it's like to stand in front of someone and have to tell them that their child is

dead! And they don’t know now, but once it gets out that I *knew* about the danger and didn’t do anything they’ll never trust me again. Hell, Weaver would probably let it happen and fire me anyway to make herself look better! Then she gets her 'summer dollars,' sympathy votes, and the power to do whatever she wants while she hires and walks all over a new Sheriff,” Adora rants.

And that was true. Catra had never had to look someone in the eye and tell them that their family member was gone, but she’d had it happen to her twice now. While she didn’t care about the police officer or the social worker that told her, she can’t imagine that it had been the highlight of their day either. Weaver was manipulative, and she had no doubts that what Adora was saying is exactly what she would have done. She's not going to share with her hysterical... friend... that she agrees that Weaver was capable of much more than just *ignoring* a problem.

“I’m sorry Adora. I’m sorry you have to deal with that, and I’m sorry that you’re just trying to do your job and help people and that the mayor is fucking you over. I’m sorry you’re being forced to spend every day putting yourself in the shoes of parents and think ‘what ifs’ about Finn. But I’m here if you need me, I’m here and I understand,” She says.

She’s been puttering around on her laptop, looking at prices and casually making plans. The thought had crossed her mind with that first email, and every subsequent phone call. The case was getting more interesting, that was certain, but she couldn’t deny that there was just something about the phone calls and the voice on the other end, her silly jokes and the fascinating way her brain worked through problems, that had her more enraptured than she’d care to admit.

“I appreciate that, Catra. You… Fuck, you don’t know how good it is to hear someone say that they *know* I’m doing what I can. Because it feels like I’m never doing enough,” Adora speaks softly. She’s calmer now, feeling the breeze wash over her skin while she listens to Bow and Glimmer help Finn bake a batch of cookies through the open window in the kitchen.

“I know we don’t know each other, but I kind of wish you were here, so there was someone else with me that had a shred of a conscience to deal with this situation.”

“What, Boy and Glitter aren’t strapping on their goggles and shimmying into wetsuits to help you catch this shark?” She jests.

It earns a snort, and she grins at the sign of Adora's improved mood.

"Damn, it feels good to make her laugh," She thinks.

“No, not particularly. They’re very supportive, but I think with this they'd be much more ‘you can do it!’ from the sidelines kind of people. I’ve never had to doubt if they love me or Finn though, so that’s all I need from them,” She says.

Catra bites her lip, thinking hard about what she’d say next. Things between them had been strictly professional for the first couple of calls, but their personal lives started to slip in every once in a while and then suddenly here they were, pretty much on a phone call about Adora’s bad day at work and her kid.

“That’s all you need from them? So what do you need that you don’t get from them?” She asks.

Adora sighs heavily into the receiver, and Catra would be annoyed if it were anyone else. But it feels kind of nice to just sit here and hear Adora breathe.

“You know, I know exactly what I need out of a relationship, but I just don’t know how to find someone. I’m really busy with Finn and finishing my degree but if I met someone… God I wish I could just meet someone,” She sighs wistfully.

Finding love, finding someone to share her life with, was a dream she’d put on the back burner for some time now.

“You’re finished this fall though, right? Home stretch?” Catra says.

Catra's own college journey was hard work, from getting in with scholarships and having her graduate research fully funded with a stipend. There had been times that she worried the grants would run out and she'd have to put her dream aside, but she'd been able to accomplish all of her academic goals. She can't imagine how hard it must be to work full time, have a kid, and have the normal level of exhaustion that being in one's late twenties brought on top of trying to complete a bachelor's degree. She had a lot of admiration for Adora for that.

"Home stretch, and then I can… try to get a better job and try to get out of this town. It's funny that we just moved here but I am itching to leave. Bow and Glimmer both work remotely, so it's not like they need to stay. They literally only moved for me, even though I told them they didn't have to."

"They sound like amazing friends. And that kid of yours sounds pretty cute too," Catra says. She leans over to take another bite of her pizza that had gone cold again. How talking to Adora stole hours of her time in the blink of an eye was a mystery to her. It was just something in that voice, or maybe something in that brain of hers.

Before Adora can respond Catra hears the sound of a door opening and a child's shout.

"Mommy the cookies are done!"

Adora and Catra share twin laughs, and Adora feels lighter than she has in weeks.

"Well, duty calls," She says, standing and waving Finn inside.

She didn't want to hang up, never really wanted to hang up. She can't think of a single conversation she and Catra had so far that she wouldn't keep up for the rest of her life if it were up to her.

'The rest of my life, huh? I can already feel that this woman is going to wreck me,' She thinks.

“Sure thing Chief, eat an extra for me and tell Finn to save some for your day off tomorrow.”

“Will do, m’lady. I hear the gears turning, don’t stay up too late. You can’t do science tomorrow if you do science all night and forget to rest.”

Catra throws her head back, laughing, and can hear much the same from the other end of the line.

Neither hangs up, just listening. Catra listens to the breeze coming off of the ocean, salty, misty air. She hears trees rustling and, while she knows Salineas Island is too far north, she likes to imagine that there are palm trees and that the beach smells like coconut water.

Adora hears the sniffle of Catra’s deviated septum, the spritzing sound of her automatic air freshener.

For a strange moment, unlike any they’d shared yet, they’re holding on to each other as tightly as they can from so far away.

Finn knocking on the window and waving jolts Adora from her momentary trance and she’s sighing again.

“I really gotta go. Thanks for… talking me down earlier. And for being here,” She says.

Catra smiles to herself, willing Adora to feel it's warmth and fondness.

“No problem. I’m always here if you need to talk.”

Catra sits in silence, staring down at her computer screen and sipping on her wine while she tries to think through this logically.

It would be ridiculous to just leave everything she was doing behind to go chase some fantasy shark.

It would be ludicrous to do it under the excuse of science when in reality, she really wanted to meet this woman.

But if the shark was as big as she suspected, she'd be at the forefront of discovery, the largest great white shark on record.

And, as a strictly secondary goal, she'd get to meet Adora.

So she hits 'book' for the flight, and she hits 'book' for the hotel, and she closes her laptop with a shudder of excitement going up her spine as she grins down into her glass.

She'd know soon, one way or another, if there was anything for her on Salineas Island.

Is there a Dr in the house?

Chapter Notes

Ok, CW for this chapter

I've been leading up to Adora not liking her job, the gist of it is political and if that's not your thing and you don't want to read it, or if you just want to be prepared for it, I put "@@@" at the line where it starts and again at the line where it ends. So you don't have to skip the whole scene if you want the other parts

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora has never seen a pier this crowded, and as she moves forward on to the rickety wooden planks and weaves between fishermen, she begins to regret stepping onto it at all. It’s packed, far beyond what she’d think it should be, but as the only dock at the port that wasn’t reserved for the ferry, she has to at least thank her lucky stars that the same scene isn’t unfolding all over the island.

Kyle follows her, nearly getting knocked out by a stray fishing rod as someone hoists their pack over their shoulder and hops on board their tiny sailboat.

The whole thing reeks of poor planning and unrealistic ideas, and Adora is pretty terrified at the number of vessels she sees that couldn’t even remotely be for fishing. Sure, the odd boat slip contained a ship that was fitted with trolling lines and a reel that looked strong enough, but the majority were small craft that were, from her and Dr. Hooper’s rough calculations, probably smaller than the shark they were hunting.

None of it was a good idea, and as she looked around at the frenzy of people cramming into boats over capacity and tossing fishing gear between them, she wondered which would even return to port.

She rushes past someone, bumping shoulders, and turns her head to say "Pardon me!" as she rushes to the end of the dock.

"Hey, you have enough life jackets for everyone on board?" She asks.

The man waves his hand dismissively and says, "Yeah sure, I got 'em."

"Great. Soon as you show me a lifejacket on every one of you, you're free to leave the dock," She responds.

The chorus of 'Oh come on!" and "Really?!" she heard, exasperated groans from everyone on board the tiny vessel, is a true testament to one's ability to look danger in the face and tell it to 'fuck off.' She hears an engine backfire and whips around, turning in time to see a cloud of smoke billowing out of the hatch of another boat, a cabin cruiser this time.

She starts moving toward it, calling over her radio, "Kyle run to the shed and grab a fire extinguisher will you? See if those guys in the Sea Ray need help."

It's utter chaos, with so many people out to get their chance at the bounty. Mrs. Frederick, the victim's mother, had put out a bounty for anyone who was willing to catch the shark, and in the two days after the attack on the beach it reached by word of mouth and eventually newspaper to every coastal town in 200 miles. Now, three days later, the town was packed with anyone willing to stake their claim on the money and bring themselves a name of fame and fortune.

That meant, unfortunately, that word was spreading fast and relentlessly. It was also doing very little to deter patrons.

During the press conference the day after the attack, Adora had said firmly that they were going to close the beaches, when asked. The uproar that followed was clear, that the decision wasn't popular. Weaver made sure to tell everyone that the closure would only be 24 hours, and then they were back open

without a care in the world for whether the fish was still on the hunt.

Adora had been about to propose that they pay someone to catch it, but the child's mother had already put out the bounty.

Clearly, she should have gone ahead with her proposal anyway.

"Shark Attack on Salineas Island" was written on the front page, a true nightmare if she'd ever had one. And the number of people that she feared were about to sail to their deaths was growing rapidly.

Adora hears a shouting match between sailors on two smaller sailboats, one blocking the other in by the dock, and rubs her hand over her face. She sighs when one of them stands, voice growing louder, followed by the other. The boats are rocking back and forth, splashing against each other and the dock as the debate gets more and more heated, and Adora rolls her shoulders and exhales before stepping forward to deal with it.

She presses on, squeezing through the narrow path between a group of people.

"Excuse me," reaches her ears, and she knows it's got to be that same stranger she'd brushed past before.

She turns around to look, and is not prepared for what she sees.

She's wearing a pair of jeans, cuffed at the bottom to reveal her ankles and the beat up white sneakers on her feet. Her shirt, a fraying grey sweater, is covered by a denim jacket that is similar in color, equally worn. It's certain that they're well loved articles of clothing, the patches at the elbows and the faded creasing indicate years of use. On top of her head is a beanie, resting just above her ears, and the tight curls of her short hair poke out above her forehead. Her sunglasses, wayfarers in style, have slid down the bridge of her nose just enough for her eyes, one hazel and the other a striking cerulean, to peer up at Adora.

She's silent, staring for a moment. There's no sound, nothing but the two of them standing on the dock, and she's all at once relieved and anxious that her eyes have fallen upon the most beautiful sight she's seen all day.

"Fuck, stop staring, you're such a disaster."

"Hey, I'm sorry I have to- I just- can you tell those guys they're overloading that boat? Thanks!" She points to another dingy at the end of the dock, this one with nothing more than an outboard engine. No steering wheel, simply a joystick and a throttle at the aft. It was sinking well below it's water line with the four passengers already aboard. With the two others that were still passing supplies to those on board, it wasn't looking like it was making it very far with what their plans were.

It buys Adora time to deal with the other conflicts around her, at the same time trying to get her head together after the shock of someone who looked like *that* showing up right in front of her in a place like *this*.

Catra steps up to the edge of the dock, leaning slightly forward. She wraps one arm around the piling, fingers scraping the worn, splintered wood, and cups her other hand around her mouth.

"Excuse me gentlemen, the Officer asked me to inform you that you're overloading that boat," She shouts, figuring she might as well give the 'nice' approach a try since she stepped off of her own boat seconds ago.

"Can't give this town too much shit yet. Haven't even spoken to anyone. Though judging by the look of these boats and the amount of dynamite I see, none of these people look like they're the 'bright ideas' types anyway." She thinks.

She isn't surprised, smirking and nodding along, when they wave her off and moan their complaints.

"Well, could you tell me if there's a good restaurant or hotel on the island?" She asks.

"Yeah, walk straight ahead!" One of them shouts, followed by a round of boisterous laughter from the rest.

She nods and laughs along, turning around and whispering to herself, "Hah, well none of them are making it out of the harbor alive."

She'd just gotten here, and after the plane flight and the boat rental, it was a miracle she was still standing. Her last week of work went by fast, between making arrangements with the department for time off and securing the right equipment. It was a short ride from the mainland, but the cooler northern water and rough waves sprayed her relentlessly, and her entire right side was damp. Checking into her hotel and resting was at the top of her list, but when she stepped on the dock and saw the commotion and the single officer trying to handle the rowdy excited crowd, she figured it was her best bet to see if said officer knew where to find Chief Brody.

She didn't get a look at her nametag, but she could tell by her voice that she'd found who she was looking for.

Catra's eyes search the commotion, trying to spot her friend in the frenzy of half-assed fishermen.

"I have a feeling these dipshits are going to get on my last nerve, but maybe they'll give up when they realize they can't actually catch the shark on their ten foot party rafts." She thinks.

Still, she's certain that all of this will be worth it, because she was already giddy with an excitement she wouldn't dare let show on her face.

If Adora's measurements were anywhere close, then her calculations estimated this shark larger than any on record, and she was going to be here to record it. Her name would be in textbooks, show up in searches, and she'd finally have done something that was worth remembering her by.

But the shark wasn't the only reason she was thrilled to be here.

Her and Adora had connected, really connected in their conversations over the phone. She had friends, those she'd consider good friends in fact, that didn't know what she'd told Adora on their late night phone calls while Adora was up working on school work and Catra was too engrossed in her research to attempt to sleep.

Keeping her arrival a secret over the week wasn't too difficult a task, considering the fact that Adora herself was getting busier. Their phone calls no longer contained the conspiracy of 'if' there was a shark and 'if' people found out, so they didn't usually go back to their more professional discussions.

She wondered through it all if Adora was as attracted to the mysterious, technical stranger, on the other end of the phone as she was. She wondered if Adora was intrigued by her, mesmerized by her voice, taken by her laugh, and already in love with her intellect like she so hopelessly was for Adora.

If nothing else, she didn't have to wonder if Adora would be physically attracted to her, if her staring right there on the dock was anything to go by.

What brought her here, to this island, was *more*. More of Adora, more adventure. Whether adventure meant being on a boat in the middle of the ocean searching for a shark, or right here getting to know what it was like to be the person Adora wanted to come home to.

Catra knew she shouldn't get ahead of herself, because they hadn't even met yet, but it was just so easy to picture the 'what ifs' when it came to Adora.

She reaches the officer, shoulders tight, and can tell that, while she'd been observing from the sidelines for a few minutes, there wasn't anything going through her head but stress.

"Hey there, know where I can find Chief Brody?" She says, stepping up to plant herself right in Adora's line of sight, with a

smirk on her face and an eyebrow quirked.

“Chief- yeah that’s me. What can I do for you?” She asks, standing up a little straighter.

Catra’s grin widens, and she looks her up and down. She’s tall, taller than her but not terribly so, and her uniform shirt hugs her biceps. Something about a woman with a radio, strapped to her shoulder no less, just looked so *official* and *dorky* at the same time. It was endearing, and her smile softens a little at the strands of blonde hair that fall from the brim of the hat and land around her ears. Her hair is short, long enough to *grasp* onto but short enough that it didn’t even touch the back of her neck, and her bangs sweep to the side to frame her face.

She’s *cute* and *sexy* at the same time, and while Catra knew that she had to be at least a little bit of those things if she was going to sound so hot over the phone, she’s still letting herself stare… respectfully.

“Uh miss?” Adora asks, reaching up to take her hat off and run the other hand through her hair.

“Huh,” Catra says simply.

Might as well play around with her a little bit.

“Huh?” Adora echoes back, confused.

“I know I’m pretty short, but for some reason, you didn’t *sound* taller than me on the phone,” She says casually.

Adora’s eyes light up in recognition and she steps forward.

“Catra?” She asks.

“Yeah dork, it’s good to see you,” She responds.

Adora opens her arms, looking bashfully at her through hooded eyes.

Catra rolls her eyes and steps forward into the hug.

“Alright dummy, you having a good time out here?” She jokes, trying not to give away that she, too, felt like a disaster around this woman.

Adora snorts.

“Well you know, just a bunch of people clamoring for their joint death wish. Breaking maritime laws and putting themselves in danger. What else is new?”

It’s weird, meeting someone in person that they’d been spending so much time speaking to.

Adora leans down, resting her nose on the scratchy knit hat covering Catra’s hair, hands gripping the rough denim of her jacket, and can still feel her warmth through the slightly damp layers.

Catra buries her face in Adora’s neck, a more intimate gesture than one would go for during a first hug.

But they *know* each other, is the weirdest part.

Adora feels like she’s wrapped her arms around Catra a thousand times by now, and Catra feels like she’s been cocooned in the radiating heat of Adora already.

All too soon Catra feels Adora sigh beneath her, deep in her chest.

“I think I caught everyone openly smuggling dynamite and overloading their boats. I don’t think there’s anything else I can do except crowd control and try to direct boat traffic so there isn’t any incident while they’re all at the dock,” Adora says.

Catra nods against her chest, “Yeah, there really isn’t anything you can do beyond making sure everything at the dock is safe. Once they’re out of the harbor and on the ocean it’s the Coast Guard’s problem, and they’ll just have to radio for help.”

Adora pulls back, but keeps her hands on Catra's hips for just a moment longer, and starts making her way to the end to wave on the traffic and try to diffuse any more situations. Once the last boat leaves the dock, the rowdy crews of each vessel shouting and laughing in excitement and possibility, she turns around to walk back to Catra.

She finds her breath catching in her chest again, seeing Catra as she remains smirking in the shade of the dock's shed. Her skin is deep and rich and flawless, with barely there freckles along the bridge of her nose and a warm undertone she just couldn't help wanting to reach out and touch. A longing desire scorches through Adora's chest, seizing her lungs and stinging her lips. Catra's *angelic*. Adora stood staring again, trying to get her bearings from the sight of her, before she finally decided it was time to get herself together enough to approach her.

"Well then, why don't we head somewhere a little more private, and catch up? We have a lot to talk about. Like when you were going to tell me that you were coming? Speaking of, do you have accommodations?"

"Oh princess, trust me you'll know when I'm *coming*. And yeah, one room at the Trusty Seagull."

Adora blushes at the nickname and the inuendo, face turning a furious shade of red until she puts her hat back on and pulls the brim low to hide her face.

"I'll drive you there so you can check in, and we can head to the morgue to see what the *real* cause of death was, then we can grab lunch and talk. But keep that up, and you'll sit in the back," Adora says, turning around to head off of the dock.

Catra follows, cackling behind her, and Adora's smile widens.

She could already get used to it, the banter, the teasing.

It terrifies her that she could already get used to Catra, here with her.

But at the same time? It feels like she always has been.

***

The atmosphere of the morgue is stale to say the least. It's like time stands still, in a place where life doesn't progress, air doesn't move, and the normal hustle and bustle of daily life are so drowned out by concrete walls, echoing off of sheet metal doors, that there isn't a sign that this is even real.

Adora *hates* it here.

Catra doesn't fare much better, but has been through advanced classes with intricate dissections enough to only be bothered minimally by the fact that these are *people* and not *fish*.

"Alright, I'll need to see the remains of all of the victims. The girl that washed up on shore a couple of weeks ago, if you still have them, and then the two from the fishing boat," Catra says to the mortician.

All the while, Dr. Norton stands in the corner with her hands crossed over her chest, and Mayor Weaver sits on one of the rolling chairs by the exam table.

Adora expects the tech to slide out some of the drawers along the sheet metal wall, but they head to the freezer in the corner instead.

There weren't enough remains to justify a drawer for each person, it seemed.

They take out several bins, placing them on the exam table, and Adora moves to the corner opposite Norton to survey the situation from afar.

Catra places a headset on her head, with a microphone pointed to her mouth and her sleeves rolled up.

Adora sees the tattoos on her arm, an anchor with a chain leading upward past the sleeve of her sweater beyond where Adora can see. Still, what she can see is interesting. A juxtaposition of the manmade iron shapes against the delicate intricacies of sea anemones. It's fitting, and Adora finds herself staring even more.

She just wished she could *concentrate* around Catra, even a little bit at this point.

"Probable boating accident," Catra says into her headset's receiver as she reads the file before her.

"The height and weight of the victim can only be estimated from the partial remains. The torso has been severed mid-thorax, there are no major organs remaining."

She takes a sip of the glass of water on the counter top behind her and continues her examination. Her eyes shift over the remains, darting back and forth, looking for something she's trained to see that Adora isn't.

"The right arm has been severed above the elbow with massive tissue loss in the upper musculature. This? Was no boat accident. Did you notify the Coast Guard about this?" Her question is directed to Adora, to avoid suspicion perhaps.

Catra knew that Adora hadn't notified the coast guard. She knew the only thing stopping Adora was Weaver.

But she couldn't let on that she knew that she was aware of all of the things that Weaver was hiding.

"No, I was informed that it was to remain within local jurisdiction," Adora responds.

Weaver narrows her eyes.

Catra pulls the severed arm out of the bin, saying "This, the wound patterns, indicate the non frenzy feeding of a large squalus. The tissue loss and bite radius indicate that the squalus

must be considerably larger than any normal squalus found in these waters."

She slams her headset off and onto the exam table, breathing heavily but measured. She turns to the sink in the corner, pushing back her hair, though it bounced right back forward, and rinses her face in the cool, refreshing water.

"This was not a boat accident. There wasn't a coral reef, or a jetty, or even a propeller that could do this to someone."

Catra stands back up from her bent over position.

She turns, slowly, to Weaver. Anyone in the room who had spent any length of time with her could tell that she *knew* Catra suspected something.

She takes a step forward, and though she addresses the room, Weaver knows that Catra is talking to her.

Catra looks Mayor Weaver in the eye and speaks sharply, voice dark and deadly serious.

"This was a shark."

***

"I'm taking lunch. Call if there's an emergency," Adora says into her radio as she pulls the door closed behind her.

The hotel room is small, with a queen bed on one wall and a console that serves as a TV stand and extends far enough to the side in a makeshift desk. There is a mini fridge to the other side, and a microwave on the shelf directly under the TV. Though the building is old, a colonial style with wrap-around porch and faded white plank siding, the inside has been recently renovated. Where Adora would expect ancient wallpaper and faded paintings, there are grey-white walls and crisp photographs in black and white.

It was nice, but what made her freeze was the sight of Catra taking off her jacket and shoes, and sitting cross-legged on the bed.

Catra rolls her eyes at Adora's sudden inability to speak.

"Well? We gonna eat or what?" She asks.

Adora nods, moving to the desk to place the bag down. She gets out their carry out, Catra's soft crab sandwich and hands it to her along with a few napkins and some ketchup packets for her fries. She takes out her seafood chowder and the dinner roll it comes with, and sits in the one chair provided, turned to face the bed.

"Think I was a little obvious, staring right at her like that?" Catra asks, taking the top piece of bread off of the sandwich to put on the lettuce and tomato that came on the side.

"Maybe, but it was hot, staring her down like that. She looked like she'd been caught, that's for sure. But we should be careful not to let her get too suspicious about it," Adora says, opening a few packets of oyster crackers to crumble over the surface of her chowder. "Regardless, I liked hearing that she was wrong, and you telling her right to her face? I have a feeling she doesn't get told she's so blatantly wrong before."

Catra chews the bite of the sandwich she'd taken, thoughtfully considering that yeah, it might have been suspicious, but something about it felt especially good.

She thinks the added bonus, on top of being *right*, which she *loves*, is the sexy smug look on Adora's face when Catra turned to leave. She'd been so dejected, shifting her eyes away and letting Weaver have the room and control the conversation to avoid confrontation, and it was worth whatever future problems it brought her for Catra to see what it looked like when confident Adora came out and was told that her hunch, her intuition, had been right all along.

Which was all a long winded way of saying that Adora had an obvious praise kink, and being told she was right had really done it for her. And telling Adora she was right, bringing that feeling to her? Well that really did it for Catra too.

"Yeah, we'll be careful not to target her directly again, but come on, it was a little funny to see her look so mad."

Adora throws her head back laughing, glad she'd already swallowed her bite of food.

"Yeah, she doesn't look like that very often. Best to keep her happy until I can get out of her shithole town," Adora mumbles.

@@@

Sure, she'd become a little resentful of the job she didn't like in the town she didn't like, where her decisions held no weight but she took the brunt of the blame. Mrs. Frederick *slapped* her for letting people go swimming when she knew there was danger. Weaver just stood there smirking, apologizing loudly right there on the dock for Adora's misstep.

It still surprises Catra to hear her talk so negatively. She was usually a little better at looking on the bright side.

She puts her sandwich down and wipes her hands off with a napkin, standing to make her way over and place her hand on Adora's shoulder.

"Hey, you're almost done with your degree, and you have way better opportunities waiting for you. I mean, forensics has to be an in demand field, or whatever you're majoring in. You could get a job anywhere. There are towns with law enforcement, well, everywhere," She says.

It's meant to be encouraging, Adora knows that, but she can't lift her scowl. If anything it deepens.

"Computer science, actually."

Catra tilts her head.

“Are you going into like… computer forensics? Or department of defense stuff?”

“No I um… Web development actually. I have a pretty good portfolio from projects I have worked on myself, even a little bit of a freelance background over the last couple of years between the weird hours of the bodyguard stuff. I have at least one professor that knows of a job opening for entry level programmers once I get my degree and qualify.”

She sounds excited, cracking a smile. It makes Catra smile back, that Adora was excited like this about her classes and her future, a far cry from the last few minutes.

Adora clears her throat again and rubs the back of her neck, “I don’t um… I didn’t really *want* to be a police officer.”

Catra gets back up, moving to sit on the edge of the bed so they’re only a few feet apart. She’d had questions, but wasn’t sure how someone could become the chief of police of a town when they didn’t like their work.

“Why are you then? If you didn’t want to, why are you?” She asks.

Adora sighs, scowl returning.

“Teachers, school counselors, everyone said I’d be ‘good at it.’ I thought they were telling me I worked well under pressure, that I was strong and had a good head on my shoulders, that I could make decisions fast and I was someone trustworthy. But those aren't reasons they said it. They just… I guess they didn't think it was worth it to help me get into college, and they saw my people skills and muscles and decided that it was my best bet. I had good grades, but when no one believes in you, that doesn’t really matter,” Adora whispers.

“I just wish… a job where you have to be *ok* with *dying* and *ok* with *killing* wasn’t the default for kids who couldn’t afford school. I was an emancipated minor without a family to tell me that I should consider all of my options, that I even *had* options. Now I'm over a decade behind trying to start a brand new career. But I still need to play nice with Weaver to get the permanent job here so I have income through the fall."

Catra knows, god does she know, what it feels like to be alone in the world. All of those decisions she shouldn't have had to make alone, the ones where she chose wrong and it all miraculously turned out ok. And she can’t believe that with all of the ways that they’ve clicked already, that she can add having been an emancipated minor to the list of ways they understand each other. It pulls at her heart, the thought of a young Adora, bright eyed and ready to take on the world making sacrifices for everyone because she didn't know she was allowed to want anything for herself.

"It's such bullshit. What you wanted should have mattered to them," Catra says.

Adora takes a breath, tense and stressed, and knows that this has already gone way beyond what their casual lunch conversation should have been. Hell, she needed to get back to work soon anyway. But things had gone so far already, and she figures it’s worth mentioning the other thing she hated about being a police officer.

She exhales, blowing a long breath out of her mouth, and says, “Not to mention that… I don’t want to be a part of *this*, an unreformable and corrupt system that doesn’t really aim to protect. It aims to punish. It's built on oppression. And I don’t want to make *money* walking around all day looking for things that I deem ‘trouble’ with the sole purpose of handing out fines people can’t pay and making arrests that ruin people’s lives.”

Catra would be lying if she said she wasn’t hesitant to be as friendly as they had been over the phone with a cop, but she’d

gotten to know Adora and had been willing to give her the benefit of the doubt, mostly because the only problem she'd talked about on this island was the shark.

@@@

"Adora, you're working so hard to do right by Finn, to do right by yourself and to change the way you think. You're being so hard on yourself because you care and because you really think you can do better, and I think that is very admirable of you," Catra says.

"Thank you, Catra. That... It really means a lot. I just got so used to the world on my shoulders that I didn't mind when more people piled it on, and I ended up scared and angry in a vacation town during the worst string of shark attacks it's ever seen. So between the attacks and Weaver letting me do nothing, it doesn't feel like I'm doing right by anyone," Adora says.

"Someday soon you get to walk up to Weaver and tell her to take her blood money, her bad dye job, and her brittle old bones and shove them up her ass because she can't make you do shit anymore. And then it will get out that she was the one that stopped you, she was the reason those people died, and all of her manipulation is going to come back to bite her." Catra says.

Adora sniffs, wiping at her eye, a little emotional from the deep talk, but laughing none the less at the image of saying all of that, along with everything else she'd been thinking, to Weaver.

She really had to stop pouring her heart out to Catra if she was *ever* going to have any game when it came to wooing her. At this rate she'd be on her ass crying about how old Finn was getting and how the last six years of their life has just flown by- *nope nope stop that*.

"Anyway, you should finish your lunch, and I have to get back out on patrol. I'll call you later? Or I could… I could swing by? Or you could come by the house? Or-"

Catra's shoulders shake with her giggle.

"Yeah princess, I have some work to do, but call me when you're off and if you want to grab dinner or something we can. But if you want to just get home to Finn I understand. Not that I'm not looking forward to a second date, but I get if you're busy later," Catra says.

Adora freezes, choking a little on the sip she'd just taken of her coffee.

"Date? This.. this was a date?" She sputters out.

Catra laughs harder.

"Well what do you call two people who are extremely attracted to each other sitting in a room *alone* sharing a meal and talking about more intimate feelings and parts of their lives than what is normal conversation?"

She makes a good point.

Adora can't get past that first half of the sentence though. Her smile splits wide, a goofy grin on her face.

"You're *extremely attracted* to me, huh?"

Catra rolls her eyes.

"Whatever dork, don't make me take it back. Now get back to work," She says, taking a sip of her own coffee and opening her takeout container to reach for her sandwich again.

"You're right, you're right. There's probably a *boatload* of fishermen out there on the pier by now," She says.

Catra narrows her eyes.

"They're probably *floundering* for a spot to dock their boats."

It's completely silent, neither of them speaking. Adora looks so proud of herself, obnoxiously so, and Catra just stares open mouth

in disbelief.

Adora takes the opportunity to put her hat on, grab her leftovers and coffee, and head to the door. When she reaches it and turns the handle, she looks back as she steps backward out the door.

She's halfway out when she pauses and says, "Have a good rest of your day, don't work too hard."

Catra glares at her, really glares.

"You too princess."

Adora is almost gone when Catra says, "Oh and Adora?"

She turns around and looks, poking her head back through the door.

"The puns are cute, but if you make one more, you're *not* coming back into this bedroom, for any reason."

"Understood," Adora responds, closing the door behind her and walking right out the front door of the hotel, whistling the whole way.

"What a fucking dork. But fuck me if it isn't already charming." Catra thinks as she lays back, collapsing onto the bed and closing her eyes.

***

Adora doesn't notice, no one really does. With the commotion on the dock that has been present for the last few days, there wouldn't be any way to keep track except for a registry. No one would have been willing to fill it out anyway since it would be a clear indication that they were overloading their boats and less than experienced with less than stellar equipment.

But out on the water, as the sun begins to set, one lone fishing boat rocks through the waves.

It’s a Wellcraft, an older one, with a wooden hull and just enough of a cabin for maybe two people to lay down in. Along the back are three fishing rods, all with lines taught and trailing deep below the water.

The owner of the vessel sat at the helm with the seat swivelled back to keep an eye on the lines. He sipped a beer and ate the dinner he’d packed, content with the peaceful quiet and beautiful sunset.

Everyone else had headed in, and he thought it was the perfect time to catch the shark, the perfect time to get away from the frenzy of people vying for their shot and allowing him a much better chance to be the one to catch it.

All of a sudden, the sound of all three large commercial fishing rods starting to slowly let out their reels with a satisfying, sharp *click* reaches his ears. He slowly and quietly puts down his food and drink, standing carefully so as not to rock the boat, and shuffles forward to take a look.

He isn’t sure how all three of them seem to have something on the line, and doesn’t really know which to focus his attention on. He stands right by the center one, buckling on his specialty belt and attaching it’s clips to the handle of the rod. He oh so gently picks it up and settles the very base of the handle into the cup in the harness, and starts carefully clicking it in until the line goes taut, and he takes a deep and nervous breath.

This was it.

He was about to catch the thing, and all that reward money would be his.

He grins. Maybe he’d put a dent in his mortgage, or he’d invest it. Or perhaps find a nice car to replace the junker he’d been kicking around in.

There’d been a $200 bottle of scotch he’d had at a friend’s bachelor party that he was dying to have again, and all these

years later, he finally knew exactly where to get it. A celebratory drink wouldn't put a dent in the money he'd have. He could probably swing it.

All he had to do was reel it in, and as he kept clicking away at the line, rotating the handle and spinning the reel in rhythmic, cautious circles, he could almost taste the reward money.

The lines all go slack, and he frowns in confusion. Did he lose it? He reaches over to the rod on his left, spinning the handle until that line is taut, taking up the slack that had accumulated since he'd focused his attention on the center rod. He does the same with the one on his right and, once those are taken care of and he's sure they aren't draping down and tangling with the propellers or anything, he starts reeling in the line attached to him.

Suddenly he's yanked forward, his knees hitting the aft wall of the boat as something, something *big* pulls hard on the line attached to him. He starts fighting it, leaning back to gain what slack he can and then quickly turning the handle and reeling the line in as he lurches forward. He does it a few times successfully, pulling back as hard as he can and quickly getting a few rotations of the reel, a few feet of the line as he tilts back forward.

Sweat covers his face and he's already regretting not getting help, but he was experienced. He'd caught marlin and tuna, and those could be hundreds of pounds. While a shark was certainly… sharper around the mouth area, it couldn't be much worse than that.

He's yanked forward again, slipping and straining his right knee as he's pulled almost out of the boat, though he manages to recover and keep his footing.

He realizes that keeping the rod attached to him is a terrible idea, with the way he'd already almost been pulled overboard. This thing was a man eater, had killed that kid at the beach and another person before that. So he walks back to the rod's holder

where it sits firmly screwed into the deck, and latches it in place before taking the harness off.

As he's thinking of what to do, the entire boat is pulled back, and he slips backwards and lands by the helm seat.

Maybe he'd have to try to bring it closer to shore. He was only around a nautical mile from the sandbar that extended past the southern edge of the island. The tide was going out when he left port, so there was a chance of beaching the monster and allowing him a much easier shot at killing it.

But when he fires up the engines, the sound does something to startle it, and the way it pulls the boat back and starts dragging it around in a large swooping circle terrifies the man all the more. He throws the throttle forward and as the RPM gauge starts to read 500, 1000, 1500, 2000 and wake kicks up behind him, he's distressed to realize that the boat isn't really moving, or at least not in the way he'd hoped.

No, the engines whir and smoke, sputtering fumes emitting from them, as the beast drags the boat every which way. Water splashes over the sides, and he fears that it was going to capsize, throwing him into the ever darkening water as the sun continues it's descent across the horizon.

"Fuck, think, think, think. God dammit!" He thinks as he stumbles up and tries to pull the release on the reel that would allow the line to go back out. At least that would give him enough time to think about how to get back to shore. When it doesn't budge, he turns toward the cabin where he kept a set of large filet knives, and he's pretty sure a machete, to cut the lines. It would be expensive to have them all fitted with new fishing line, but better than having his boat sink to the bottom of the ocean with him on it.

Suddenly, as quickly as the monster shark made its presence known, the lines go slack and the boat stops moving. The

fisherman looks around, shuffling slowly to get his footing and cautiously looks over the edge.

He registers a crack behind him, and the boat lurches, throwing him into the water.

No one was there to hear him scream.

Chapter End Notes

> "Squalus: a genus (the type of the family Squalidae) of sharks originally comprising all the known sharks but now restricted to various typical dogfishes."
>
> So if you look up 'squalus' it is no longer a branching term for all sharks, rather for a specific type of shark, but I've been including some of my favorite dialogue that I think is the most memorable from the movie and didn't want to change it.

L is for the way you look at me

Chapter Notes

> The science? Is my science. No real science. If I got any science wrong? It's not wrong it's just.... alternate science.

> Fake science

The smell of maple syrup and coffee hits Catra’s nose as the door to the diner swings shut behind her, the bell signaling her arrival. It was too busy for anyone to hear, though, and the restaurant just keeps on maneuvering around her as she looks around for Adora.

She had texted Catra a few minutes ago that they’d arrived and were in a booth near the restrooms, so it wasn’t long before she spotted Adora’s head and shoulders and Finn’s little blonde curls poking out over the faded red leather of the cushioned seats.

They hadn’t gotten together the other night, or in the last couple of days, other than for work purposes. Adora had been busy with her compressed summer classes and taking care of Finn. Meanwhile Catra was busy with her own research, as well as a few virtual staff meetings she’d had to attend regarding the department and the courses that she’d be teaching in the fall. Still, in spite of the scheduling, Adora always called her after Finn was asleep and her quality time with them was over for the night, and Catra didn’t know she could love anything as much as she loved the bubbly way Adora described her evening with her child. She felt like she already loved Finn too.

She also felt like she already loved Adora, but that was probably not possible when most of their relationship so far had transpired over the phone.

But it sure felt like it was.

It was her idea to meet for breakfast, after all. She knew how strange it could feel to meet a new adult. Before her parents' deaths, she remembers that they were constantly having company over. Combined with the fact that their relationship was more serious than merely work friends, she figured that Finn would be more comfortable if she wasn't invading their space. And if they didn't care? Well that just meant that she got to treat her two favorite people to breakfast.

And Finn had quickly qualified as one of her favorite people, though they had yet to meet.

Adora had agreed that perhaps it was best to ease them into the idea of introducing someone like a partner into Adora's life without making them feel like it was getting too serious too fast. A breakfast date? That was just cute enough to count as a 'get to know you family date' without the pressure of something more intimate in their own home.

The two are sitting next to each other with their backs toward the door, and Catra can just manage to overhear their conversation as she sneaks up from behind.

"Mommy do you kiss? Like Aunt Glimmer and Uncle Bow?" The cutest voice Catra has ever heard asks.

She has to cover her mouth as she laughs, and to her surprise, Adora just shakes her head and laughs along.

"Not yet, baby. But I kind of hope so."

The way she's just… Not a disaster is something unexpected. Catra would have thought for sure that the mention of them possibly kissing in the future would have made her panic, but apparently she was calm and collected when it mattered and only a disaster around Catra.

That thought makes her heart melt a little more.

“Well why don’t you?” Finn asks, continuing to color the back of their kids menu with the set of crayons provided.

“Between you and me babe, I’d love to kiss her. But we just met in person, and we’re taking things slow, so we can really get to know each other first,” She responds.

Finn groans.

“But you talk on the phone all the time! And you talk about her every day! She even knows that you don’t like sand and that I like hot wheels!”

Catra decides to jump in and save her.

“So, you talk about me every day?” She asks, making Adora jump and Finn whip around in their seat to stare at her.

Adora sputters, uselessly and embarrassed. But Finn, oh Finn is *excited*. Although they've never spoken, because Adora wasn’t going to let her kid talk to a near stranger on the phone regardless of how well they actually knew each other, Finn knows almost everything about Catra that Adora does.

And they’ve been *dying* to meet her since their mommy told them that Catra had arrived on the island.

“Catra!” Finn says, throwing their hands up.

“Hey! And you must be little Finn?” She asks, leaning down to ruffle their hair.

They grab her hand in both of theirs, giggling as she musses up their hair.

“I’m not little! I’m six!” They shout.

It makes Adora and Catra laugh, and even garners chuckles from a few neighboring tables that overheard.

Catra gets her first look at the two of them as she sits down on the opposite side of the booth, and can not believe how cute it is.

They're *matching*.

The blue and white horizontal striped shirts, the slip-on vans, the khaki shorts, and the two dinosaur covered bucket hats sitting on the far edge of the table are just about the most endearing thing she's ever seen.

Adora wouldn't have to put her uniform on until she worked later, and up until now Catra hadn't even begun to think about what she'd dress like outside of work. Now that she knew that Adora dressed them in matching outfits though, she was gone. She was so far gone for this family that she has to clear her throat and take a sip of the glass of water she knows to be hers.

"-tra?" She's jolted from her thoughts by Adora's voice, and her eyes make contact with Adora's concerned gaze.

"So do you two wear matching outfits exclusively? And is a third musketeer invited?" She recovers quickly and asks.

Adora's grin is instantaneous, and Catra thinks that she could really spend the rest of her life putting that smile on Adora's face.

"Oof sorry, to be bestowed with the honor of matching outfits you have to have taken me on at least two dates," She says.

Catra raises her eyebrow and says, "And what do you think this is?"

Before Adora can answer, Finn clamors onto Adora's lap and Catra is staring right at them. They try to color across the page, but the tacky crayons drag in a manner she can tell that frustrates the kid as they say, "This is a date? What's a date? I been to the diner a lot, is it always a date?"

Catra grins at them and reaches out to hold the paper still while they color.

The action alone makes Adora *swoon*.

"A date is just any way for people to spend more intimate time together-,"

Finn interrupts, "Whats that?"

Catra softens,"'Intimate' just means private or personal. So when you have dinner with just your mommy? That is more *intimate* than if you invited a bunch of friends, because it's private, just the two of you. Make sense?"

They nod, continuing to color, and she continues.

"There are two kinds of dates. The first kind is for people who are already together. Your Uncle Bow and Aunt Glimmer go on dates to spend quality time with just the two of them. They might go out so they can focus just on each other, doing an activity or going somewhere that is special and means a lot to each other. The other kind of date is for people who just met, getting to know each other. Your mommy and I go on that kind. It's called 'dating,' because we're going on those dates, and it's kind of a way to see if the other person is right for you for a relationship. So Glimmer and Bow aren't dating, but they dated in the past. Ok?"

Finn puts down their crayon and squints, brows furrowing. It's the same expression that Adora wears when she's concerned or thinking, the same one that Catra finds herself getting lost in, and she didn't think she could fall in love with an entire *family* until she'd seen that shimmery wonder reflecting back at her.

"So… you're dating my mommy?" They ask, voice taking on a sudden shyness.

Catra leans in, smiling gently at them. They're hunched over, looking at her like she holds the answer to every question they've ever wondered, and she thinks that if this is what it feels like to have a child? This feeling like she's responsible for answering every curiosity? She thinks she's okay with that.

“Yeah baby, I’m dating your mommy,” She says.

They’re quiet, just staring at her, like they’re sizing her up.

She sits up straight, looking back at them, hoping to convey just how serious she is that she’s willing to put it all on the line for *both* of them.

“Aunt Glimmer and Uncle Bow are married. If they dated before, and you’re dating now, does that mean you and mommy will be married too?” They ask.

“Well kiddo, it’s a little early to tell. You gotta be together a while, past dating, to see if you’re going to get married. Another big part of dating is seeing if you both want the same thing. Some people date because they want to find someone to marry, but some people date because it’s fun, and they want the company of another person but without it being serious. So we’re going to figure out if your mommy and I want the same thing, and go from there,” She explains.

Adora smiles at her, lips quirked up, and she doesn’t know which part of that sentence she’s smiling at.

Probably the ‘too early to tell,’ part, since it wasn’t a ‘no.’

Finn stands up on Adora’s lap, waving Catra forward and then planting both hands on the table to lean over.

She gets up and meets them in the middle, turning her head so they can whisper in her ear.

“Do you want to marry my mommy?” They ask.

She wouldn’t be surprised if Adora could hear, because they are *six* and six year olds don’t exactly whisper when they think they do. She obviously catches it, because she stiffens and looks away biting her lip.

“I can’t give you an answer yet babe. Because we haven't known each other very long. But if you want to know how I feel? Well… I feel like I’d be lucky to marry your mommy.”

They move to sit back down, staring at their paper, fingers twirling one of the crayons in their hand.

Then they look up at her.

“Ok!” They say suddenly, something shifting in their eyes.

They must decide something, that she’s trustworthy, that she’s someone they can trust with their mommy.

Or maybe it’s just the decision that they like her, and that’s enough for now.

“Well hey there Chief, and the little one! What can I get y’all to eat?” Comes the voice of the waitress.

She’s purposefully ignoring Catra, probably because she’s busy making eyes at Adora. She doesn’t touch her, because that would be just over the line, but she does rest her hand on the cushion of the backrest just inches away from Adora’s head.

Adora, for her part, looks like she’s trying to contain her irritation.

“Hey Clarice. I’ll have the double stack combo, blueberry. Eggs over easy with bacon. Finny here-” She pauses to ruffle their hair endearingly, “-will have the kids waffles with a side of sausage. And Catra, baby what do you want?” Adora responds.

It takes Catra a second to realize that Adora called her ‘baby’ and a moment longer to actually answer.

“Eggs benedict and a coffee please,” she decides, handing her menu to the waitress wordlessly while maintaining eye contact with Adora. She winks for good measure.

Just because they weren't official yet didn't mean she was going to let some other woman waltz in and flirt with her.

"Right, well I'll get those orders in for you three," She says dejected, walking toward the kitchen.

Finn keeps coloring on their menu and Catra gets a chance to turn her full attention to Adora, and is altogether awestruck once again at what she sees.

She's staring back at her, a gentle smile with her brows turned up in the most heartfelt gaze, lovingly looking at her, that she could imagine.

Adora just *knew* that Catra would get along with Finn, but it was a matter of seeing it with her own eyes that would be the deciding factor if she'd had the correct intuition or not.

But Catra had exceeded her expectations, treating her baby with a gentle kindness while indulging all of their questions, and she can't imagine someone she might want more than Catra at this point.

The rest of breakfast passes by much the same, Finn asking questions and Catra doing her best to answer. She never once loses patience with their curiosity, never makes them think that they were doing something wrong. Adora had, in the past, dealt with more than one potential partner that didn't think forming a relationship with Finn was important. She could see that this wouldn't be the case with Catra.

They're just in the middle of talking about Adora's fall courses and her graduation date when a plate scraping across the table makes both adults fall silent. They shift their gazes to the side, and see little eyes peeking over the table while a hand pushes their plate slowly, painstakingly across. It's with a lot of effort, because they're no longer in the booster seat in an attempt to reach as far across as possible.

Finn’s tongue pokes out, concentration evident on their face as they continue lunging forward, pushing the plate a few inches, and drawing back to resituate themself.

Catra bites her lip and grins, while Adora looks on with glassy squinting eyes and a serene smile on her face.

Catra reaches one hand, the one on her side facing the aisle, across the table to grab Adora’s and weave their fingers together. The other slides over to grab the edge of the plate, and Finn stops in their tracks.

She drags it across the rest of the way to her side of the table, right next to her, and they quickly disappear under the table, grunting when they bump their head.

When they emerge right next to her, climbing up onto the booth to sit in their new spot, they lean into her side and she wraps an arm around their shoulders.

“Alright kiddo, you need your booster seat so you can actually eat your breakfast,” Catra says, reaching over the table to receive the seat from Adora as she hands it over. Finn gets up so she can set it down, and when she’s finished positioning it in front of their plate, they then take the liberty of pushing it just a little closer to her so they can sit against her side. Once they deem the seat close enough, they sit down in it with their arm right up against Catra.

She picks up their fork and hands it to them, then wraps her arm around their shoulder again and threads the fingers of her other hand with Adora’s.

They spend the rest of breakfast, and a few cups of coffee after they’d finished eating, acting exactly like Adora had hoped they would.

If she looked hard enough, it kind of looked like a family.

As Catra sat across the table, she couldn’t help thinking the same thing.

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News spread quickly, as soon as the fisherman had returned to the dock, that someone had caught the shark and as Adora pulled up to the pier it was almost impossible to find a place to park amid the cars and news vans.

She and Catra had to park a quarter mile down the road and shuffle past the crowd as they drew closer. The uniform and badge got them through pretty quickly, but that was only when the onlookers were paying attention.

As they approached the dock, through the crowd at its thickest point, shouting and excited, they caught their first glimpse of the shark in question. It hung off of a hook, the reel of a large fishing boat hovering it’s lifeless form above the splintered wooden deck. Adora hadn’t ever seen a shark up close before, and a morbid fascination overtook her as she walked closer, gazing upon the leathery grey skin and it’s deep navy stripes. The teeth alone, rows of jagged razors, were enough to make her shiver, but it’s milky eyes were what really got her. Their lifelessness made her almost feel bad, for the life they’d taken, the life this thing had before.

But people died, people with consciousness, people who were beyond the struggle of ‘kill or be killed’ and she couldn't feel bad for killing the shark that had taken those people’s lives.

She sees Catra approach the thing, a notepad tucked under her arm and a pencil in her mouth as she draws a tape measure across its mouth, but she turns away when she sees Weaver out of the corner of her eye.

“Miss Mayor,” Adora nods, keeping an eye on the scene and trying her best to stop looking so excited that the thing was finally caught.

“Chief Brody,” She responds. She surveys the scene on the dock herself, turning to her assistant and saying, “I want every paper north of New York running the headline ‘Local Fisherman Catches Deadly Shark’ by this time tomorrow morning. Call Fox News, they owe me a favor for covering up that… *incident* a few years ago. And Bill O'Reilly and I are still on good terms, so send the story over to him too.”

They nod to her, writing furiously in their notepad as pages turn over in the rough sea breeze, and quickly scurry off to their office to run the headlines.

Adora, meanwhile, tries not to look nauseated at the corrupt and unethical woman standing next to her.

“Well, I see we have nothing to worry about. And there hasn’t been another incident on the beaches, in spite of your eagerness to ruin our town’s livelihood and close them,” Mayor Weaver speaks, addressing Adora now.

She takes a drag from her cigarette, and manages to blow a cloud of smoke directly at Adora, who winces and just manages not to cough.

“Take this as a lesson, Adora. Don’t be so quick to try to ruin this town’s reputation, or you might find yourself… Shall we say… On the *hook* for your failures.”

She’s about to say something, maybe even mention that there had been *plenty* of deaths since Weaver refused to close the beaches, when Catra walks up to her.

“Adora? Can we talk for a moment?”

She looks concerned to say the least. Brows furrowed and lips turned down at the ends.

“Yeah, of course,” She responds, resting her hand on Catra’s elbow and walking her a few steps away down a short pier that

sticks out from the main dock. No one was standing on it, and it gave them just enough privacy that no one would hear then.

No one except the eavesdropping mayor.

“Adora, this isn’t the shark.”

The words shoot fear into Adora’s heart. She knows Catra is the expert, knows she has to be right, and knows what it means for this town if she is.

“What? I mean look at the thing, it has to be. Doesn’t it?” She asks.

Weaver looks on, eyes narrowed in irritation and skepticism.

“I measured it’s mouth, the bite radius. This isn’t it. It doesn’t match the bites on the victims or to the hull of that boat that washed up. Different shape too. This is just another shark that they managed to catch,” Catra says.

Weaver interjects, “Well Dr. Hooper, there *aren’t* any sharks like this in these waters. So it has to be it. And it is. So I suppose it’s time for you to take your ‘professional opinion’ back to the university office you came from.”

Catra takes extreme offense to the woman’s unwillingness to listen to fact.

Numbers don’t lie. The bite radius of the wounds on the victims was significantly larger than the mouth of this shark, and it was pretty obvious to anyone that would notice that it wasn’t even really the right kind of shark. Sure, it was hard to tell, but the shape of the jaw was distinct.

“The numbers tell it all, Mayor Weaver, and they tell me that the bite radius of the shark we are looking for is at least twice the size of the mouth on that thing I just measured. Not only that, but the shape of it’s jaw doesn’t match up with the shape of the wounds. Tiger sharks have a rounder, flatter face. Blunt and wedge like.

The shark that attacked those people? It has a much longer cone like snout. And even if it was the same type of shark, there isn't any way this one is big enough for the victims we've had."

"You have a set of partial remains, and from where I'm standing, a partial bite isn't enough to decide how big a shark will be. So how do you know? That's right, you don't. You can't prove that this *isn't* the shark," Weaver says, so proud of herself there's even a smile gracing those cracked lips.

"All this thing does is eat, and make little sharks, and then eat some more, and you do not want to go messing with it and pretending that it's been caught when it hasn't. You either take away it's food source, or you kill it. And since you haven't done either, you're not any closer to preventing more deaths. This isn't about your messed up power trip anymore. People are *dying* and they're going to keep *dying* until you do something about it," Catra says, heat building in her throat and heart racing.

Catra is pretty done with the gall of this lady, and turns to face the only person she's encountered on this island with any sense.

"Adora, this isn't the shark. The digestive systems of these animals are extremely slow. I say that we cut the thing open. Whatever it's eaten in the last 24 hours is bound to still be in there, and we can say definitively whether or not it's the shark we're looking for," She says.

Again, Mayor Weaver cuts in, and it takes all of Catra's willpower not to scream at the woman.

"Listen here, this is not the time or the place for some half assed autopsy on a fish. And I am not going to stand here and watch you cut that thing open and see that man spill out all over the dock. This is over. I won't let you sully this town's reputation, *my* reputation."

Before they know it, before they can retort, Mayor Weaver is stepping up to stand next to the shark, along with half a dozen of

the people who caught it and anyone else on the dock that felt like being a part of the celebration that day, while a cameraman takes a few photos.

Catra is about to step forward, bringing the whole thing to a halt with what she knows is enough evidence to at least get them to stop celebrating that much, but she feels a hand on her shoulder and turns to see Adora.

She's looking defeated, just like she does after every time Catra knows she's talked to Weaver, and nods her head in the direction of her car.

"We should go, they're not going to change their minds, and the Mayor sure isn't going to try to set the record straight. Let's head out and think of a plan."

Weaver waves them down though. She has something she'd like to say, something to say to Adora in front of Catra, and everys single person at this dock.

"Adora, I suggest you rid yourself of this distraction. Before you lose the ability to care for that *child* of yours."

Everyone falls silent for a moment, doesn't move or speak. But then just as the moment starts, it passes, and everyone is bustling about getting ready to take photos of the shark for the papers.

But with just a little less respect for and faith in their police chief.

Adora looks away, for so long that Catra worries she believes Weaver. She worries for a split second that Adora will abandon everything they've worked for, all of the research they've done, all of the evidence they've collected. She worries Adora will turn and leave her there on the dock, to get back to the hotel by herself and pack her bags.

But instead, she reaches out and grabs Catra's hand and says, "Let's go."

Catra doesn’t say anything, though she thinks she should. Her instinct is to defend herself, saying that she’s there as an expert and there isn't anything she could possibly do that would qualify as a distraction.

But she can tell that Adora already knows that, and as she leads Catra out to her jeep, opens the door for her, and takes her hand as she settles into the driver’s seat, Catra understands exactly what Adora’s game is.

She’s waiting.

She’s waiting out the clock, because Weaver’s intentions would be revealed, and all that they’d worked for would be within grasp.

So she tightens her hold on Adora’s hand, and prepares to enjoy the ride back to the hotel.

But even as they drive by the dock, Catra’s surprise at the characters of this little town grows exponentially. She swears that below the deck of an ancient fishing boat, she sees an old woman half her height with bright white hair and a purple dress chopping fish and tossing them into a bucket.

“Who in the world is that?” She asks.

Adora looks around to where she sees Catra’s gaze turned and stops the car.

She says, “Oh that’s Razz.”

Catra lifts a brow and looks at her, “Who is Razz?”

Adora rubs the back of her neck.

“I’m not really sure? But she came in talking about the U.S.S. Annapolis or something? And some sharks and all of a sudden she was offering to take care of our problem.”

Catra nods.

"U.S.S. Indianapolis. It was this heavy cruiser that sank, struck by a Japanese sub on the way back to the Philippines from delivering parts of one of the nuclear weapons to a base on Tinian, back in July of '45. It sank in only 12 minutes, if you can believe it. Around 900 made it off of the ship, but only 300 or so survived the whole thing, most of the crew died in the water from shark attacks, dehydration, exposure. Oceanic whitetips are attracted to the kind of commotion and smells from accidents, so they're sure to show up to any ship wreck, and they're really aggressive. It was and still is called the worst shark attack in history. If she survived that, I'd bet money she knows her shit about sharks," Catra explains.

Adora stares at the fishing boat and the old woman as she putters around minding her business. She's either doing a remarkable job ignoring everyone on the dock and land, or she just doesn't notice it. She finishes cleaning off her knife and puts a plastic lid on the 5 gallon bucket, turning to climb the ladder with concerning and surprising speed. Heeled shoes slotted with the rungs of the ladder as she climbed up to the helm seat where she pulled out a ball of yarn and a set of knitting needles.

Adora had thought about it, thought hard about the funds she'd need to secure to hire someone to catch the shark. She thought about how hard it would be to get Weaver to sign them, and hadn't thought about it since.

But the shark was out there, and Razz was here, and she had a boat that looked like it could hold the kind of creature they were hunting and the means to catch it.

Adora nods to herself and pulls onto the road to take Catra back to her hotel so they can both get back to work.

In the back of her mind, the gears are turning.

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Adora registers the knock on the door, but can't manage to drag herself out of her chair regardless. Today was rough, rougher than she thought it would be, and the fact that Weaver still refused to see reason was really getting to her. She had all afternoon to stew in the interaction, the looks she got on the pier, the way Weaver smiled at her like she was looking through her.

So when Glimmer answers the door, she doesn't expect Catra, in her signature denim jacket, to march in.

She's holding a bouquet of roses, *and* a smaller bouquet of daffodils, but that's not what Adora stares at.

No, Adora can't stop staring at the way that same denim jacket forms a rigid and structured armor around her shoulders, while revealing the button up shirt and tie she's elected to wear beneath it. The shirt is a crisp white, but it's chambray, the texture matching well with the jacket, tucked into a pair of navy corduroy slacks, and a deep burgundy knit tie loosely knotted around her neck.

She looks *astounding* and Adora can't do anything but stare.

"Like what you see, princess?" Catra asks, setting the two bouquets in their vases down on the table.

Adora stays seated, but she crosses her arms over her chest in a show of her biceps, and Catra feels her mouth practically start to water at the way her muscular forearms cord tightly over her chest.

Adora definitely notices and smirks, "Like what you see, kitten?"

Glimmer groans and rolls her eyes leaving the room as she says, "God I don't know why I stood around and waited for that to happen to me."

Catra grins, and Adora bursts out laughing at her distressed friend.

Adora then turns her attention to the flowers.

“Couldn’t decide?” She asks.

Catra blushes, deep crimson peppering her face right across the span of freckles over her nose and cheeks.

“Oh don’t flatter yourself, the daffodils are for Finn.”

It makes Adora’s heart *stop* before it starts thundering in her chest.

“You got flowers for Finn?” She whispers.

Catra smiles at her gently.

“Well yeah, I’m trying to get *both* of you to like me,” She jokes, continuing more seriously, “I know they have allergies, so I got daffodils. The shopkeeper said they were some of the lowest allergen flowers they had, and I guessed that they like yellow?”

Adora stands up, rounding the table, and brings her arms up to rest on Catra’s shoulders, leaning her head in to rest against her forehead.

“Yeah, yellow is their favorite. Want to go give these to them?”

Catra nods, “If it’s cool with you, yeah I’d love to see them. They’re a snuggly little thing and I don’t know about you but after today I could really use a big cuddle pile with my two favorite people.”

Adora lets out a shuddered breath, fanning over Catra’s face, and leans in so their lips are millimeters apart.

“Yeah, cuddling with *my* two favorite people sounds amazing.”

And then they’re both leaning in, and their lips are brushing together, and there isn't anything in the world that could take this moment away from them.

Their lips move together, sliding effortlessly with all the care they had for each other, all the love they could already feel themselves falling into. They stand there in the kitchen and slot their bodies together, wrapping arms around each other and grasping on to clothes tightly, while their lips stay in that warm and supple embrace.

When they pull back, panting lightly, Catra reaches to the back of Adora's head and nudges it down enough that she can reach Adora's forehead to give her a kiss there. She brings Adora's face down to her neck, rubbing her back, and feels the tension and pressure leave her body entirely.

"Let's go give these to Finn and see if we can put on a movie in the family room," Adora whispers.

"Yeah, after you princess."

Finn falls asleep halfway through the movie, right between the two of them. Adora knows that they hadn't had much time for themselves with how she had to run home to be with Finn, and wonders if it's less than ideal to date someone with a kid getting *physically* between them, too. But she looks over and catches a glimpse of Catra running her fingers through Finn's bangs with a look of pure joy on her face mixed with something else.

But she knows that look.

Because that's the way Angella and Micah look at Glimmer, how Lance and George look at Bow. It's the way she's pretty sure she looks at Finn too.

And then Catra's gaze shifts up, and she looks at Adora the same way, but different somehow, tinted with a little something more.

When she gives a smile back, she hopes it says 'I love you.'

Not, 'I love you, already.'

Or, 'I *think* I love you.'

Just ‘I love you.’

Because she does.

Shadows

Chapter Notes

Surprise Catra and Adora are GNC (this isn't a surprise it's my HC for them)

I didn't tag it before because I don't like tagging it and then not having any evidence in the writing, but I wasn't sure how to work it in until now. So that's why it probably seems abrupt, but I assure y'all that it was my plan all along anyway

This chapter starts where the last one leaves off, because I needed just a little more fluff before... ya know

Stuff happens

When the movie ends, Adora brings the remote up to turn off the TV, and the three sit in silence for a few moments. Finn is still passed out, leaning against Catra with her arm around them. She's rubbing their back gently, and the other hand has reached across to fiddle with the curly strands of their hair. She looks down at them with love and adoration, with a peaceful serenity that Adora recognizes as the way she looks at them. Catra looks at Finn like they're *hers* and Adora really hopes that one day? Maybe they will be.

It's sweet how much Catra already cared for the child, and Adora swears she falls just a little bit more in love with her every moment that they spend together.

"Guess we should get this one to sleep. Then I should-," Catra starts, but is cut off with a yawn. She's clearly tired too, and the walk back to the hotel seemed monumental.

"You could spend the night? I know it might be early… but you could always sleep with me? And if not, you can take my room and I'll take the couch," Adora says, uncertainty in her voice as she stands and hovers over Finn.

She tries to pry them off, but they've got a hand securely fisted in Catra's shirt. Catra has to work pretty hard to stand while holding them and making sure not to disturb them, but something about the absolute dead weight of a sleeping child, the trust it implies, the way they already really like her, nearly brings a tear to her eye. She holds them a little tighter.

There were a couple of things she was nervous for Adora to find out, a couple of things that she didn't share until well after the third or fourth date normally, but she knew Adora would understand.

"Relax princess, I'd love to share with you. I'm not going to let you sleep on the couch, and besides, you seem awful snuggly. Finn has to get it from somewhere. Now, where can we drop this little one?" She says, soothing and gentle.

Adora lets out the breath she'd been holding, smiling brightly and moving in the direction of Finn's room. The short walk down the hall is taken by Adora backward so she can get the full effect of the way Catra looks holding Finn, the sleeping child content in her arms.

She hopes she gets to see this far more often, but doesn't let the thought that Catra didn't live here and would be going back home after this ordeal was over get to her. It was something she'd considered every time she caught herself thinking about the woman, and granted, it was kind of a bummer.

But at this point? She was all in. And if Catra was too, she could do long distance no problem.

They get to a door down the hall with a glittery rainbow sign on it and Catra smiles at the design.

Finn's room is single handedly the most adorable thing Catra has ever seen. There are string lights bordering the room at the seam between the walls and ceiling, extending down to the canopy of a four poster bed. Artificial ivy winds down the wooden rails to the

height of the bed. The sheets are a deep purple with gold swirls, the small area rug on the floor in the same colors and a similar pattern. There are little landmines, hotwheels cars and legos all over the floor that Catra has to step around on the way to the bed. Along the wall with the window that overlooks the ocean is a Barbie dreamhouse (she's a little jealous honestly, because she'd always wanted one as a kid) with a racetrack running expertly through all of the windows from a point up near the nightstand all the way to the floor. It's held together with floral wire and zip ties, built to withstand the pressure of a car rocketing down the track. Around the bottom of the table is a different type of track with a set of electric cars, the remote controls for them sitting haphazardly by the foot of the bed, and she can tell that there had been many races between Finn and the other occupants of the house.

Adora pulls back the comforter on their bed so Catra can lay them down, and they both pull the blanket back over them. They snuggle down into it immediately, burrowing their face in the pillow as Adora tucks the blanket around them.

She leans in to kiss them on the forehead, and when she pulls back, Catra leans in to do the same. She looks down at them for just a moment more, something deep within her making her reach out to trace under the curls strewn across their forehead. She can't help but stare at their tiny face, the wonder and imagination that she knows lie behind their smooth eyelids.

They're so fucking perfect. I love them so much. Is all she can think about.

She'd do anything for this little family, for Adora and for Finn.

On the way back out of the bedroom, Catra can see the wall adjacent to the door, and walks over to survey the decorations. There is a bulletin board with pictures of them, dating back to Adora holding them as an infant in the hospital, and a few brightly colored stickers. The small craft table, only shin height, is covered in G.I. Joes and little army tanks painted pink and purple. There

are a couple little plastic parachutes laid out to dry, freshly painted. Along the wall are notebook and sketchbook pages filled with drawings of everything Finn could have imagined. There are rough illustrations of dragons and castles, princesses on horseback, a few sailboats bobbing on the ocean surf. Then Catra gets to the family portrait section, with Bow and Glimmer, sparkly and pink pictures of their Aunt and Uncle, and then them and Mommy. It's like they're a timeline, the first few with Finn no taller than knee height on an Adora with long hair, and then up until they're hip height and Adora's hair is much shorter.

Then, when she gets to the end where the pictures stop, closest to the door, is one that she doesn't expect. It's the three of them. She's got shaggy brown hair, curling into swirls with different colors of brown in a startling level of complexity for a kid's drawing, and they've even got her favorite denim jacket. Adora isn't in her uniform, rather the same matching outfit that they'd worn to breakfast the other day, and it makes for just as cute a picture as what she'd walked in on in the diner.

Catra is jolted from her thoughts by a hand on her shoulder, and looks up to see Adora standing there, that same smile, as she guides Catra out of the room wordlessly. They move down the hall, toward the only other door in the house, besides what she knew to be Glimmer and Bow's room, and Catra is filled with a sudden anxiousness.

This was it.

This was *really* it.

She steps into the bedroom and takes in the crisp white sheets on a queen sized bed. On each side of the bed sat a nightstand with a lamp, but the one on the right, on the side with the en suite bathroom held a phone charger, an inhaler, and a book. She took that to mean that the left side would be hers, and went over to sit on the very edge of the bed.

“Do you need some clothes? I mean obviously because you didn’t bring any but I meant what do you like to sleep in? I have pajama pants and sweats, t-shirts, long or short sleeved, but I also have a bunch of pairs of boxers and some tank tops-” She starts to ramble.

“Boxers and a tank top are fine, thanks baby,” Catra says, and her voice soothes Adora’s clear nerves.

Adora walks over to the closet to pick out some clothes for both of them to sleep in, and it gives Catra a chance to walk around and look at the rest of the room. It’s painted the same color as Finn’s room and the hallway, the same beige, and she has a feeling that Adora didn't have much time to dedicate to home decor. It was fair really, Catra barely had time to try to decorate her tiny apartment, and she didn’t even have a kid.

Yet, she finds herself thinking.

The walls are covered with pictures of Finn, the same one from the day of their birth is framed in a much larger size right above the dresser on the wall of the closet, along with a dozen or so of everything from birthday parties to days at the park, featuring some combination of Finn, Adora, Glimmer, and Bow in all of them. She’s glad that Adora had her friends there from day one, and while she doesn’t know the circumstances around Adora being a single mother, she at least takes comfort in knowing that the sweet, dedicated, loving person that she’d gotten to know, had received the help she deserved.

There are a few pictures that she can tell were gifts from Finn, perhaps birthday or holiday cards, taped to the wall around the vanity mirror in the corner.

It’s... Exactly what she’d expect. She didn't think Adora would be the type to decorate for herself, while she was this busy and stressed, but she took her to be exactly the kind of person to hang up every picture she’d ever taken of her child, every picture said child would have given her.

“Hey,” Adora says behind her, and she turns around to see her next to the closet with a stack of clothes in her hands.

When Adora hands her the clothes, she doesn’t even bother going to the bathroom to change. She strips off her tie and button up shirt, revealing the binder beneath just as Adora is yanking her own t-shirt over her head.

And Catra stares at Adora’s binder.

She rolls her eyes at herself and snorts.

“Guess we really do have a lot more in common than I thought, huh?” She jokes

Adora says, “Huh?” Looking down and blushing.

“Oh! I forgot this wasn’t like… normal. Fuck ‘normal,’ but like, I kind of forgot that being gender nonconforming was even nonconforming. It’s just how I’ve been for so long that I forgot it was a thing I was supposed to think about,” Adora explains, shrugging.

“Hey, I understand. It’s been a part of me for so long that I didn’t think until a couple of minutes ago that you’d see my binder and my… yeah.”

Adora raises an eyebrow and Catra gears up to explain.

“I’m trans. Like… trans feminine? I don’t want to get into it too deep right now, but I started transitioning when I was in my last year of high school, on hormones since then. But eventually I realized I liked wearing suits and I like having short hair. So I started taking back all of the things that would have been weaponized against me, all of the masculine things that I enjoyed that would have been reasons for people not to believe me. Now I just… I like my body a lot. I wear the binder sometimes, when I feel like I need to, but it feels good to have breasts? And I wear suits, but it feels good to have people see a woman when they look at me? I have no idea how to explain it honestly. I just know

that gender doesn’t really mean anything to me… But I am the happiest I have ever been because of all of the transitioning that I’ve done. So I'm not super feminine, but I'm still a trans woman?”

Adora smiles, “You don’t owe me an explanation. Trans women don’t owe anyone femininity, trans men don’t owe anyone masculinity, and no queer person owes anyone androgyny. I just care what you want me to call you, how you want me to think of you, who you want me to know you as. I don’t think anything else about your transition, other than what you want to tell me, is any of my business. If we gave a name to our relationship? Yeah I would hope to learn more about you. If we moved in together? If we got married? I would hope that you trusted me with that information. And we'll have to talk about it at least a little bit if we're going to have sex just to be safe. But for right now, I want to know what you want to tell me, and I want to treat you the way you want to be treated. That’s all.”

Those are all the words Catra wouldn’t let herself hope to hear, wouldn’t let herself dream to come from a person she was this interested in. She never thought she’d be this understood, hearing words this comforting from someone.

“What about you?” She asks, gesturing at the binder on Adora’s chest.

She shrugs.

“I wear it when I feel like it? Some clothes just… Look better to me when I wear it. The way they fall around my body looks better, the way I feel about it is better. But sometimes it doesn’t help, and I wear a sports bra or something. My gender is pretty fluid, and I don’t really care what pronouns people call me or how people think of me because I don’t really think of myself as *having* a gender anyway.”

Catra nods.

“Well, since I was worried for nothing, and you literally didn’t even think about it, let's get ready for bed,” She says, unhooking the side seam of her binder and taking it off.

Adora is a *disaster* but she’s also *mesmerized*.

At Catra’s breasts, yeah, those are supple and perfect and soft looking but also because *her binder isn’t that cool*.

“Where did you get one with hooks? That looks so much easier to put on! What the fuck I’ve just been dislocating my shoulder to shimmy this thing over my head!” She exclaims, shimmying said binder over her head to change into her night shirt.

Catra laughs, “I’ll send you the link for the one that I bought."

They talk and laugh like that back and forth, Catra even taking off her underwear to slide on Adora’s boxers and Adora doing the same until they’re crawling into bed next to each other.

“You know something?” Adora whispers, wrapping an arm around Catra’s waist and leaning forward to rest her head on her shoulder.

“What?” She responds, giggling just slightly at the breath on her neck.

“I knew you’d be beautiful, because on the phone you sound like an angel, but I never imagined you’d be this fucking *handsome*.”

It makes Catra blush, because while she liked ‘beautiful,’ got called ‘beautiful’ by a lot of partners, she hadn’t been called ‘handsome’ much. People usually thought she wouldn't like it, which was a fair assumption. But she liked being handsome the way a woman could be handsome.

“Well I have to be, if I was going to come rescue my princess,” She whispers.

Adora tightens her arm and presses closer in, but Catra brings her free hand up to grasp at Adora's chin.

She scratches her nails over Adora's sharp jawline, tilting her face up to look her in the eye.

"Now, would a kiss please the lady?" Catra asks.

Adora's cheeks, once a gentle pink, rage red.

She licks her lips.

"A kiss would please me greatly," She whispers back, so soft she thinks the breeze from the open window could carry it away, as she leans forward mere millimeters away from Catra's deep burgundy lips.

When their lips connect, slotting together and moving perfectly in a practiced dance, a languid motion, sparks shoot up Adora's spine and make Catra's toes curl.

They fall asleep, facing each other with limbs intertwined.

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Catra and Adora step up next to the lifeguard chair, Adora resting her forearm on the loose flakes of paint covering the wood, and Catra standing next to her barely separated. The summer celebration is in full swing, everyone on the beach for the Fourth of July celebration. The town was busier than ever, with every restaurant at capacity and the section of beach closed for fireworks later in the evening being the only square footage of sand that wasn't covered in chairs, towels, and plastic beach toys.

It was terrifying, and Catra for the first time gets the full effect of just how scary it was to be in Adora's position, being one of the people in the know and still powerless to do anything.

So she waits, taking in the children building sand castles and playing in the surf, the couples walking hand in hand down the

beach, and a fearful nervousness shooting through her at all of the swimmers just a little too far out for her liking.

Is this how Adora felt? Like she should stop them, but she can't? Like any of these people could be the next victims, and she feels like it's her responsibility to try to stop it?

No wonder Adora had trouble sleeping lately, kept up by the thought that if it was just a few years earlier and she was at the beach with Glimmer, Bow, and Finn, any one of them could have been the unlucky next prey to a shark that everyone else believed was caught.

She hears a piercing scream and tenses, relaxing when she locates the happy child splashing in the waves, barely a few feet tall as they sit in the shallowest part of the water. She feels Adora's hand on her lower back and at first she jumps at the sudden focus on her physical presence. As Adora moves to retreat her hand, though, Catra leans into her and grabs it to intertwine with her own.

"This is… Fuck this is terrible," Catra says.

"Yeah, it really is. Like… *We* know, but no one else does. And it's horrifying to think about what could happen, what's going to happen," She says back, turning to plant a kiss on top of Catra's head.

They were trying to keep their relationship professional at first. Nothing good would come of it if Weaver saw them being all handsy at the beach while Adora was on duty. But that was before the scene at the dock, and now Adora was much more interested in spending time with Catra as herself than pretending to be who the mayor wanted her to be.

Plus, they could both sense that the time to really contract someone serious to catch the shark would be coming up soon, and it was only a matter of weeks or days before Catra had to head back to the university, back to her life. Neither was ready for

that, and unbeknownst to Adora, Catra had been talking back and forth with her boss and her coworkers about the possibility of working remotely for the rest of the summer until she had to return to teach her classes in the fall semester.

It was too early to tell, though she knew her boss was working with her on it.

Catra leans into Adora's side, resting her head on her shoulder, and continues looking around the beach.

"Do you think that… That I'm doing enough?" Adora whispers.

Catra frowns, turning to look up at her.

"Yes, I think you are. You tried to close the beach and got denied. You tried to contract someone to catch the shark and got denied. You tried to let me dissect the one they caught, and were once again denied. I don't know what more you think you could have done, but Adora, none of what's happening is your fault."

Adora sighs, kicking at the sand with her black boots.

"Yeah, I guess on paper when you bring up all of that it seems like I'm doing all that I can. It just… it doesn't feel like enough. It never feels like I'm doing enough, working hard enough, and it really sucks to feel like that when people have been dying and are just going to keep dying."

"Just remember, you don't have to do all of this on your own. There are other people that are supposed to back you up, that are supposed to give you the tools you need to do your job, and believe in you enough to do it. Just because Weaver doesn't believe in you, is choosing not to let you. That isn't on you. Please believe me," Catra whispers, tilting her head down to kiss Adora's shoulder.

She doesn't respond, but Catra can tell that it's equal parts because she straight up doesn't believe Catra, and because she's trying as hard as she can to believe her.

At some point Adora gets restless while standing still and they move down toward the water to walk through the compacted sand along the edge. Keeping a close eye on the beachgoers in the water, Catra manages to enjoy the smell of salt as the breeze tickles over her skin. In spite of the circumstances, she'd always loved the ocean. From the moment her father first carried her in, still in diapers, to that last beach trip of the summer before the accident. And when she was finally ready, her last year of high school, the ocean was there when she returned, holding all of her memories in a protective embrace. She would never grow tired of the way it felt to step onto the sand and feel her father's hands cupping her smaller ones, hear her mother's laughter while she reeled in her fishing rod.

She reaches up to wipe away the tear, and Adora looks on in concern.

"Hey, you ok?" She asks, stopping.

Catra stops walking too, and looks at Adora.

"Yeah, just memories you know?"

She nods.

Catra hadn't caught all of her tragic backstory yet, and hadn't shared much of her own, but she knew that Adora had experienced a very similar loss to her. So she doesn't feel as bad about being vulnerable in front of Adora as she would anyone else, a stranger.

They continue walking, going as far as the inlet and then turning to walk back up the beach in the direction of the fireworks display a mile up. Things are peaceful, as far as they can be with how busy it is. The scrambled groups of children running around with volleyballs and footballs, ready to cause mayhem for the older patrons, remind Catra of Finn. She'd love to share her love of the ocean with them, maybe play a few rounds of catch in the shallow water or sit around a bonfire teaching them a few knots for

sailing. Maybe Adora would even be interested in the three of them having a little fishing trip.

But that was for later, when it was safe again, when the beast was caught and there wasn't any danger. While she wouldn't normally condone hunting an animal just for existing in it's own natural habitat, she couldn't deny that this shark was acting quite strangely. Sticking close to shore, in the same place for months on end? It had clearly decided that this was it's feeding ground, and that was completely out of the ordinary for one of its species. Especially since there weren't really any prey large enough to satisfy a Great White in these waters.

Well, except for people.

It had to be caught, because it wasn't going to stop hunting here until it was dead, or it's food supply was cut off. And the people of this island weren't being led to believe that it was dangerous to keep going in the ocean.

"Is that a shark?" She hears someone say, and freezes.

The whispers start, a few people pointing at a large shadow below the surface of the water.

She thought she saw a fin, thought she saw it moving, but wasn't going to shout it to create a panic.

"Shark!" She hears someone else shout, someone further up the beach.

Then the panic starts. Beachgoers are clamoring over themselves, screaming in a panic to get out of the water. They pick up their kids, those who were further from their parents nearly trampled as they fall over in the surf. Adora lunges forward to pick a kid up out of the shallow water, waves breaking over their face, and carries them back up to shore while Catra rushes out to help a couple of elderly swimmers get their footing.

The beach is a dangerous mass of people trying to escape, trying to get out of the water, and Adora fears that in addition to casualties from the actual shark attack, there would be injuries from the terrified and frantic crowd.

A couple of the last few to escape the water stumble on shore, and Adora and Catra look around to see if anyone is injured, see if there is any blood or broken bones, anyone laying on the sand instead of standing up, but for the most part while shaken everyone looked alright.

And when they all turn around, the crowd lets out a loud sigh of relief when the 'shark' begins to disperse, the shadow of the large mass of seaweed breaking apart into individual pieces.

It wasn't the shark. It wasn't the shark, and Adora has never been so thankful that she was wrong about today.

But then they hear a shout, a faint voice in the distance.

"Shark! Shark in the pond!"

She looks up, but she's already exhausted, and if it's another false alarm, she'll just look like a fool for being this terrified, losing her cool.

Catra stops her, just as she's starting to relax, and the look of fear on her face paralyzes Adora.

"Finn's in the pond," She says, placing her hand flat on Adora's chest, feeling her heartbeat.

Because Bow and Glimmer, knowing the ocean wasn't safe, had taken Finn into the pond off of the inlet where they were sure a shark wouldn't go.

But they were wrong.

Adora takes off sprinting, Catra hot on her heels. She tears through the sand, knocking over a few chairs and pushing to the

side some less than impressed beachgoers on her way in her haste to get to her child, to make sure they were safe.

Somewhere in the corner of her eye she sees Weaver, but pays her no mind as she continues her mad dash to reach Finn, to reach her child and her friends.

To reach her family.

By the time she gets to the wooden walking bridge that crosses over the inlet she sees the shark's fins cutting a smooth line through the water, headed directly for a few small boats.

She knows that one of them is the canoe that usually sits in her front yard, and recognizes the two people in it.

It's Bow and Finn. Bow and Finn are in a canoe on the water, happily rowing in circles, while the creature that has killed countless people, bitten holes straight through the hulls of fishing boats, heads straight toward them.

Adora runs like her life depends on it, oblivious to the people she passes, the tears running down her face, the ache in her side, and the fact that at any moment her child could be gone forever.

"Fuck fuck fuck fuck I'm coming Finn," she thinks as she gets to the other side of the bridge and launches herself over the wooden railing, landing on the sand and tripping over her feet a few times in her frantic dash to reach them.

Out on the water, Bow hears shouting, and looks around.

"Uncle Bow? Why are they all yelling?" Finn asks.

He scans the water, worried for the both of them. He knows how Adora felt about the ocean, but he'd gotten her permission to take Finn out in the pond. There was no way the shark would come in here when there were so many people out in the open water. Still, he looks around for any sign of disturbance and then back to the beach where Glimmer is now standing up out of her beach chair.

“I don’t know bud, but let’s head in and see what Aunt Glimmer brought for lunch. Ok?” He asks.

He doesn’t see the shadow that passes below them, the shape or size of it.

Maybe it’s better that way, that he doesn’t see it before it happens.

He starts rowing them toward shore, trying to stay calm so he doesn’t scare Finn.

From the new angle as he turns, he can see the small sailboat that had been turning circles a few yards away capsize, and while he doesn’t know for sure, he rows toward the beach faster.

If it was an accident, they’d be fine. If it was a shark, he wanted to keep his godchild far away from it.

Because after everything they’d been through together, high school and college and then another decade of living as each other’s family, he would do anything to keep Finn safe and protect Adora from losing her child.

Anything

They’re halfway to the shore when he sees Adora and Catra running up, and then come the screams from behind.

“What was that?” Finn says, trying to turn around, but Bow just puts his hand on their shoulder and nudges them back to face the other way.

“Don’t look buddy, it’s alright,” He says, rowing almost frantically now.

Then, he feels something hit the bottom of the canoe, and has to throw himself to the side to counter the harsh impact as it attempts to tip them over.

Finn is shaking now, looking scared, and Bow reaches out to pull them closer to himself so they don't fall over with the force of whatever was coming next.

And he just keeps rowing.

He's sure it's shallow enough that a shark wouldn't attack, but that thought is quickly thrown out the window when he sees, out of the corner of his eye, the dorsal fin of the animal as it makes contact with the back of the canoe. Finn cries out in shock, and Bow tries his hardest to right them again, but the spinning motion rocks the canoe until they're tipping over, and Bow grabs onto Finn by the straps on the back of their tiny life jacket to pull them close.

They go under, and Bow waits to feel teeth or leathery skin, but the shark must have swam away to circle back, because he has enough time to get to the surface, take a breath, and pull the knife from his pocket. He looks around, kicking both of them toward shore while he still searches for the shark.

Then he sees it, coming toward them, and stops. It's larger, faster, and more terrifying than he'd ever imagined. He knows they won't make it to shore fast enough, knows that there's only one thing he can do, and he hoists Finn up to the relative safety of the capsized canoe as it bobs up and down. A perfect air bubble trapped beneath keeps it afloat, and he can feel Finn shaking and crying as he pushes them up.

"Uncle Bow?" They whimper.

"It's ok baby," He says, panting and out of breath while he swims to the front and tries to hold on to it. When he tests it and is confident that it could hold his weight as well, he lifts his legs up in the water and brings them parallel to the bottom of the canoe. He hopes that it gives him a low enough profile that the shark will see that he isn't really reachable and swim away to recalculate.

As it gets closer, Finn cries harder.

"Just hold on Finn, it's gonna be ok. See? Mommy is right on shore. She's right there and she'll be there when we get back ok? Just keep looking at mommy," He begs, trying to keep them from seeing it if the shark does get a hold on him.

It's almost to them, and he can see it open its mouth.

He flicks out the blade of his knife, a six inch hunting knife that his fathers had gotten him for a birthday a few years ago, and waits for the shark to get close enough.

Finn is crying, and he feels a tear run down his face and he prays that, if this doesn't work, they just keep looking at Adora and don't see him get dragged under.

He hopes that Finn doesn't watch him die, that Finn can stay on top of the canoe long enough for rescue to come to them.

It gets closer and closer, rocketing toward them, and Bow sets his targeted eye on one of its eyes, the only sensitive part of it he could reach.

Rows of razor sharp teeth, jagged and blood stained from the victims from the other sail boats, give way to a dark and haunting cavern deep within it's mouth.

When he thrusts the knife forward, lodging it in it's eye, he can tell that, while it certainly pissed it off and it was nowhere near dead, the obstruction and pain are enough to deter it. The shark detours back out toward the mouth of the inlet, and Bow doesn't know if it is gone for good or if it will be coming back, but there isn't time to see.

They won't get a second chance at this.

He acts quickly, kicking his feet down and pulling Finn off of the canoe and back close to his chest, knowing that he could swim faster if he wasn't dragging the canoe behind him. Finn clings to him and he starts kicking, and to his shock and surprise, he

doesn’t swim far before Adora, Catra, and Glimmer are all meeting him.

“Mommy!” Finn cries, Adora taking them from Bow and holding them close to her as she treads water in her clothes.

Catra and Glimmer grab Bow, taking on some of his weight and helping him swim as he goes silent and starts shaking.

When all five of them make it back to shore, Adora collapses to her knees, holding Finn close to her and crying. She’s openly sobbing, and so are they.

Catra, Glimmer, and Bow walk up behind her, and Bow falls to his knees to wrap his arms around both of them. Glimmer and Catra cement themselves to Bow and Adora’s sides, all of them silently supporting each other.

When she notices that Bow and Finn are silent, both of them cold to the touch and shaking, Catra walks over and steals the blankets and towels from a few people off to the side, though they don’t seem to mind after everything they’ve just seen.

Because regardless of what happened to Finn and Bow, who made it out alive, they had also seen the people on the small sailboat that hadn’t made it to shore.

“Adora? Take Finn’s life jacket and shirt off, I think they’re in shock,” She says, holding the towel open. Adora makes quick work of both, and can feel Finn shivering as she takes off the cold and wet garments. She hands them forward to Catra, who wraps the blanket around them. Finn snuggles into Catra’s chest, shaking subsiding a little bit, but she still reaches for Glimmer’s phone where it lays on her chair to call 911.

It was safer for both of them to go to the hospital. Either of them could have hit their heads falling out of the boat, sustaining head injuries. They could have breathed in and swallowed water, and while it was rare, secondary drowning was still a serious contender for ‘most terrifying things that can happen after you

think you've survived a water accident.' Not to mention the drop in blood pressure and the resulting complications from just going into shock.

She hands the other towel to Adora and instructs that she help Bow out of his cold, wet shirt and wrap the towel around him as well.

While they wait for an ambulance to take Finn and Bow to the ER, just to make sure they're truly unharmed after the incident, they notice that a crowd has gathered.

All down the shore toward the ocean, across the walking bridge, and on the other side, people have gathered in whispered shock at what has happened, right here after they thought the shark was caught.

Adora doesn't say anything, doesn't try to disperse the crowd, doesn't try to call the other officers to see if everyone on the beach was ok. She doesn't even glance at Mayor Weaver where she stands in the parking lot just a few yards away.

She just focuses on Finn and Bow, on her family, and when the ambulance gets there and Weaver tries to talk to her, she shoulder checks the frail, evil woman as she carries Finn to the EMTs. It *bodies* her, nearly knocking her to the ground if her assistant hadn't caught her.

After Bow and Glimmer are in the back of one, and Finn is handed off to have their blood pressure taken, Adora turns around to face Catra..

"Are you ok?" She asks.

Catra nods, reaching forward to hug Adora.

"I'm just glad Bow and Finn are ok. I'm fine. Are you?"

Adora considers that for a moment.

"No. I'm shaken up and angry, and I came close to losing my best friend and my child today. But I will be."

She reaches into her pocket and pulls out her keys, "Here, take my car so you can go get cleaned up and changed. You can hang out at the house and I'll call you from the hospital phone to let you know how they're both doing."

Catra takes the keys and they share a quick kiss before Adora is climbing into the back of Finn's ambulance, hearing their shaky and tired voice asking a million questions about all of the equipment and what it's for.

"I'll grab you all some fresh clothes while I'm there. Call as soon as you're through triage so I know when to head over," Catra says.

Adora nods, and the ambulance doors are closed behind her.

When they drive off, Catra turns to walk back across the bridge to the parking lot by the beach, and hears the questions already starting.

"When was the chief going to tell us the shark was still out there?"

"So they're just going to let people go swimming when there is danger? Unbelievable."

"And did you see how she didn't even care about anyone else?"

It makes Catra *snap*.

"Tell me you'd care about a single other person if your child was in the water with that thing, if your best friend and your baby barely made it out. Because if you even tried, I'd call bullshit. She's a *person*, and if you can't have even a little compassion for that, there isn't any helping you and you wouldn't deserve it. And if you want to know when the chief was going to tell you? As soon as Mayor Weaver stopped willfully hiding it. She's the one you should

be asking, because she’s the one keeping it under wraps. Adora tried to close the beaches and call the coast guard a month ago, but Weaver wouldn’t let her. So whatever happens here this summer, make sure you remember that fact at the next election, because Mayor Weaver does *not* have anyone’s interests at heart but her own.”

She sees Weaver as she walks away, but doesn’t give her even a glance.

Adora is right, arguing with her isn’t worth it.

She’s going to grab the few things that even remained in her hotel room after the days she’d spent with Adora, head to Adora’s house, and wait for her to call about Finn and Bow’s conditions.

***

The house is pretty quiet as all five inhabitants sit in the living room, cuddled up together where they'd moved after taking bites of their dinners. Catra had gotten everyone's orders for the local Italian restaurant, and everyone managed to eat at least half of their meals before putting the leftovers in the fridge. Finn and Bow look the most tired, having been in life threatening danger, but though they looked worse for wear, they were both fine. Adora is sitting on the couch right next to Bow with Finn in her lap, Catra to her other side, and Glimmer just on the other side of Bow. They normally didn’t all try to squeeze onto the little sofa, but there was a need that all of them had to keep each other close.

Each time Finn starts nodding off, they stir again, tucking their face further into Adora’s neck and shivering a little bit. Catra keeps rubbing up and down their back, while Adora strokes their hair and holds them close to her. It doesn’t take a lot of thinking to put together what was keeping them awake, the sight they couldn’t get out of their head.

But they do eventually fall asleep, and Adora carries them straight to her room. She puts them down in bed, and climbs in to tuck herself behind them. Then, Catra slots herself in right behind Adora, reaching around her to place a comforting hand on her stomach and the other right below Finn's head so she's cupping their cheek.

"Catra?" Adora whispers.

"Yeah?" She responds, slow and tinted with sleep.

"I'm gonna catch that shark. I'm going to get Weaver to hire Razz, and I really hope you'll come with me?"

It's silent for a second, a long pause, and then Catra squeezes Adora tighter.

"Of course I'm going with you, dummy."

Romantic Fishing Trip Pt. I

Word spread like wildfire that Weaver had something to do with the overall silence when it came to the shark, and by the end of the holiday weekend folks were sending her angry glares on the street, had called to have her car towed from the front of their businesses (where she normally parked illegally without issue), and she'd been certain they'd started to even upcharge her at stores. One person's testimony wouldn't normally have been enough for anything more than gossip and rumors, but the townspeople were getting desperate and looking for someone to blame. The way Adora was always at the beach, waiting to help? That seemed suspicious in a way that she knew what could happen and wanted to help when it did. But the way Weaver hung around the beach, following Adora all over town, and was far from the action when it actually happened? Well that was suspicious in a guilty sort of way.

All of this new behavior that showed that she was losing favor was compounded by their not so quiet whispers about the coming election, and the word 'impeachment' was floating around the older, more seasoned citizens.

Needless to say, Weaver was infuriated. And the only thing she could think to do, besides worm her way back into favor with a strategic and public apology, was to sign the ordinance that Adora slammed onto her desk on Monday morning.

Begrudgingly, she agreed to shell out the $50,000 that Razz had asked for to catch the shark, and Adora was on her way back to her own office to put her out of office message on her answering machine and then head home to take a few days off to prepare.

She finished her next project, her term project, and had been able to convince the professor to let her take the exam early, not knowing how long she would have to be away.

Glimmer and Bow were less than thrilled about her leaving, Bow more so since he'd seen the animal, but by far the worst reaction was from Finn.

They were still so scared, rightfully so. They'd even closed their window shades so they couldn't see the ocean, and taken down a few of their drawings of them and their family at the beach. They didn't leave Adora or Bow's side, was practically glued to at least one of them if not both.

It was all the more reason that Adora had to do this. She had to be sure it was finally going to be over, for them. She couldn't promise Finn, when they crawled into her bed after another nightmare, that things would be ok, if there was still a risk of them seeing a news headline of *another* shark attack.

She finds herself on the pier the crisp morning that she and Catra are to set out with Razz. A few contracted hands are loading Catra's more expensive equipment, a shark cage and a few air canisters, onto the boat, while Razz herself is at the helm flicking on the bilge pump and firing up the engines.

"Be careful Mommy?" Finn asks, holding on to her shoulders as she holds them up.

"I'll be careful baby. It's going to be ok. I just have to go help catch the shark, and then the water will be safe again and nobody else is going to get hurt," She soothes them.

They still look skeptical, so she adds, "Plus, Catra will be there to protect me. She's studied sharks her whole life! Remember at dinner the other night when she answered all your questions? She knows everything there is to know about them!"

That seems to placate them for now, and they give her one last kiss goodbye before she hands them off to Glimmer.

"Hey, be careful out there," Glimmer says, giving Adora a one armed hug.

“I'll be safe. Really. Make sure to get Finn to their appointment tomorrow? I hear this one is really good with kids and hopefully a professional can help them process everything,” She says.

Glimmer nods, turning around to head back to her car, and Adora feels Catra’s hand intertwine with her own.

“Hey, it’s going to be fine. I’ve been on whaling vessels this size, and there’s no way this thing is that big. We’ll be gone a few days, catch it, and be back before you know it,” Catra whispers, leaning her head on Adora’s shoulder. She rubs her face along the smooth merino wool of Adora’s long sleeved shirt, the soft material tickling the hairs along her hairline. The thin material, made to be breathable and protect her from the sun, was pulled tight over her muscular shoulders and biceps.

Adora tilts her head to the side to lean down and rest her head on the scratchy knit hat atop Catra’s head and sighs.

“I know. I just hate leaving them like this, so soon after everything. But I want this to be over, Razz doesn’t have a crew, and I really don’t trust anyone else to help her and not lie again about catching the shark. Plus, who knows how long it would take for Weaver to change her mind about the whole thing. This way, I take care of this, everyone is safe, and we can go back to worrying about normal things instead of who is going to die next.”

Catra hums, “And I guess I’d go back to the university?” She asks.

Adora raises an eyebrow, because that was clearly a question.

“I mean… Do you have to?” She asks.

The hope is there, Catra just needed to hear it herself before asking.

“Well I talked to the rest of the department… I don’t *need* to be back until the end of August when the semester starts and I start teaching classes,” She says.

Adora is silent for a moment, then says, “So you… You could stay? Would you stay?”

Catra circles around to face Adora, looking her right in the eyes and wrapping her arms around her waist.

“Yeah… And then… I mean I don’t have a problem with long distance if you don’t? And maybe when you finish school in December we can talk about what that means for us and where we live? My contract is yearly, January-December, and you’ll be applying for jobs somewhere else…” She trails off.

Adora brings her hand up to cup Catra’s cheek and rubs her thumb over her high, sharp cheekbone.

“We can talk about that when we get there, but for now, I want this. I want you. And we don’t have to decide right now, but I want you here for as long as I can have you. When the summer is over I can start using my vacation days, so maybe Finn and I could come down to see you for a weekend or two. It’ll work out if we work on it. And I don’t plan on letting you go that easily.”

Catra stands up on her toes, and Adora leans down, just in time to press their lips softly together. Their kisses were still just so gentle and tentative, a sweetness gracing their lips. Adora hadn't ever been kissed like that, like she was precious and fragile. She liked it.

“Ouch!” Adora jumps back, rubbing her head, and they both look to see Razz standing a few feet away with a broom in hand, pushing her giant glasses back up the bridge of her nose.

“No kissing! We’ve got a shark to catch!” She says, walking away to board her boat.

Adora and Catra follow, waving to Glimmer and Finn where they stand on the dock as they pull away and head out of the harbor.

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Adora gets seasick pretty fast, but after a couple of motion

sickness pills (that Catra had packed, luckily) and an hour or so laying down, she was climbing the stairs back up on deck from the cabin below. The cool, salty air helped clear her head, but she's nervous at the sight of the open ocean in front and behind them. The shore was just in the distance, because it wouldn't do any good to leave the shark's hunting area all together. So they chug along parallel to the shore around the southern tip of the island, and would be turning around at the sandbar to circle back if they got all the way there without sight of the shark.

It was pretty calm, a rocking motion throwing off her footing a little bit as she made her way to the aft where Catra and Razz sat.

Razz was on an old, *old*, chair. It's oxidized aluminum base extended into a pole that fit snugly into a corroded flange screwed into the worn wooden deck boards. The split leather of the cushions was a deep patina'd brown, though salt and sweat stained thin rings of it a crusty white. The boat itself also looked worse for wear, but judging by the assembly of engine fluids by the tool box Razz at least took care of it functionally, though it could use a wood sealer and a few coats of paint.

At the bottom of the fishing chair sat a foot rest with a base that was made to house a fishing rod. Sat in the base was a commercial fishing rod, a reel several inches in diameter attached to it's sleek black handle. Razz had her hand on it, lazily tugging every so often to see if there was a level of tension on the line that would indicate that something was caught on her hook. She was relaxed though, so there wasn't anything. Not yet, at least.

Catra sat on a plastic folding lawn chair, looking absolutely *perfect* as far as Adora was concerned.

She'd shed the denim jacket and had rolled up the sleeves of her linen shirt, revealing the wiry muscle of her forearm and those tattoos that wound their way up her smooth skin. Her hands were expertly twirling a rope between them, tying the knot with speed and expertise that made Adora stare in awe. Her posture was relaxed as she joked back and forth with the old woman, sharing

their battle scars from seaworthy adventures and their love for the ocean.

Adora felt bad for a moment, that she wouldn't ever have something that exciting to share, but shook that thought from her head. When they got back to shore with the shark in tow, she'd have a story like that of her own.

But then, Adora finds herself hoping something else, hoping that Finn gets this excited about their future, about what they study. She hopes that Catra is around to teach them to tie knots and catch fish, treat sea life and the ocean with the respect that it deserves. She sees future trips to the beach, to the aquarium, where Finn points at something and Catra answers every question they ever had about it.

She hopes, and hopes, and *hopes* that she sees it come true.

"Hey Adora, feeling better?" Catra asks, looking toward her.

She stumbles for a second with a particularly unexpected wave, but manages to catch herself on a rung of the ladder going up to the helm. She kicks over one of the air cylinders from Catra's stash of scuba gear, the metallic clang as it rolled a few feet away echoing off of the wood of the boat. Catra bends down to catch it, giving her a look.

"Me? Psh yeah, I'm fine! Great! I was just um, yeah getting my footing… you know?" Adora tries weakly, wincing.

"You gotta be careful princess. You screw around with this compressed air and it's gonna blow up," She says.

"Right! Right yeah, I should um- we wouldn't want that would we," Adora stutters out, rubbing the back of her head.

Catra returns to her seat and picks up the rope she'd been holding. Adora stands there awkwardly, not really sure what to do.

“Well, when you get your sea legs, come on over here and I’ll teach you some of my *favorite* knots,” Catra says, winking.

Adora blushes so hard she’s worried the capillaries in her face are going to burst, but their moment is interrupted.

“Not time for knots! Time to chum!” Razz says, hopping up out of her seat.

Catra throws Adora a sympathetic look, and she knows that whatever ‘chumming’ is, it’s her job for the trip.

Sure enough, Razz pops up again, seemingly out of nowhere, with a five gallon bucket full of *god knows what* and a large scoop.

“Start tossing this overboard, Mara dearie, we have a shark to catch!” She says, leaping onto the chair once more and pulling a large sun hat over her face.

Adora shrugs and moves toward the aft, scooping up some of the sludge of fish goop and tossing it into the water.

“You gonna release the guns? Or do we need tickets?” Catra says, sideling up next to her and doing her best to distract her.

Adora grunts as she tosses another shovel full over the back of the boat, covering her nose.

“You need tickets to the gun show, but you get a free pass if you take over shoveling this shit for me,” She says, voice nasally from her plugged nostrils.

Catra laughs, clapping her hand on Adora’s shoulder.

“Sorry babe, but it’s your first fishing trip. You have the honor of chumming the water. It’s a right of passage. And also… I mean I’m not gonna do it.”

Adora sighs, tossing out some more, and turns to face Catra.

She’s smirking, but she’s looking down at the rope in her hands while she casually ties another knot. Adora can’t really focus on much more than that, honestly. While she hadn’t done any practice, she’d spent nights awake researching *those* kinds of activities with *those* kinds of… materials.

“No flirting! We have a shark to catch!” Razz shouts from the helm. Adora, startled, looks between the seat next to her that Razz had occupied moments ago, and where she stood across the deck and up the ladder, and wonders *how* she keeps *doing that*.

But when she looks back at Catra, she looks just as surprised and maybe a little annoyed at the old woman’s agility. Still, she looks back at Adora and shrugs, returning to her chair to keep practicing her knots.

Adora scoops another shovel full of chum and tosses the foul smelling stuff into the water. When she does, she hears a sound behind her, gurgling and splashing, like the waves are disrupted by something, something big. She whips around and sees it.

The eyes, one a void black and the other a pink and irritated haze from where Bow had stabbed it, a mouth so large she fears it’s big enough to swallow at least a person whole without them even touching the teeth, and row upon row of jagged bone leading down into the vast and dark nothingness of it’s throat and stomach, is the sight that greets her when she gets her very first glimpse of the shark. She hadn’t seen it up close before, had just barely seen it’s massive dorsal fin as it cut through the water on the way into the inlet as she dashed over the footbridge. The leathery and dimpled skin was a deep grey-blue, while the underside was a stark white. Deep scars littered it’s face and body, from boat propellers and coral reefs, or perhaps the fishing knives of any of it’s victims that weren’t as lucky as Bow.

She stands up straight, dropping the shovel to the deck in her shock, and backs away. Catra notices she’s moved, and steps forward to see what it is.

Catra freezes too, shocked at the sheer size of the shark. It was massive, surely longer than anything on record. She pulls the GoPro in it's waterproof case out of her pocket to snap a quick picture. If she got lucky, she'd snap a picture of it next to something for reference, or they'd get it back to shore and she would be able to get measurements of it. She feels guilt pang in her chest at the fact that she was getting so excited over an animal that killed so many people, but discovery was always something to be excited about.

As it ducks back below the water and swims off, circling the boat in a large path, Adora looks over at Catra.

"We're gonna need a bigger boat," She says.

Catra, watching it as it's massive body parts the water around it in it's speed, can't help but agree.

Razz throws the engines into forward and engages the throttle, pushing it to follow the thing as it swam in a large swath around them. It's a jarring motion, sending Adora off her feet and slamming her hip into the side of the boat as she tries to catch herself.

"Chief! Get up here!" Razz shouts as she already descends the ladder.

Adora gets up and sprints to the helm, fast as she can, and takes control of the boat.

But she doesn't really know how to drive a boat. She sees the gear, and sees the throttle, and can assume what they do, but it still seems like way too many switches and way too many controls.

Razz grabs her harpoon gun and walks to the front of the boat.

"Dr. Hooper!" She shouts back.

Catra reaches into her bag, grabbing one of the tracking devices she had grabbed from the research lab in the hopes of getting to use it, and slides along the narrow walkway to the bow of the boat, next to the large yellow barrels there, and catches the rope that Razz tosses her.

"Tie this to one of the barrels! Hurry! Before we lose it!"

Catra leans down and loops the rope around the cable screwed into the plastic barrel and clips the tracking device to it, shouting, "Don't wait for me! Take the shot!"

Razz looks back at where Catra is tying the knot, faster than she thought the college kid would, and then back to where the shark is quickly losing them. She doesn't want to shoot yet, because if she does and Catra isn't ready, the rope is going to rip through her skin and destroy her hands, and that isn't something she wants to do.

But the shark was getting away.

So Razz turns to shout up to the helm.

"Chief! Hard Port! Take us up to 2500!"

"Um, yeah I don't know what that means?" Adora shouts.

Catra yells back, "Port is left, grab the throttle and push it up until the RPM gauge is at 2500! Gently!" She's almost through with the knot, just one more loop to feed the working end through and she's good to go.

"Don't wait for me! Take the shot!" She shouts again.

As they get up to speed, Razz sees it, a clear shot right at the shark as they finally swing close enough.

And she trusts Catra to know what she's doing.

She fires the harpoon gun, landing the sharp end deep into the shark’s skin right on it’s back, and the rope snaps taut. Catra finishes the knot, letting go and snapping her hands away just in time for it to get dragged overboard and plop down into the water. Her heart is hammering with the speed she'd had to work, a shaky excitement on her tingling hands as she grins.

This was what she'd wanted. This was the adventure she'd been missing, what she'd been looking for. She was *alive* and she was out on a fishing boat hunting a shark larger than any Great White ever recorded.

But a calmness also settled over her, because part of her felt like she didn't need it anymore now that she saw adventure when she looked at Adora, when she looked at Finn.

They all wait, bated breath.

Granted, Adora didn’t really know what the barrel was for, but Catra and Razz seemed to be waiting for something.

“Take us back down to 1800 Chief! Steady ahead!” Razz says as she leans on the railing.

The shark has disappeared below the water, but the barrel bobs up and down as it swings around in another large circle, and Adora guesses what it’s for.

“Does the barrel slow it down?” She asks.

Catra nods. “Yeah, it keeps it close to the surface, tires it out.”

But then something unexpected happens.

The barrel disappears.

And it doesn’t resurface.

***

If Catra is going to be the knot-tier and Razz is the harpoon-shooter, then that made Adora the boat-driver, so she sees it necessary for Catra to give her a crash course in the terminology she'd need. In the quiet afternoons as they continue putting up and down the coast, Catra teaches her everything she'd need to know about steering the vessel.

They hadn't seen the shark or caught its tracking device on the radar in the hours since, even as they continued chumming in the heart of it's feeding grounds. As the sun began to set, Razz declared that they needed someone to keep watch. Their anchor was in, keeping them in place for the night while the engines were shut off, but she thought it best to look out for the shark. Only searching for it during the day, when it was equally, if not more, active at night was a mistake. So at first sight of it, whoever was keeping watch was to wake the other two and prepare to go on the offensive.

Catra took first watch when the sun fell, electing to stay up on the helm with a book and her thoughts to keep her company. She'd always liked nights like this, where it was just chilly enough to be comfortable adding a sweater beneath her jacket and a knit hat on her head. Nights where it was calm and quiet, the full moon streaking across the water and lighting up the boat like there was nothing in the universe except for Catra, the vessel, and the stars, would always run a shiver down her spine.

She loved the ocean, the earth, the stars. She'd always loved the feeling they gave her.

She wasn't religious in the slightest. But sometimes the thought, the *feeling* struck her that her mother was one of those stars, shining so brightly in the sky that she could pick it out over all of the others. Her father was never far away, a lesser star in the same constellation. He was always searching for her, revolving around her, worshipping and loving her the most he'd ever loved anyone.

It was what she remembered the most about them. Sure, her memories centered around their love for the ocean and the time they spent there. But the way her father loved her mother? That was something to be inspired by. That was an old and deep magic, lost to the cosmos as far as she knew. It was a rare love that she hadn't seen since, but that she longed for more than anything.

But that was before Adora, and she could feel that love returning to her. She'd always been impatient, but was finally realizing that some things were worth waiting for when you couldn't go after them. And that same old magic that strung her parents together, wove her soul to theirs though they were lost so long ago, ran through her and Adora too.

She hears footsteps, metallic clanging as rubber soles make contact with the ladder, and waits for Adora to join her.

"Hey Adora. You should be asleep," She says, though she gets up to meet her half way.

"I know, I just couldn't. I'm too…" She trails off.

Catra nods her understanding, leading Adora by the hand over to the captain's chair and making her plop down. She then snuggles into her side, half on her lap even though the chair is double wide and could easily fit the both of them.

"It's just too exciting, is that it? Trust me, the first trip is like that. When I went out with my dad I was too excited to sleep. He'd lay me down in the cabin and I would say *"Papa the ocean is awake, so I'm awake."* It's so full of life, you know? And even if you can't see them it's like you can feel that there is life below you. It's like… like."

"Like every form of evolution is taking place below you, how could you sleep when there are still dinosaurs down there?" Adora supplies.

“Exactly!” Catra exclaims, excited. She never really had a partner who understood just how much the ocean had to give, how much it had to study.

They sit there for a while before Adora speaks up.

“So, why did you decide on marine biology?” She asks.

Catra takes a breath, going over the story in her mind.

It didn’t leave a lot to the imagination, because there wasn’t a single part of the story of her present, and her future, that wasn’t tarnished by details of the tragedy of her past. It was either open up entirely and tell Adora the truth, the real truth, in all its gory detail, or try to skirt around any real part of it at all.

She doesn’t think it would be very fair to do that, because Adora, while not sharing a lot about her past, had certainly shared a lot about her feelings now. So she goes with the tragic backstory, her villain arc, and her dramatic realization and awakening to the possibilities of a future that didn’t hurt quite as much.

“Well, I always loved the ocean. We went a lot when I was a kid, my parents loved it. They took me for at least a week, every month of the summer. It was how they decorated their house, what they planned family gatherings around, the reason they bought a truck with 4 wheel drive, so they could take it out on the sand. They met when they were both out on surf trips with friends, actually. When I think about my childhood, I don’t have a single memory that doesn’t revolve around the ocean. My dad would take me on fishing trips, teach me to boogie board. Before I could even walk he would hold me up on the very edge of the water, watching me giggle while the water tickled my feet. My mother would make a bonfire or drag the grill out of the bed of the truck and roast hotdogs, barbecue chicken. Then she'd filet and cook the fish my dad caught. She’d take me to the tide pools and we’d look at the little fish and sand crabs. But when my parents passed away I didn’t go again until high school. Both

because I couldn't afford it and because I didn't know if I wanted to go without them."

She pauses, remembering them. Their faces pop into her mind now and again, but instead of pain, she feels pride and love, tinted with just a touch of longing and sadness.

"When they first… yeah… I tried to avoid thinking about them at all costs, because it just hurt so much. I didn't know if I could handle doing something that has memories so firmly attached to them, you know?" She says.

Adora nods solemnly, "Yeah, I know."

Catra knew that Adora had spent her fair share of time alone, that she had experienced loss and grief as well, and reached down to squeeze her thigh.

"But then in high school, a few friends wanted to go to the beach. I was really shitty to them, to be honest. It was right after I got removed from the only good foster home I'd ever been in, because the dad got too sick to keep taking care of an extra kid. I was tired of everyone I loved leaving me, and pushed the rest away. One of them told me when I was being a bad friend, and it knocked me on my ass, but made me realize what I was doing, the self destructive spiral I was in. So even though I had barely enough from my part time job, I went with them."

She stares ahead at the water, smiling at the memory. Her eyes are a little misty, and Adora sits ready to reach out and wipe a tear off of her cheek, should it choose to fall.

Catra clears her throat and says, "I cried for the first couple of hours, sitting there under the umbrella with my sunglasses on. Everyone let me be after I told them that it was fine, that it was just the memories. I couldn't think of anything but my parents and the life we shared, the life they lost, the one I lost too that day. But I stood up and went to the edge of the water, saw the dolphins swimming in the distance, and noticed something."

“What's that?” Adora asks.

“It hurt, but it wasn’t the same. It was a longing, a remembering, but it wasn’t the stabbing I thought it would be. I missed them, but it didn’t hurt the way it used to. It always hurt, and it always would, but looking out on the ocean that day, it’s like I could breathe again. Like a part of me that I didn’t know was gone had returned to me. And that part was different, because my parents were always there. But now that they weren’t, what better way to remember them than to look out at the water and see my father holding me above the waves, or my mother on her surfboard. So I kept going back to the beach, little day trips here and there, and when I went alone I’d walk along and see things I didn’t see before, like crabs and jellyfish, sure, but tidepools with anemones and urchins and squid.”

“I was fascinated, and I wanted to spend every waking moment in that place where I could see the family we used to be so clearly in my mind. So I studied marine biology at a school on the ocean, and I’d get to go out and talk to them while I did lab projects. I’d imagine all of the things I could talk to them about, all of the things they’d be proud of me for.”

Her voice cracks, and Adora indeed finds herself reaching up to wipe away a tear.

“That’s beautiful, Catra. I’m… God I’m so happy that you found that again, that you got back something you lost even if it was just a tiny fraction of it. I bet they’d be…. I bet they *are* so proud of you,” Adora whispers, choked up and voice full of that same longing.

“I miss them, and sometimes I regret choosing a field that reminds me so much of them, but at the same time I am still so happy that I don’t have a chance to forget. You know? Some people cope, move on, and they spend days without thinking about it until something jolts their memory. I don’t ever want to forget them, forget where I came from or who loved me the most.”

Adora turns her nose down into Catra's neck and breathes in the sandalwood scent she finds there, pressing herself closer to her soft skin.

"I worried for so long, when I realized I was trans, that they would have been disappointed. But I had so much time to think. I thought about how much they loved me, how proud they always were, and how they always told me to be myself because I was the greatest gift they were ever given, so being myself was what they wanted more than anything. And the guilt of transitioning, changing my pronouns, changing the name they gave me, all went away. Because I know they love me, know that they would never want me to be someone I'm not just for the memory of what used to be."

It's quiet as they sit there, Catra's words echoing in both of their heads.

They both knew what it was like to have a family ripped away from them, to wonder whether the parents they knew would be proud of the people they'd become.

Adora pulls Catra closer, and starts to whisper.

"Fly me to the moon, and let me play among the stars."

Catra is silent for a second before turning into Adora's embrace and in turn whispering, "Let me see what Spring is like on Jupiter and Mars."

"In other words, hold my hand," Adora sings, staring out at the moon reflecting off of the glittering blackness of the ocean. She reaches for Catra's hand, and she intertwines their fingers.

"In other words, baby, kiss me," Catra chokes out.

Adora turns her head and kisses Catra on the forehead, though that's not really what she wants. She can't be mad though, at the love Adora pours into it. Adora breathes her in, the smell of her

hair, the smell of her lotion, and it's all she can do not to melt at the way she touches her, the way she feels her.

"Fill my heart with song and let me sing forever more," Adora sings.

Her voice goes gravely as she wills Catra to feel what she means, what she feels.

"You are all I long for, all I worship and adore," She says, kissing her way up Catra's neck.

It makes Catra gasp, to feel Adora's breath against her, to feel her lips so desperate and gentle on her neck.

"In other words, please be true," Catra says, tilting her head to reveal more of her neck for Adora to kiss. To take. To worship.

She wants to give all of herself for Adora to kiss and love and hold.

"In other words, I love you," Adora finally says, finally whispering in the wind so softly that she's sure it's the sea breeze playing tricks on her, a siren song stealing her soul and devouring her whole.

That's what it feels like when she's with Adora. She feels like she's floating, however temporarily. But she knows that with Adora, the passion doesn't come with a down side, it doesn't come with pain. She knows that whatever this is, however fast it's moving when it isn't supposed to, that Adora wouldn't hurt her.

So she leans up and kisses her, pressing her lips to Adora's slow and soft at first. It isn't the first time that they've kissed, but with every new exploration of her mouth, Catra feels like she needs ten times more. She feels like she's desperately clinging to Adora with everything that she is because she needs this feeling. Catra needs this feeling of being wanted so fiercely, so desperately, like Adora can't breathe without her, can't live without touching her. She

wants Adora to put her hands anywhere, everywhere, and she needs that same thing too.

She puts her hands on Adora's hips, pulling her closer so hard she almost falls out of the chair, but her mouth never leaves Adora's. Their teeth click together and bite, lazily bruising swollen lips. Catra pushes her hands up under Adora's shirt, scratching up the smooth skin of her sides, over the plane of her abs, back down to tease at the waistband of her underwear. When they reach up, Catra expects her fingers to hit her binder or a sports bra. She isn't sure which Adora had elected to wear today, but her brain all of a sudden remembers that Adora had been trying to sleep earlier just as her fingers brush the undersides of her breasts.

Adora gasps, and Catra pulls back to look at her.

"You're so fucking beautiful," She says, running her hands back down and withdrawing them from Adora's shirt, lifting them up to rest over her strong shoulders.

"I meant it," Adora says, leaning forward to rest her head on Catra's collar bone.

"Meant what?" She asks, running her fingers through the silky short strands of Adora's hair.

"I love you, I do. I know it's early, but I love you so much already. And I know it might not be realistic to say I'm *in love* with you yet, but I'm falling so hard. And it's so scary, but I want to keep falling for you."

Catra thinks on that.

She's fallen hard, too. And she knows that it might be a disaster waiting to happen to declare her love for Adora, but she also knows that no matter what direction their relationship goes in, she wants it all, as long as it's with Adora.

"I love you too. And I know it's scary, because I'm so scared too, but I want this and I want it with you."

They stay like that, holding each other, as they listen to the waves lap gently at the hull of the boat, feel the rocking motion lulling them into a peaceful rhythm. The moonlight, full and crisp, glitters a streak across the water as the stars twinkle in it’s glassy reflective surface.

Catra looks up at the sky and seeks out that same constellation, the stars she knows to be her mother and father, and smiles that even though they were gone, at least a part of them still got to watch her fall in love.

Romantic Fishing Trip Pt. II

Catra continued her watch into the night, letting Adora sleep pressed up against her side on that tiny captain's chair. She looks up at the stars, tracing those same constellations and then closing her eyes to see them burned into the lids from memory while she feels the slow and measured breath of the person next to her.

The ocean was always in flux, never ceasing it's churning motion, but on the surface it all felt so still. There was nothing around, nothing to distract her or draw her attention. It was one of her favorite things about being out on the ocean. The discovery, being in the presence of sheer, unadulterated possibility, was a draw all it's own. But the meditative peace was unparallelled. The escape was immeasurable. She'd always hoped to share this feeling with someone, the feeling that time stood still and let you catch up to all of the emotions that had been at war inside of you.

Sometime in the early hours of the morning, when the sea was calm and the earth stopped spinning, where she was sure that if she looked down at her watch the hands wouldn't be moving either, Adora woke up to give Catra a chance to sleep. They switch positions, Adora lounging with her feet out on the dashboard and Catra leaned up against her side. It was a peace she hadn't known. Not even before Finn had she been able to achieve this level of relaxation. But now that she was a mom, nights were for sleeping, and if she was ever awake it was usually because Finn was sick or she had too much work on her plate to rest.

But this? This was simple. All she had to do was keep a look out for a blip on the radar that would signify the shark's tracking device, and make sure they stayed afloat. Other than that, she was left to absentmindedly run her fingers up and down Catra's arm, tugging at the fraying seams of her jacket sleeve as she went. She feels the warm puffs of breath on her neck, tickling the fine hairs around her ear and jaw, goosebumps erupting along her arms at the feeling of being this close to someone.

This swell of emotion, out here in the first quiet night she'd had in 7 years, was just so profound to her. And what was more is that, while Adora missed Finn terribly, she thinks that being here with Catra is enough for her.

It has to be something about the ocean, something in the peaceful rocking, the moonlight and stars, that brings that feeling to her.

She hadn't ever seen the sun rise over the ocean, in spite of living on the island for a few months now. When her shift was early, she made it to the station and was well into paperwork before the sky awoke. If work started later, she was far too busy getting breakfast ready for Finn and doing a few chores or maybe an assignment. The trips they'd taken to the beach for vacation were spent sleeping in as late as she could before she began the task of getting Finn ready and carrying their various sandcastle making tools down to the beach.

So when she sees the sunrise this morning, she can't believe she's done herself the disservice of never seeing it like this before. Golden sunlight streaks over the horizon, a cascade of cotton candy pastels paint over those stars and speckle the water in a shimmering line. It washes over Adora's skin, it's warmth waking her up, and she looks down to see the way it looks on Catra's peaceful face.

The outline of each individual hair turns gold as it curls tightly in on itself, and Adora can just make out the red undertones of her skin in the warm, amber hue. It's just another thing she hadn't gotten to see, another state of being she hadn't yet seen Catra in. But like every new thing she notices, she hopes that she never stops finding things to discover about her.

"What did I say about flirting?"

Adora looks up to see Razz standing on deck, in that same purple and pink dress with her hands on her hips and a basket hanging from her wrist.

"Now, get something to eat. We have a shark to catch!" She says, suddenly swinging the basket in her arm and tossing it haphazardly up to Adora.

She lunges for it, knocking Catra's head with her elbow and barely stopping herself from falling down by catching herself on the ladder. She does manage to stick a hand out and the handle of the basket lops itself over her outstretched arm.

"Wow, good morning to you too I guess," Catra grumbles, rubbing her head and looking over the side of the chair to raise an eyebrow at Adora.

"Sorry! Sorry Razz said 'breakfast' and I jumped because… well… food?" She says, sounding timid.

She reaches into the basket, below the blue and white checkered tea towel, and finds a blueberry muffin. She reaches out, grinning in triumph.

Catra softens and takes the muffin, turning back to sit up on the chair.

Adora pulls out another muffin for herself and even finds a thermos of fresh coffee in the bottom of the basket. She sits next to Catra, wrapping an arm around her shoulder and taking a bite.

Razz doesn't even mention that they'd clearly gone back to 'flirting,' but then again, she'd pretty much handed them the makings of a romantic picnic.

"I hope we catch this thing before we run out of pasta and baked goods. I saw those cans of beans and I don't know how things will go for me. Plus like… I need vegetables," Catra says, reaching for the thermos and clicking it open to take a sip of the coffee.

Adora snorts, "I've never seen a hot bitch without IBS."

Catra throws her head back laughing, and it strikes her that she's probably already laughed with Adora more than she's laughed

with anyone else.

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I'm never touching another dead fish for the rest of my life, Adora thinks as she chucks another scoop full of chum over the side of the boat.

Not that it wasn't fun, just the best time, but she was hoping to have a less stinky role on this trip if she was being honest. Then again, she hadn't ever been on a fishing boat, or fishing at all for that matter, so maybe that was just wishful thinking.

After they'd gone down to the cabin to change clothes and get ready for the day, Catra and Adora had met up on the deck by Razz's fishing chair. The old woman didn't even make a fuss when they hugged *and* kissed before parting ways to get to their jobs for the day.

It seemed that she couldn't resist the pull of romance, even as a bystander. And Adora had a feeling that Razz didn't actually mind too much that they continued "fraternizing" and "flirting" on her fishing boat.

Adora couldn't wipe the grin off of her face all morning, even as she chucked the seemingly bottomless bucket of chum over the stern of the boat while Razz observed from her old chair and Catra drove. The churning, frothing water behind them mixed with the deep reds and purples of the leftover fish… parts… into a pink swirling tail that followed the boat as it made its course back north. Time passed quickly as she zoned out, continuing her task and allowing herself to be hypnotized by crimson swirling into the bubbling, frothing wake of the vessel, and seeing how far out the pink tail ran before it disappeared in the glittering seafoam.

She's so focused, so zoned out, that Catra's shout is jarring.

"I see it! Off the starboard bow!"

Adora turns around, climbing up the rail toward the bow. Razz does the same, carrying her harpoon gun.

Sure enough there it is, a bobbing yellow barrel being tugged by what they can safely assume is the shark, swimming in their direction.

Catra swings hard starboard to steer out of it's way, pushing the throttle forward until they're chugging along at a brisk speed, faster than the lazy motion they'd had before. The engines protest, like they always do, but this time she stays up at the helm and doesn't call for Adora to take over.

She'd been sure to fix a rope to each of the remaining barrels so they didn't have another close call like they did yesterday, and that meant that instead of Adora driving while interpreting the instructions being shouted at her, Catra would have the knowledge and experience to drive while taking directions from Razz far quicker than Adora could.

And that left Adora as support.

None of them knew just how soon they'd need that third person on board.

Razz takes the shot as they pass by the shark, the harpoon hitting her target and as the barrel flies out of it's cage and into the water, they pass by the shark. Adora stares down into that pitch black eye, takes in the sight of it's massive body and it's horrific rows of teeth.

It disappears below the surface, taking both barrels with it in a display of strength she can tell even Razz hasn't seen, and the water goes calm for a moment.

Catra looks at the radar, detecting the receiver, and still see's the blip on the green screen.

"It's under the boat," Razz says, calmly. But it's still eerie and foreboding the way she says it.

Catra curses, and Adora can only imagine what could happen if it resurfaced now.

The barrels and line could get caught up in the propellers, but that wasn't the worst of it.

The worst of it comes a second later when a sharp, splintering crack resonates and the boat lurches. It's enough to throw Adora off of her feet, catching herself on the fishing chair, though she still hits her head. The sharp pain reverberated around her head for a second while she pinched her eyes closed, but she understood the shouting just the same.

"Where did it hit us?" Catra says.

"Below deck! The galley!" Razz responds, heading down to see the damage.

Adora feels the boat slow, Catra probably pulling the throttle back and shifting it into neutral.

In a second she's right next to Adora, helping her stand with a hand on her back and the other on her elbow.

"Adora? You ok?" She asks.

Adora nods, the motion shooting a throb through her head.

"Yeah. How bad is it?" She asks.

Catra looks her over, taking in the tear in her jeans and the slight amount of blood on her forehead.

"Your head is bleeding a little, but you don't look too bad other than that," Catra says, already across the deck pulling a box of bandaids out of the first aid kit.

"No, how bad is the hull? Can we keep going?" Adora asks.

Catra pauses.

"You just fell and hit your head, miles from shore and a hospital, and you want to know how the *boat* is doing? So we can keep going?"

Adora stops.

"Ok yeah I know how that sounds, but boats can *sink* and we're miles from shore if it does. So yeah, I'm a little worried about how this ancient death trap is doing."

Catra nods, sighing, "I… I know. You just, you never care about *you* Adora, you always just care about other people. You keep saying "no one else gets hurt" but when do you stop and care that *you* could get hurt? You do everything for everyone else, but what do you *want* to do Adora?"

Her expression is pained, and Catra regrets it immediately. Not because it was unnecessary, but because right now definitely wasn't the time to bring up Adora's abysmal self worth and her need to protect everyone else.

Adora opens her mouth to say something but Razz's muffled voice filters out through the cabin.

"Chief! Get in here and start plugging this hole! We're catching this shark today!"

She sighs, turning back to Catra.

"We'll talk about it later but… I know you're right, but this isn't the time."

Catra nods, and Adora squeezes her hand before she walks away to see what she can do.

There is water on the floor, about an inch of it, and Razz rushes past her to head up, yelling "Plug the damage with whatever you can! No time to waste there dearie!"

She finds a few cans of flex seal, spray on rubber, and thinks that maybe they'd hold, but then catches sight of several cans of spray foam insulation and tries her hand filling the larger gaps with that. It's messy work, the thick, sticky foam coming out in clumps as she fills it in between the seeping boards. The impact happened in the draft, the portion of the hull below the water line, but it was close enough to the surface that depending on the direction they were going and the way the waves slapped against the hull, the water came in intervals that allowed Adora to fire more of the foam into the gaps and then when she felt the boat rock in the other direction she'd hold a board over it to keep the foam in place.

Above, Catra fires the engines back on and swings the boat in the direction that the blip on the radar moved, due south toward the edge of the sandbar.

"We'll trap it along the sandbar and it won't have anywhere to go but toward shore, then when it's stuck there, we'll fire the larger harpoons," Razz says, setting up her gun to fire the third barrel.

She gets to the very tip of the bow, the pulpit extending out over the water, and rides there on the lookout.

"Take us to 2000 RPM Dr. Hooper!" She shouts.

Catra does, the engines struggling to get up in speed as she pushes the throttle forward. It's steady though, and as they start to cut through the waves faster, they get closer to the barrels that had resurfaced.

"5° west Dr. Hooper!"

Catra turns, using the compass on the dashboard to determine the 5°. The shark is dead ahead, but in spite of the two barrels it's already burdened with, it still seems like it's going faster than them. And the further ahead of them it gets, the slimmer their chances of hitting it with another.

"2500 Dr. Hooper!"

Catra grabs the throttle, gritting her teeth as she pushes it forward slower than she had been accelerating before as the engine whines. She can feel that it's lurching, trying to propel them forward faster than it can handle. By the time the gauge gets to 2200 RPM, the engines shiver with the effort, and Catra pauses her acceleration.

"Hooper!" Razz shouts again, bringing her gun up to rest the butt on her shoulder, looking through the sight.

Catra closes her eyes and prays it even works, thrusting her hand forward. The gauge revs up, shooting around to 2500 RPM while the engines choke and sputter, smoke starting to billow out of the engine room.

Below deck, Adora has just gotten what she thinks is an acceptable amount of spray foam and flex seal over the splintered boards. She'd sprayed enough to cover them and then used a hammer she'd found to nail down a spare piece of plywood tightly over the chunk of the hull that was damaged. Enough foam squeezes out the sides that she thinks it's done it's job, and has sprayed enough of the black, rubberized sealant to keep them from taking on water.

Too much water, at least.

She's pouring sweat, taking off her flannel to cool herself down, and runs her sticky hand through her hair to brush it off of her face, which she immediately regrets. The spray insulation stuck to her hair was the least of her problems, though.

Just as she stands, she smells a metallic sort of burning, and looks to see thick, black smoke coming out of the engine room. She runs up on deck, grabbing a fire extinguisher just in case, and shouts up to Catra.

"What's going on?"

"Hey there princess! Oh you know, just seeing what it takes to turn this internal combustion engine into an *external* combustion

engine!” Catra shouts back, throwing a toothy grin over her shoulder.

Adora chuckles, shoulders shaking, though she can see the tension in Catra’s posture. She can see the skepticism in her eyes and the anticipation as well.

She climbs up to the helm, trying to fight the blush on her face when Catra looks at her biceps as the white t-shirt hugs them.

“What can I do?” She asks.

“Hooper! Hard port!” Razz’s shout interrupts them.

She swings the wheel, turning hand over hand until they've almost swung in a quarter of a circle, and they come upon the shark right alongside the bow where Razz shoots and finally makes contact with the beast.

The third barrel that they’ve attached to this thing rockets off the side of the boat and joins the others as the shark swims away, but they’ve allowed it to get out from between them and the shore and it’s now heading out to sea, away from the island.

Catra curses under her breath, hoping this third barrel is enough to tire it out. She’s tired of the game it seems to be playing with them. Because if it wasn’t trying to play with them, it would have swam away, far north or maybe even out to sea, and they would be searching without a sign for it in the vast open water. But no, it was playing with them. It was doing this on purpose. It was so strange and out of character for a shark that she couldn’t even fathom why it would be acting this way.

“Due east Hooper! We’ve got it now!”

They follow it out to sea, but when Catra hears the engine pop and turns to see the barrels disappear below the water, she pushes the throttle down and kills the engine.

It’s gone. It’s just gone, and all three of them are in disbelief that it could drag all three barrels below the water.

“Let's see what we can do about these engines,” Razz says, seemingly undeterred.

Adora jumps, the sudden appearance of the old woman right next to her, when she’d been on the very tip of the bow, once again rockets her into heart palpitations.

Razz lifts up the hatch, the trapped smoke in the engine compartment floating out. It’s thick and black, and they wait for it to dissipate before Razz jumps down and Catra follows her.

“Mara dearie, there’s a toolbox behind the ladder. Grab it for us and bring it here, will you?”

Adora sighs.

That isn’t her name, at all, but they had bigger things to worry about than the fact that occasionally Razz forgot her name.

She grabs the toolbox, sitting it on the edge of the compartment, and opens it.

“What do you need?” She asks.

Adora passes tools and cans of lubricant down to Catra and Razz as they start repairing the things they can tell are broken, fittings that have melted, parts that are warped from overheating, a couple of hoses that had been steadily dry rotting and split under the strain.

The engines might be shot for now, but at least they’re not taking on water anymore.

As they make their repairs, all three listen out for the radar, but they don’t hear a thing.

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“Strap wrench?”

Adora puts the handle of the strap wrench directly into Catra’s hand and watches it retreat.

“Mara dearie there’s a hose clamp in the bottom of the toolbox, give me that and a flat head screwdriver,” Razz says, her thin, frail hand reaching up.

Adroa hands her both of the things she’d asked for, and goes back to listening out for the radar and looking around for any sign of the shark or the barrels.

“The radar is cool. It’s like that scene in Jurassic Park 3, where they know where that dinosaur is because they hear the guy’s phone ringing in it’s stomach.”

Razz and Catra poke their heads out, looking at Adora each with a single raised eyebrow and a distinct lack of amusement on their faces.

She just puts her hands up in surrender, chuckling awkwardly, and they go back to making the repairs. Evidently a movie where people get eaten by a wild animal isn't on the list of approved topics for this particular fishing trip.

Soon, though, they’re climbing out to give the engines a test run. Razz climbs up to the helm and grabs the keys while Catra stays on deck looking down into the compartment to try to see any leaks or smoke.

The first that they try, the port engine, backfires the first time she tries to start it, followed by the cranking of the engine turning over. It cranks and cranks, Catra holding her breath as the time between turnovers increases until it stops all together.

It would be difficult, because of the positioning, but if the starboard engine starts they would at least be able to hobble back to shore. Right now with neither engine working, they were just

adrift. Razz leaves the port engine's key in the off position and switches to the starboard.

The engine cranks for long enough that they're ready to give up, turning over weakly a dozen or so times.

They all exhale a frustrated sigh, except for Razz who looked strangely optimistic.

But then, against all hope, the engine roared to life. It choked and sputtered along the way, emitting that same suffocating black smoke before calming to a struggling hum with minimal fanfare.

It's the most relieved Adora has felt since she heard the splintering crack of the hull breach earlier today, or the fearful way Catra looked at her when the engines started smoking. Out on the open ocean with nothing to see but the silvery horizon, the relief that they could at least head toward shore was palpable.

"I'll head west toward the island," Catra says, jumping to action and heading toward the ladder.

"Excellent idea dearie! We'll get fuel, and head back out! We've almost got it," Razz says, going over to the engine hatch and closing it.

"You mean, we'll get fuel, *repair the boat*, and head back out, right?" Catra says.

"Of course, of course! Well you do that and I'll get the old rod out and catch us up something to eat! We'll need lunch after all that work! Maybe later we'll bake a pie!"

Catra turns the wheel until they're facing west, shifting gear forward.

She looks at Adora, and Adora looks at her.

They both shrug.

Razz simply wasn't to be understood, that much they were certain. The woman was amazing and loveable and wonderful, but had a way of thinking that was all her own, like she was jumping between timelines and conversations. The undeniable charm about her was enchanting.

There were certainly worse people to be stuck out on a fishing boat with.

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Making it back to shore on a single engine turned out to be slower going than they'd hoped. It was well into the afternoon by the time they saw land, and even then, it was far south. Most of the population of the island lived on the northeast quadrant, the rest of the land made up a state park that couldn't be developed.

Adora, safe from her previous task of chumming, sat up next to Catra as she drove with Razz napping below.

"I must have read through that same section of code for hours, and then when I finally gave up and sent it to my professor, she identified immediately that I was missing a parenthesis. That's how I learned that, before you go assuming you went about the project the wrong way, check your syntax first," Adora says, groaning.

Catra laughs, slapping her knee and throwing her head back.

"I took precisely one coding class before I decided that computer science wasn't for me. I was decent at Java and decided, you know what? Fish won't betray me the way parenthesis do."

Adora doesn't mention that so far, one very big fish had, in fact, betrayed Catra greatly in the last few days.

The engine gives a whine, but luckily it returns to the struggling hum without any further complaints. They continue the light banter back and forth. Adora's hand reaches over to rub at Catra's thigh, and Catra removes one of hers from the steering wheel to

lay gently across it. She traces Adora's knuckles in a light, tickling pattern while they talk. She focuses on a particular scar that bumps up off of Adora's knuckle and then back down to the sensitive skin on the back of her hand.

Catra feels Adora shiver and looks over to see blue eyes staring back. They're inches apart, and Catra leans forward just that little bit to gently sandwich Adora's bottom lip between her own.

Adora sighs, melting into the kiss.

They're focused on each other (it's not like there was anything out here to hit if Catra took her eyes off of where she was steering for a couple of minutes) but somewhere in the back of her mind, Catra registers a *beep*.

She freezes, and then Adora quickly does the same.

They part, staring at each other with wide eyes, before slowly turning their heads toward the dashboard.

Right there, next to the compass, is the radar.

With a little, green dot.

It continues to beep as that green dot gets closer.

They both stand up, looking around for any sign of the shark or the barrels, but don't see anything yet.

Adora jumps down to the lower deck to the entrance of the cabin, but Razz is already making her way up on deck.

"We've got it now!" She says, grabbing her trusty harpoon gun and climbing up to the crow's nest to keep a lookout.

Then, just as Adora is about to climb out onto the bow, the splashing, gurgling sound of the barrels popping up right behind the boat grabs her attention.

She isn’t sure where the shark is, because the barrels just bob there, unmoving.

“The poles! Grab those lines!” Razz shouts.

Catra jumps down and grabs the two poles, hooks fixed to the ends, and hands one to Adora.

She then leans out over the side of the boat and uses it to grab the rope attached to a barrel.

Adora does the same to another of the ropes.

“Tie them to the cleats now, hurry!” Razz instructs.

Catra ties her rope to the cleat on the port side, and Adora takes hers to the starboard corner, careful to loop it over Catra’s head so she isn’t trapped between the rope and the hull.

As soon as they have their ropes tied to the cleats, the lines go taut, and the shark starts swimming away.

The boat swings far, almost in a half circle as the shark drags them by the stern out to sea.

It’s fast, the monumental strength of the shark pulling them so quickly that water starts to froth and curn, spilling over the transom and into the boat.

Adora and Catra are soaked, water filling up to their ankles while they both struggle to grab at the ropes.

“Untie them! We’re taking on too much water!” Catra says.

“I can’t get it loose, the damn shark has it too taut!” Adora grunts.

Water is splashing violently into the boat now, sloshing around and making the deck slick while odds and ends that hadn’t been secured start floating around. A fire extinguisher bangs into

Adora's ankle, while a loose life vest and some rope get tangled up in Catra's feet.

Meanwhile, the shark keeps pulling harder, and they can all hear the creaking, splintering noises of wood cracking.

"It's going to rip the transom off! Get those ropes loose!" Razz says, jumping down.

Her bright purple dress floats around in the water, closer to knee deep on her shorter frame. When she, too, is unable to pull either of the ropes free, she turns and walks down into the cabin.

Adora has transitioned from mildly in pain and annoyed to full panic when she sees what Razz was talking about, that the transom, the flat wall of the very back of the boat, was ripping away from the sides.

She pats around in her pockets for her knife, trying to find something she could use to cut the rope, but before she can, Razz reappears and pushes her out of the way.

Adora falls to the floor, soaking what little of her was dry in the near foot of water sloshing around.

Razz heaves a gigantic machete over her head with both hands, and slams it down on one of the ropes, cutting it free.

Releasing one rope makes the boat swing, as it continues to be pulled by the other corner, but she makes quick work of slicing through that rope as well.

The vessel slows, just a gentle drift now, and they all breathe heavily. At least for now it isn't being ripped apart any longer.

But this time, instead of disappearing into the murky depths of the unknown while they sit distraught over the circumstances, the shark circles back.

It passes below, it's massive dorsal fin scraping along the bottom and rocking the boat violently side to side. Razz takes up her harpoon gun again, ready for the next time it passes to try to get a shot at it's head, and then Adora does the only thing she can think to do.

She heads below and grabs her sidearm out of the compartment where she'd been keeping her belongings. Thankfully it wasn't wet, and she opened the revolver to drop in 6 rounds. She then snaps it closed, buckles the holder onto her belt, and sprints up on deck.

As it passes under them again, Razz manages to shoot right at its head. The harpoon lodges itself right between the shark's eyes, a foot or so away from the tip of its snout. But it's skin is too thick, it seems, for that to be a damaging enough blow. Adora runs to the other side and fires three shots, aiming near its head, but the water refracting and the sun glittering off of the surface made it impossible to aim accurately and she ends up missing.

"Did you just try to shoot a shark? Like with a gun? When it's like…. Ten feet underwater?" Catra asks, amusement painting her voice.

"Well it was worth a *shot*," Adora says, turning and wiggling her eyebrows at Catra.

She rolls her eyes.

"They're getting worse."

"No-" Razz starts.

Adora and Catra cut her off "-flirting, we know."

The shark is gone for now, and now that the ropes that held the barrels had been severed, the only way to find out when it would be back was to wait.

But Catra was tired of waiting. With an engine compartment full of water they weren't going to be getting those engines starting anytime soon, and it would take hours to pump out the bilge at this rate. They'd just be adrift until they got all of the water pumped out and the engines started, but that was the least of their worries when the shark was still out there.

"It's time to lower the cage," She says.

Adora does a double take, just to make sure she heard correctly.

"Ok listen, none of our fishing techniques are going to work if we can't get these engines started. Being in the water once we finally sink? Is going to be bad news if that thing is still alive," Catra says.

"Yes yes, we can't just throw out a line and hope, we need a real plan," Razz agrees, in what is probably the most full sentence she's bothered to say since they got on board.

"So let's put the cage in. I'll suit up. I have a shark dart that I've filled with strychnine nitrate. I'll get down in the cage, wait for it to come back, and then inject it. It'll be dead before it can even swim away, and then we can really focus on getting back to shore," She says.

"Are you crazy? I'm not letting you get in the water with that thing! You've seen what it did to the hull! Can you imagine what it'd do to that cage?" Adora says, alarmed

"Let me? You don't get to tell me not to help Adora."

Ok, maybe that was a bit of an overreaction, but the thought of Catra in the water with the shark made her nauseous.

"Alright, I'm not telling you not to help! I just… I don't want to lose you. You know? And Razz has never had the barrels fail and we just don't know what it could do. I'm… I'm scared," she says.

“I know you’re scared, but you have to let me help. You can’t do everything on your own, Adora. I’m going to go change, then we’ll lower the cage in, and this will all be over before you know it. And then we’ll be back home to see our… to see Finn. Ok?” She says.

Adora nods.

Catra reaches up and places her hands on the sides of Adora’s face, rubbing her thumbs along her cheekbones. She pulls Adora’s head down gently so that she can lean up and plant a kiss on her forehead, Razz making a very performatory grunt at the sight, and heads down to the cabin.

Razz looks at Adora, a shimmer in her eye.

“You know something, Mara dearie?” She says.

Adora looks up, quirking an eyebrow.

“Not just any woman is going to scuba dive with a deadly shark for you. Remember that,” She says, taking her broom and very gently tapping it on Adora’s head.

She looks at Razz, watching her pretend to ignore Adora’s staring.

“You sound like you had someone like that too Razz,” Adora says, walking over and helping remove the ratchet strap that held the shark cage against the wall.

Razz smiles, looking up at the sky. She breathes like that, and closes her eyes so the sun can wash over her skin.

If she catches the right hint of salt on the air, the right mix between cool sea breeze and scorching sun on her aged skin, she feels the same way she felt that day so long ago. Back when things were easier. When it was just the two of them on the ocean together. Teaching a much younger, much smaller girl to fish.

“I did Adora, but not like Catra. My Mara, dearie, she was everything. She loved me. Now that was really something. You

understand though, you have Finn."

She opens her eyes, sighing.

"She gave everything, my Mara. You remind me of her. But don't let that stop you from doing things for *you*."

Adora lets that sink in, laying down the side of the cage so she can pick up the square bottom piece and place it down on the deck.

It wasn't that she *didn't* do things for herself. She did plenty. She was graduating soon with the degree that she wanted.

But what else had she done for herself? She moved to this town and took this job for Finn, but she'd do anything for Finn. She was paying rent on the house, which Bow and Glimmer were itching to help with, but she felt bad about charging them rent *and* making them take care of Finn all day.

What was she supposed to do for herself?

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They assemble the cage quickly once Catra is changed and can provide some help setting it up. There wasn't much to it, just four tall walls with aluminum bars and a space near the top that looked a lot more like a 'horrific shark entry window' than anything that could be structural or purposeful, but Adora wasn't an engineer and didn't question it. The bottom bolted on, and the top was fixed on hinges to allow easy entry between the two cylinders that assisted in the cage staying buoyant.

Adora spends the time constructing it half in a panic at the idea of the last time she sees Catra being moments from now when she disappears below the water, and half aroused at the skin tight wetsuit showing off every curve of her muscles.

'Scared and horny' isn't how she thought she'd spend the day, and the anxiety ripping through her was getting worse the closer they

got to putting it in the water.

As Razz takes the line that runs through a series of pulleys in the reel to the shackle at the top of the cage, Catra places her hand on Adora's shoulder.

"Hey, you ok?" She asks.

Adora shakes her head and squeezes her eyes shut.

"I trust you, I really do. And I know you know what you're doing… But Catra I've *never* felt the way I feel when I am with you and I know it's too soon to say shit like this but I don't know how to recover from losing you."

Catra looks down.

"I know. I don't know how I'd deal with losing you if this went on and something else happened. But you just… you never do anything because it's what's best for you. I want that for you. I want you to be happy, to let yourself have what you want, to let yourself… fuck, to let yourself fall in love on a fishing boat and then go back to Weaver's office and let yourself quit. I want you to want other people to help you, because you know that you need it. So I'm doing this, because it's what I can do. Because I can't make you care more about yourself, but I sure can take some of it off of your shoulders. This way, you get to go home to Finn no matter what happens."

Adora grabs Catra by the shoulders, looking in her tear filled eyes with shimmering lines running down her own face.

"Thank you," She whispers, pulling Catra in to hold close to her.

"Thank you. I just… Thank you," She says again.

When Catra pulls back, she takes a breath and says, "It's time I guess."

Adora cranks the handle on the reel, the gears clicking loudly as she lowers the cage into the water. When it's half submerged, Catra opens the top and steps down with her air canister on her back and the regulator over her shoulder. She stands on the bottom, her chest just above the water, and puts her goggles on.

Adora hands down the shark dart. It was a harpoon with a handle, about three feet in length, with a metal shaft sticking out of it and tapering down to a point. Within it, a hollow channel ran that carried the supply of strychnine nitrate that Catra had loaded into it earlier. She'd put a little cork stopper at the top to prevent any accidents, miles from a hospital and certain death awaiting any of them should they have been pricked by it.

"Ok, I'm ready. Ready?" Catra says, looking up at Adora.

Adora feels something then, something shifting in her. The urgency and panic bring to the forefront of her mind what she'd been thinking for days now.

What did she want? Why couldn't she just reach out and take it, reach out and ask for what she wanted? Why was she always doing everything for everyone else when the one thing she wants is standing right in front of her, risking her life for her?

"I'm moving to North Carolina!" She shouts.

Razz raises an eyebrow but ultimately shrugs.

Catra looks at her, wide eyed.

"You're… what?" She says.

Adora nods.

"I'm looking for jobs in North Carolina, near the university. When I'm done here and get my degree, Finn and I are moving there. We're… we're gonna get our fresh start, with a job I like and a place that makes me feel something, something good. I want to be with you. I want to go to the grocery store to pick up your

favorite cereal on the way home from work on a Friday night because I know you'll want something sugary for breakfast on Saturday. I want to stand by the front door and see Finn run up to you when you get home from work. I want to go to the park, the aquarium, and the zoo. I want us to have a stupid destination wedding and only invite like, three people to see it. I want Finn to wear your wedding suit to their senior prom because somehow you turn out to be the same size. I want to love you. And I just… I hope you want to love us too?"

Catra lunges up out of the cage and wraps her arms around Adora.

"I want that too. I want you to come with me, however long it takes you to follow, when I go back. Both of you. I want to love you, Adora."

Adora leans down and kisses Catra, the most urgently she ever has, as she slides out of her arms and back down into the cage.

A single tear follows, dripping down to plop into the ocean, a single drop.

Catra pulls her goggles back on, puts the regulator in her mouth, and gives the thumbs up that she's ready to be lowered down the last couple of feet until the cage is floating in the water.

Once she's below the surface, Catra looks around to get an idea of her range of motion in the cage and how far out her visibility is.

It isn't long before she sees a mass, dark blue, appearing out of the shadows. It swims toward her, the motion looking slow and languid in the underwater world. She found that time passed differently once she was in the water, in her element. But it was still alarming to see it's features draw themselves on in stages as it got closer within her range of visibility.

What really strikes her, the thing that she usually likes but for some reason is giving her a feeling of dread, is the quiet, the stillness. It's silent as it makes its way toward her in her little

metal box, the only thing protecting her being some flimsy aluminum rails.

It swims right by, and disappears off into the cloud of blue. She reaches over and removes the cork, waiting in anticipation for it to return. She can feel her heart beating in her chest, the violent hammering in her ears. It's a pounding, fear and adrenaline combining in her head.

Her eyes sweep left to right, scanning her periphery, but she still doesn't see anything. The stillness, the blank slate, is eerie and foreboding. It fills her with a sense of dread and helplessness. It was still a matter of waiting, regardless. She keeps her eyes peeled for movement, fish schooling in a particular pattern to avoid a predator, the murk being disturbed down below, anything that would give her a hint that the shark was getting close again, but there's nothing.

There's nothing for long enough that she thinks it might not have seen her in the cage, might have swam away.

But then the feeling of dread overtakes her again, and it's with alarm that she thinks that maybe she's been facing the wrong way.

Just as she has that thought, a tremor shakes the cage and she turns just in time to be faced with the largest teeth she's ever seen. She tries to bring the dart forward but the angle and the sudden motion makes her let go, and she has to contort her body drastically to avoid being scraped by the tip as it falls to the bottom of the cage. She uses one of her fin-covered feet to keep it in place so it doesn't fall, but the thrashing maw of the shark, opening and closing its mouth in the hopes of trapping her between it's dastardly jaws, keeps her from doing anything else.

It smashes forward, clumsily bashing into the aluminum bars that dent and fold with each impact. She screams, but it's a muffled sound combined with the bubbling, gurgling of the regulator allowing her to exhale. She flounders for a moment, flailing as she

presses herself up against the opposite side of the cage as the shark wiggles forward between the rails it had bent apart.

She reaches behind her, taking out the knife that she kept in it's sheath on her belt and stabs it forward without hesitation.

The shark gets its entire face in the cage with her and she has to kick up, forgetting the dart beneath her foot, to avoid having her legs right within its grasp. She places a hand on the leathery, thick skin of its face and stabs forward.

The first jab doesn't feel like it does anything, and she'd jabbed a shark in self defence before. It's skin is thick, like she's trying to slice through pork belly with a butter knife. The second jab manages to draw blood, but it still doesn't get more than the tip of the knife in and does more to anger the shark than it does to injure it. By now it's thrashing violently, rocking the cage back and forth as it's massive tail fin thrusts it forward.

Up on deck, Adora see's the outline of the shark as it bites through the cage.

"Catra!" She says, though logic would tell her that Catra wouldn't hear her below the water.

"We have to get her back up!" She says, running over to the reel and cranking the handle as fast as she can.

Razz sees the extension sticking out over the water, wood flexing with the effort.

"Stop! It'll break and then we won't be able to get her up," Razz says, going over to look over the side.

All she sees is frothing seafoam and the dark shadow of the shark with its head inside the cage.

Below, Catra still jabs at the shark, but she'd gone up toward the top of the cage where she can see it's head. It hasn't figured out how to look up, and though she's certain it would fit, she doesn't

think it has the wherewithal to tell that it just needs to tilt it’s body and she’d be trapped. At least she hopes, that is.

She jabs down a few more times, this time slicing at it’s gills and eyes, anything that would get it to see that it was vulnerable and retreat. It’s jagged teeth scrape at the aluminum and she can hear the way it sounds, like nails on a chalkboard. Blood seeps into the water from it’s open wounds, and it finally has enough of being entirely stationary.

It couldn't breathe unless it was swimming, water actively passing over its gills, so even the bloodthirsty monster was going to pull back to regain its bearings eventually.

When it does, Catra hopes it would swim away long enough for her to get to the surface and have Adora and Razz pull her back in, but unfortunately, the sheer weight of it has pulled the cage low enough in the water that when it tries to swim forward, the shark gets stuck on top of the cage.

It thrashes more, whipping its tail in a bone crushing display of strength.

Up on deck, Adora looks down in horror at the shrieking metal. She cranks the handle harder, as fast as she can as she desperately tries to get Catra out of the water. Tears pour down her face as she looks back for even a last glimpse at her.

The reel is moving slower, the stress of the weight it wasn’t meant to hold causing the boat to tip to the side.

Under great tension, the rope snaps, and the cage starts to fall before Razz grabs it.

The boat rocks again, suddenly released from it’s tension, and Adora lunges for the side to grab the rope and help Razz pull it up.

It takes all of her strength, in spite of the aluminum’s lighter weight, but by the time they get it out of the water and see what

the shark had done to it, she’s horrified.

It’s empty.

It’s torn apart, and it’s empty.

Adora drops the rope, letting it fall out of her hand and back into the water. She sits down, mouth agape and eyes wide as she takes in what she’s seen.

Catra is gone.

Catra is *gone*

She grabs her head, rocking back and forth, gripping her hair tightly in her fists.

“No no no Catra come back,” She sobs, defeat and heartbreak weighing her down. She can’t move, limbs made of lead and blood ice cold in her veins. She sits there rocking back and forth as she cries for the loss, the fact that it was her fault for calling her here in the first place, for seeking out her expertise in particular.

Catra is gone

“Fuck!” She shouts, standing up and pacing in the ever growing pool of water at her feet.

She shouts at the heavens, full of anguish.

But the sky's still blue, and the clouds are still joyful puffing cotton balls.

She goes down below deck, rifling through Catra’s things.

She pulls out that denim jacket, the one Catra always wore, the one that belonged to her father, and puts it on.

It still smells like her, and it breaks Adora’s heart more.

She pulls the dry bag out, the one that Catra put her phone and wallet in, and clips it to her belt loop because she knows that it also holds the polaroid picture they'd taken with Finn on their family trip to the park the week before.

Suddenly the shark launches itself out of the water, landing on the back of the boat and completely crushing the transom as it falls. Razz and Adora fall to the floor as the boat tilts back, the stern completely under water in a matter of moments.

Adora grabs onto a cabinet and keeps herself from sliding toward the shark, but Razz isn't so lucky.

She slides down and has to use her feet to kick off of the shark's snout, avoiding getting her feet caught in it's teeth and sliding right into its massive jaws. It opens and closes, snapping its mouth shut to try to capture a bit of the snack it knows is right in front of it.

Adora turns back around to pull herself up, and just when she gets her footing, hears a scream.

When she turns back, Razz and the shark are gone.

She's alone on the boat, sinking in the middle of the ocean.

And yet, she can only think of one thing to do.

She grabs her rifle, the one she'd brought just in case, and heads out to the bow of the boat where it's still mostly out of the water.

She sits down, pulls Catra's phone out of the waterproof pouch, and calls Glimmer.

"Catra?" She answers, confused.

"Glim it's me," She whispers, like she's afraid if she talks too loud the moment will be gone.

“Adora? What’s going on?” Glimmer asks, alarmed at how void her voice sounds.

“There isn’t time, the boat is sinking. The shark got… it got Catra and Razz,” She chokes on the words as they come out.

“What? Adora where are you, I’m calling the Coast Guard,” Glimmer rushes out, frantic.

“Glim? We’re off the southeast coast of the island but… just give the phone to Finn,” She says.

She can see the water rising, the shark circling out about 100 or so feet away, and can see the hope dwindling from the situation. She tries to retain some optimism, some semblance of her normal voice so it doesn't scare Finn.

“Mommy?” Finn asks.

She closes her eyes.

“Hey baby, I love you,” She says, right off the bat.

Who knows how long this call will last.

“Mommy! How’s fishing? How’s Catra? I been practicing the knots she taught me!” They say.

She smiles, another tear running down her face as she covers her mouth so they don’t hear her sob through the phone.

This was the last time she’d ever talk to them.

“Listen baby? I love you so much, ok? I love watching you grow up, and I love seeing the little person you’re becoming. Don’t ever forget that, ok?” She begs.

They sound confused and a little scared, but she doesn’t think they quite get it yet.

“I love you too mommy. And I know.” They say.

She feels the waves licking at her feet and throws her head back, anguish and longing gripping at her heart.

“I have to go ok? But I love you so much baby. So much.”

“Love you too mommy!” They say. Handing the phone back to Glimmer and running off.

Adora says one last thing into the phone, “Glim? I love you and Bow too, please, don’t forget that. Don’t let Finn forget. Please.”

She doesn’t wait for a response, can’t wait for one, and hangs up. She tucks the phone back into the waterproof pouch, though she’s not sure why she even does it, and looks up.

The shark is headed toward her, and with most of the hull underwater, she doesn’t have anywhere to go but up the mast to the crows nest. As she starts her ascent, the shark pops out of the water right under her, right alongside the entrance to the cabin.

Adora looks in and sees the compressed air canisters, Catra’s backup for her dive.

”You screw around with these things and they’re going to blow up” She remembers Catra saying.

It gives her an idea, stupid as it may be, and she reaches in to grab it.

Just as the shark opens its mouth, the chasm of darkness right below her, she shoves the tank in.

It’s confused, chewing at the metal and rolling it around in it’s mouth. It continues it’s pass alongside the mostly sunken ship, circling back out for what it knows is the inevitable.

All it has to do is wait for the moment Adora ends up in the water too. She doesn't know if this idea would work, she just knows she has to try. She has to try to get back to Finn.

Adora climbs to the highest point, the lookout perch, just as the water overtakes the remainder of the hull. Catra's jacket is an armor making her feel loved and safe and strong for what could be her last few moments.

As she gets to the top the boat begins to turn sideways, and she sinks closer and closer to the water. She settles herself lying down with the rifle on her shoulder, cocking the gun and looking down the sight toward the shark as it barrels toward her.

She shoots once and it misses, whirring into the water past its face.

"Come on," She mutters to herself.

The second shot misses as well, but as it gets closer she sees the cylinder in its mouth. It's now or never. Any closer and the explosion would injure her too, and if she missed she'd have no time to aim and fire again as it barreled toward her.

"It's time for you to go," She says, taking the third shot.

She closes her eyes, because if the shot doesn't make it she's dead in it's jaws.

And if the shot makes it? There was no telling the kind of damage that would come to her if the explosion shot pieces of metal and… shark… all over the place.

She hears an explosion, the whooshing sound of the air leaving the canister and igniting under the pressure. She feels water and blood and whatever else fly over her, spraying chunks of the shark high into the air. The water is littered with flesh and blood, along with the dead and decaying remains of whatever it had eaten in the last few hours.

When she opens her eyes, it's still. She's in disbelief that the shark is dead, that she's won, but for her it doesn't feel like a win.

She doesn’t get her future with Catra after all. It was a beautiful wish, a dream, but maybe it just wasn’t for her.

Still, the quiet and stillness wakes her up. The next issue is that the boat is still sinking, and there was no help in sight. She has to find something to float on, something to get her to shore.

She spots a few barrels and some life vests floating a few feet away.

But then she hears something.

“Adora?”

She turns her head, not letting herself hope until she sees for herself.

Catra is swimming up to her, clad in her wetsuit and scuba gear.

She cries, a sob leaving her as she reaches out to wrap an arm around Catra’s shoulders.

“I thought I lost you,” She says, bumping her forehead against Catra’s.

They both laugh, and cry, and laugh some more.

Adora sighs, “It’s over. It’s gone.”

Catra snorts, “Good riddance… Thanks for saving my jacket.”

“If I was going to die, I was going to die thinking of you and Finn. I also have your little dry bag with that picture in it.”

Adora looks around, seeing the planks, bits of the hull that had broken off, floating in the water. It’s probably enough, with some of the life vests, for them to grab onto and kick themselves to shore. First, Catra lets go of Adora to swim over and grab one of the barrels for Adora to hold on to so she wasn’t exhausting herself treading water. They both select a relatively large piece of

wood, Catra using the nylon straps from a few life vests to tie it together with the flotation devices. It was easier for her to work in the water, the fins making it easier to maneuver and the buoyant properties of the wetsuit aiding her in staying afloat.

Once they're both holding on to the makeshift raft, Adora takes Catra's chin in her hand and kisses her. It's bold and brash and needy. Adora kisses Catra like she never had before, like she never thought she would get to again.

"No kissing! We've got to get to shore!"

Adora and Catra part, confused as ever at the sight of Razz swimming up.

"Razz?!" They both say.

The old woman shrugs, swimming between them and grabbing the makeshift raft.

"Time to go, dearies!" She says.

Adora looks at Catra.

Catra looks at Adora.

They both shrug, grabbing the driftwood flotation device and kicking toward shore.

Neither of them was sure where the old woman could have been, or how she survived, but that would be an issue for another day.

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They're picked up by the coast guard a couple of miles from shore, Glimmer's call-in tipping them off to their location. The sun is setting as they get back to port, and by the time they arrive back at Adora's house it is well after dark.

They walk in, Glimmer and Bow sitting in the living room waiting for them.

Bow gets up first, hugging Adora so fiercely that she is knocked off her feet but held up by his strong arms. He grabs the back of her head, holding it to his neck, and they stand there hugging.

Glimmer does the same to Catra, holding her close in her salty, crusty wetsuit.

They join into a four person hug, gripping each other tightly, kissing each other's faces and the corners of each other's mouths and anywhere because it doesn't really matter. Catra registers that she'd probably just kissed a man for the first time in her life, which ironically makes her laugh in spite of how obviously platonic it was.

The four break apart, looking at each other laughing and crying.

Talking could wait until tomorrow.

Processing how close they came to losing each other would wait until tomorrow.

Catra showers first, getting the grime and muck of being in the ocean off of herself. She gets out of the shower to see Adora sitting there on the toilet with a towel wrapped around herself.

It seemed that even the other side of the door was too far away for now.

"Hey," Catra says, using the towel to dry her hair a little bit.

"Hey," Adora says, holding out a t-shirt and a pair of underwear and sweatpants for Catra to change into.

"You alright?" Catra asks.

Adora nods.

“I will be. I just… I don’t know what I need, but I need it with you.”

It wasn’t ambiguous or flirty and frivolous or confusing anymore.

Adora needed Catra and Catra needed Adora.

Adora hops in the shower while Catra goes down the hall.

She picks up Finn from their bed, cuddling them close to her chest and rocking back and forth on her way back to the primary bedroom.

She lays them down, covering them in the comforter, and lays next to them, waiting.

When Adora emerges from the bathroom fully dressed she takes in the sight of Catra and her sweet baby snuggled in bed.

She feels another tear roll down her cheek, the first of the day that’s happy and relieved, and crawls in on the other side of Finn.

She worms one hand under Finn, holding them to her chest, and rests the other on Catra’s hip.

“Love you mommy,” Finn whispers, cuddling close to her.

She squeezes her eyes shut, holding them.

“I love you so much baby.”

Finn uses their last bit of consciousness, their late night stubbornness, to turn their head up.

“Love you Cat,” They say, collapsing back to bed.

She smiles, leaning forward to kiss the back of their head.

“I love you too Finny.”

A Much Needed Summer Vacation

Chapter Notes

> Hey y'all, I'm not sure if this needs a CW but better safe than sorry, the first scene is Catra shaving her face and her relationship with shaving and her memories of her dad. If that is triggering to you/not productive for you to read please skip to the second scene!
>
> Last chapter of the story! (I do plan on an epilogue eventually, but I am not sure when)
>
> For the most part (though I changed a lot obviously) I have included original content and dialogue from the original Jaws movie just as fun easter eggs for anyone who recognized them, but this chapter is just entirely what I felt like making it since the movie ends half a second after they kill the shark haha
>
> Thank you to everyone who has read and enjoyed the story! And a special thanks for the kudos and comments! Always fun to get the juices flowing of things a little outside the box!
>
> Just a fun and festive summer tale of falling in love in a vacation town with the added issues of a massive shark stalking the waters!

Birds, regular ass birds and not any of the seagulls she's heard the last few days, are chirping outside the window. The fact that the bed, the very structure, isn't moving around her is a refreshing reminder that the nightmare ordeal is over. She lies there for a moment, listening to Adora's light snore on the other side of the bed and the gentle breaths of the child between them, relief and calm settling over her.

It's early, the sun barely peeking through the blinds at an angle that sweeps over the room with it's soft, purple haze. The quiet is

startling, and Catra sits up to take a look around. She yawns, stretching her arms over her head and then rubbing a hand over her tired eyes and down her face.

The bristles under her hands, patchy and thinning but there none the less, tickle her palm. It's thickest on her chin, the rest of her jawline and parts of her face still smooth. Electrolysis was slow going when her work and travel schedule dictate that she take so long between sessions, but it bothered her less and less as the years went on and the amount of hair left on her face dwindled. It was more annoying than anything, still having to shave those spots that had been particularly stubborn.

She was awake now, and might as well deal with it while she had the quiet bathroom to herself.

Catra reaches under the bathroom sink for her toiletry bag, the worn leather one that her father used. The bag and it's contents, a boar brush and safety razor, were a few of the only things she could think to take with her when they seized the house and put her in the system. It was a race to find something that would remind her of her parents, and in her frantic searching, she'd grabbed the small bag and a few pictures of her parents and herself.

Normally in the morning if she was this tired she'd just use the electric trimmer in the bottom of her bag, uncaring if she got as close to the skin. But something about the way it felt to hold the heavy stainless steel in her hand, it's knurled handle between her fingers, made her pull the stopper in the sink and start the hot water while turning to get a washcloth out of the linen closet.

She runs the washcloth under the steaming water, warming and wetting it until it's nearly scolding her fingers. She then wrings it out and turns on the cool tap to balance the temperature as the sink fills up. The boar brush stands upright, the handle resting on the wall of the basin while the knot soaks.

The toilet seat makes a good enough place to lounge and hold the cloth over her face, relaxing her pores and softening the hair. There wasn't a part of the process she didn't like, because even though it reminded her of the parts of herself she'd always wanted to change, it also reminded her of early mornings watching her father do the same. It used to bother her that she had to shave at all, and she would rush through it with a trimmer and a disposable razor.

But one day, while she was rifling through her closet, she found that old leather toiletry bag. It had the initials "CH," her father's initials embossed in the dark brown patina. It had been a gift for him for his wedding, the years of love he gave it showing through the dust. She'd sat on the plush carpet of her bedroom, slowly tugging open the zipper. From within, the smell of cinnamon and clove wafted into her nose, and tears rushed to her eyes.

It was like going home, and she was smaller, in a pair of warm arms. She was on the sunny beach, small hand engulfed in a protective one. It brought back the memories of her father, and as she reached in and pulled out that old tub of shave soap, she longed for the feeling of being close to him again.

That was back when she'd first moved in with Scorpia, out of her foster home and into her best friend's newly renovated basement. The need to feel that tiny bit of home that she'd been missing, with all of the inconsistencies and anxieties she'd felt through the years of being in the system and trying to figure out her identity, was suffocating. Even in this moment, weighing the guilt of *enjoying* shaving with what she knew to be her new identity was startling. Still, she had gathered everything and taken it to the bathroom, pristine white tile greeting her as she laid all of the tools, once her fathers and now hers, on the counter.

It was exactly what she was doing now, though more practiced than that first time. That first encounter with the tools she'd been taught to use was jittery and messy, cautious and slow. And she'd still ended up cutting her face in quite a few places.

It had all been worth it though, for the satisfied feeling she got that she was finally close to his spirit again.

She stands from the toilet, bringing the towel down once her face feels warm and soft, stopping the taps on the sink once it is filled enough.

Sure and strong fingers carefully unwrap a single, double edged blade from it's wax paper and place it between the cap and the mount, carefully screwing it down onto the handle. Her father always hammered in how important it was for a good shave to place it evenly, so that an equal amount of the blade was exposed along both sides. It took a couple of tries to get it just right, but as she twirled the handle around and looked at it, she was satisfied.

Then came the lather, working that brush over the soft soap in the tub. She rotated her wrist in circles, going over the soap and loading the brush until she pulled it away and the bristles stuck thickly to each other.

She splashed water on her face and began the process she'd seen him do countless times, what used to be a rushed and anxious process now calming her. Running the swift boar bristle brush over her face in a circular motion over on cheek, building a lather as it foamed out from her face, and then switching to the other cheek. The smell of cinnamon and clove, that same scent of shave soap her father used to use, filled her nostrils again, like it always did. She got a little choked up, a tear forming in the corner of her eye.

"Hey dad, uh… I've been busy the last few days," She mumbles out.

It wasn't out of the ordinary for her to talk to him, because she never felt closer to him than when she shared one of his hobbies or passions. She spoke to her mother too, when she was out by the tidepools sketching anemones or little sand crabs. An artist

and scientist at heart, her mother's soul wound as tightly with her own as her father's did.

“I miss you guys, but you know that… um,” She cuts off, tilting her head back to brush some of the lather that was now smooth and hydrating over the skin on her neck.

Catra is silent for the moments it takes to pick up the razor, tilting it to a 45 degree angle and placing it with a feather light touch to her cheek at the hairline by her ear and letting the weight of the handle assist her in dragging it down.

She breathes out, relaxing more, and swishes the head of the razor in the sink to wash away the few hairs it gathered and the lather.

“I think I’m a mom? Or close to it? I don’t know. We haven’t talked about what it means for me and Finn yet but there’s something making me feel like this… this is for real.”

There isn’t a response obviously, but she sees the smirk on his lips all the same as she would have if he were in the room with her. She rolls her eyes at him.

“Don’t look at me like that, christ I didn't think I’d fall in love either.”

She continues like that, whispering about Adora and Finn, the last few weeks and what made her think this felt a whole lot like forever as she takes smooth passes over the rest of her face.

“I know what it was like for you and mom, you told me often enough,” Her voice comes out mumbled as she pulls her skin tight to get her neck without nicking herself. After fishing and his work at the office, her mother was all the man talked about. He was so in love with her it felt unreal.

Once she sees that she’s got all of her first pass done, she sighs.

“You guys would love them, both of them I mean-” She’s cut off by the door creaking open.

She turns, looking down to see a sleepy set of blue eyes and blonde curls. Finn rubs an eye with their fist.

“Who are you talking to Cat?” They say, a little louder than she was expecting to hear this early.

Peering through the door and seeing that Adora was still very much asleep, she places the razor on the counter and ushers Finn inside the bathroom so she can close the door and keep some of their voices out. They stand next to her, reaching up to touch the cloud of soap with a single finger and pulling their hand back to tap at it with the forefinger of the other hand.

Catra picks up the brush, grinning as she taps the very tip of that swirling soft serve on their nose.

They giggle, scrubbing it away with their palm.

“Just kind of talking, thinking about my dad. But there isn’t anyone here, babe. I was just shaving,” She says.

“Oh.”

They’re a little quiet, and she decides to wet her face again and spread some more lather on for another pass. That was the thing about the single blade, you didn’t get it all at once, but part of the joy of it was taking your time and enjoying the process. Hence why she couldn’t be bothered with it when she was younger and dreaded the chore all together.

“Why?” they ask, after a moment.

Her smile is gentle.

“Because there’s hair on my face, and I don’t really like how it looks. It makes me self conscious sometimes.”

“Oh. Uncle Bow shaves his face too. But he doesn't use a fancy brush.”

A chuckle shakes her shoulders.

“It’s kind of the old way of doing it. It takes a lot of time and the stuff for it can be more expensive. Plus a lot of people just do it the way their parents or guardians taught them. Some people aren’t lucky enough to have a person to teach them and just look it up by themselves, though. This just happens to be the way my dad did,” She explains.

They sit there quietly, holding their little stuffed toy and watching with drooping yet curious eyes. She doesn't really need to take a full pass this time, because most of her facial hair was taken care of. The process, when she had the time, was precious to her though. And Finn seemed to be curiously enraptured in it as well.

Just as she’s finishing up, splashing water over her face and using the washcloth to wipe away the excess lather from around her ears and cheeks, Finn pipes up.

“Am I gonna need to shave my face too?” They ask.

She looks at them, reaching a clean yet damp hand out to ruffle their hair. A few droplets of water splash on their face.

“Maybe. The thing is, the hormones that my body makes also have secondary effects of making the hair on my face grow. But your mommy was born with a different body than me, which is why she doesn’t need to shave her face. Then, there are some people with medical conditions that make hair grow on their face anyway, even when their bodies are more like your mommy’s. And to make it more complicated, there are people who decide they *don’t* need to shave their face, when they're born like I was. So really? The only way to know if you’ll *need* to shave your face or not, is to let you just grow up a little bit more and see how it makes you feel,” She tries to explain.

It was hard, the whole hormones and medical conditions thing. No one's journey was the same, and that was the hardest thing for her own internalized bias to figure out.

Their brows furrowed in concentration, taking in what she said before finally saying, "Oh. That sounds confusing."

She smiles, wiping the rest and rinsing her face, applying her aftershave lotion in the same scent as her soap, and then turns to Finn.

"Yeah, it can be. But you can always ask questions and I will always answer. Mommy will too."

They look up at her, eyes drifting back and forth to the brush and razor.

"Can you show me?" They ask, fidgeting with the ear of their stuffed lion.

She smiles, "Of course, kid."

Catra places the head of the razor in the washcloth so she can unscrew the handle without her hand slipping on the slick metal surface, and then takes the blade out and places it in an old and rusty altoid tin for her to put in her sharps box later.

Kneeling in front of them, she holds up the razor first.

"So this is the handle, the part you hold. Feel how heavy it is? That weight helps you pull it down your face. This is the mount and the cap. You put the blade between these two and then screw the handle onto this threaded part here and tighten it," She explains, letting them hold the handle and pointing to each part.

She keeps explaining everything, just the way her dad taught her when she was Finn's age. Everything from the razor and blade, all the way down to the boar brush and the soaps, along with the process of loading the brush and lathering the soap on their face.

They giggle as she swirls it lightly over their cheeks, significantly less pressure than she'd do on her own face, and it tickles their soft skin. She laughs too, remembering giggles of her own.

When it's time to actually use the razor she lifts them up, sitting them on the counter, to face the mirror. She holds it for them, dragging it down their face and scraping the soap off on the bladeless razor, and then hands it to them to give it a try.

For a second, as she's standing there in the bathroom teaching Finn how to shave just the way her dad taught her, she could swear she feels his hand on her shoulder and his kiss on the top of her head.

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Adora wakes up to an empty bed, a startling fact considering she'd fallen asleep with her baby and her partner by her side. Sunlight is streaming in, bright and bold streaks between the blinds, making her wince and turn over to grab the phone on her nightstand.

It was nearly 10, which explained why Finn wasn't in bed anymore. They rarely slept in that late, but the fact that she didn't hear them stir and they didn't wake her up was the strange part. Maybe they got up with Catra, but Adora really hoped that her partner got enough sleep as well.

She considers rolling back over and shutting her eyes again, but she hears giggling coming from the kitchen and is overcome with the need to see her baby again. They'd fallen asleep quickly last night, but the overwhelming need to hold them gets her moving. She sits up, groaning at the stiffness in her back and the soreness in her legs and abs. Apparently swimming miles back to shore after already jumping around a fishing boat was quite the workout, and a set of movements that she wasn't used to doing. If Finn was in a snuggling mood today it would be ideal, but honestly, she'd do anything they wanted today.

The walk to the kitchen is short, and she smiles at the giggles.

Rounding the corner her feet make contact with the cool tile of the kitchen floor, and she leans on the door frame.

Finn is sitting up on the counter, in a spot that had clearly been cleared off so they could sit there. The tight space usually housed their toaster oven and utensil bin, which were now sitting on the kitchen table. Even though they're close to the stove, the burner that Catra is using is on the other side and far enough away that Adora isn't nervous about their proximity to the flame. Their legs are crossed under them, with a tea towel sitting on their lap and a mixing bowl nestled where they can stir it with a wooden spoon.

"Catra is it mixed? It's lumpy!" They say, holding the spoon high above the bowl and letting the batter drip down into it.

Some gets on the edge of the bowl, another few drops fall to the floor, and Catra grabs a towel to wipe it up while she says, "A little lumpy is perfect for waffle batter!"

She stands up, looking down into the bowl and gently taking the spoon from Finn to stir around. She nods her approval, leaning forward to give them a loud smooch on the forehead.

"That looks perfect! Awesome job baby."

They nod seriously, taking the utmost care in their job as Catra's sous chef for breakfast.

Catra turns to the waffle iron, opening it and hovering her hand over the surface to gauge its heat.

"You want to help me put the batter in the iron?" She asks.

"Yeah! I gotta help!" They say.

She laughs, taking the bowl and tea towel off of their lap and setting them to the side so she can help them to the floor. Then

she grabs one of the chairs in the kitchen set and scoots it up to the counter where the waffle iron is.

She holds their hand as they climb up, helping them get situated, and then places the mixing bowl and a measuring cup on the counter.

"Ok buddy, here's what's gonna go down. We scoop out some batter, dump it in the middle of the waffle iron. Then we close it, flip it over, and wait for it to beep. But be really careful not to touch it because it's hot. So you'll do the scooping, I'll help you dump it in, and then we're gonna get your hands out of the way while I close it, alright?" She explains.

They nod, looking at the hot iron with trepidation.

She sees them shrinking back a little and puts her hand on their shoulder.

"Hey, there's nothing to be afraid of, ok? I'm not gonna let it burn you."

With that little bit of reassurance they're nodding again and she lifts the lid, wisps of steam fluttering up from the surface. She grabs the can of nonstick spray, giving it a coat, and then Finn takes the measuring cup and scoops out some batter.

Catra takes their hand gently in her own and brings it over to the iron, helping them turn it upside down to dump the contents out. The batter sizzles as it hits the hot metal surface, and Finn retreats their hand as soon as it's empty.

Once Catra makes sure that their hand is out of the way she closes the iron, flipping it over in its enclosure, and then lets go of Finn's hand.

"Good job! Alright, I can make the rest of the waffles, but I see a certain someone who looks like she's itching for a hug," Catra says, nodding to Adora in the doorway.

Finn lights up as soon as they see her. “Mommy!” They shout, hopping down off of the chair and running to Adora.

In spite of the soreness in her muscles she scoops them up and holds them close to her, ruffling their hair and planting kisses all over their face while they giggle.

“So have you and Catra been up all this time? I woke up awfully lonely,” Adora says.

“Yeah! We got up a long time ago! We shaved and had a snack and then went out to the swing! Catra read me the one with the happy tree, the poem book,” Finn says, looping their arms around their mommy’s neck.

Adora looks at them, their curly, sandy hair and the way their blue eyes shine when they look at her. She’d taken for granted that she was somebody’s world, and she wouldn’t be making that mistake again.

“That sounds fun! I see you’ve been very helpful, maybe you can make breakfast every weekend while I sleep in!” She jokes, slowly swaying her way through the kitchen.

“Mommy I’m too little to reach!” They protest.

“Ah, well I can help I guess. Can you reach now?” She says, lifting them up over her head.

They laugh wildly as she holds them, her large hands encased around their waist and her arms extended above her head.

“Ok, don’t get too worked up. Breakfast is almost ready,” Catra jokes, all the humor draining from her voice as she catches the look in Adora’s eye.

All Catra can see is her mother standing at the stove while her father tosses her gently.

She covers her mouth with her hand, thinking back all those years ago. Saturday morning cartoons playing on the old TV in the living room, helping her dad carry all of their fishing gear and beach chairs out to the car, returning inside to the smell of bacon sizzling away on the stove.

But as soon as the feeling of nostalgia and longing comes, it's washed away by this new feeling, the feeling of being that for someone else.

"Hey, you alright?" Adora asks, finally reaching her. She's got her fourth waffle on her spatula and finishes setting it on the plate beside her before scooping another cup full of batter into the iron.

"Yeah, just… memories you know?" She says just as Adora leans in to kiss her.

Their lips connect, and all of the tension leaves Catra's body.

"Yeah, I know," Adora whispers.

She knows the feeling too, reliving something from a bygone era but from a different perspective. Like she'd seen them together as a family before, but she was a toddler at the time looking up at a blonde woman and a man with bright red hair and a greying beard.

But this was different, because they could make it whatever they wanted to.

It takes some shuffling to get the table cleared off so they can eat, but the three sit down with a spread of waffles, bacon, and little dishes of butter and syrup

Adora takes Finn's plate and puts a waffle and a few slices of bacon on it, using her fork and knife to cut the waffle into smaller pieces while they talk exuberantly about the couple of days that they were gone. Bow had taken the first day off work to cart them around town with the doors and roof off of Adora's Jeep, grabbing breakfast at the diner and picking up a few movies from the rental

place. Glimmer took them to the playground near the ferry stop and played on the swing set.

"And then after you called Aunt Glimmer took me to that store with all the old stuff, and we got a tea set! With gold around the top and little pink flowers!" They say. Adora is relieved that they couldn't pick up just how dire the situation was, that they didn't seem to be caught up on the fear coming through the phone. Or maybe they had, and Glimmer knew what was going to happen. Maybe she wanted to get them out of the house and distract them, counting down the hours until she got a call from the Coast Guard and had to figure out a way to tell them.

"Are those waffles?" Glimmer's voice carries through from the doorway that leads to their bedroom, Bow coming in behind her.

Bow pulls out the fourth chair, holding it out and helping Glimmer scoot up to the table. Catra rolls her eyes at how cute it is, handing over a fresh plate and a set of cutlery. Glimmer shoots her a playful glare, but smiles. Bow heads out to the living room and returns with the extra chair, scooting up to the table between Glimmer and Catra.

As they eat breakfast together, Adora thinks about what Catra said. About doing things for herself, about letting people help her. She still felt hesitant, like it was asking too much even though she knew it wasn't. Glimmer and Bow asked all the time how they could help her more, what they could take care of, what she needed. Just because she didn't like asking didn't mean other people didn't want to take care of her.

"Hey Bow, Glim? Can we talk about… rent?" She asks.

They look at each other, then at her.

"Sure thing buddy, whats up?" Bow asks, taking a bite of waffles.

"I was wondering if… If you guys would be cool helping me cover rent until the lease is up in December?"

Bow and Glimmer look up, sharing quick glances, and then back at her.

Bow nods gently, trying the careful approach to make sure she feels supported, but Glimmer beats him to responding.

"Yes! Yes Jesus Christ yes let us help you," Glimmer shouts, slamming her hand down and rocking the glasses on the table.

It's quiet, and then Catra throws her head back cackling, followed by Glimmer and Adora and then soon after Bow. Little Finn doesn't have the faintest idea what's going on, but they laugh too, absorbing the joyful outburst of the lively room.

So, maybe her friends wanted to help her, and she didn't have to do everything on her own.

But she'd never imagined the weight that lifted from her shoulders, how free she'd feel.

***

Adora storms in, uncharacteristically harsh and uncaring as the door swings open and hits the wall.

Once the details had been hammered out with Bow and Glimmer about the remainder of the lease, what she could afford and what they would take care of, she wasn't able to stop her feet from carrying her directly to Weaver's office. It was only a short confrontation, and she'd be back home to spend the day with Finn and Catra. She would have waited for her next day of work, but something about that nagging in the back of her mind made it feel urgent to get out from under the toxic thumb of her superior.

Although she didn't expect the sight that greeted her.

"Ah Adooooooooora," Weaver says, clearly a few more drinks in than normal.

"Weaver," Adora responds, unsure if the title of 'mayor' held any weight, judging by the distinct lack of decoration and the cardboard boxes around the office. It was definitely different than the last time she'd been in here. Something drastic must have happened while she was away.

"I suppose you'll be happy to know I've been replaced," Weaver says, taking a swig from that flask she kept in her breast pocket.

If Adora planned on staying employed any longer she'd slap her with a ticket for public intoxication, seeing as this was a public building, but as things stood she didn't think it was necessary. The humiliation of losing her position, her life long career in public office, at the hands of a massive failure was probably worse than any fine she could give. Also, she would probably be requested to show up to court for anything she dished out and she was not willing to put more effort into the legal system of this town once she handed in her badge.

She takes her badge off, tossing it down on the desk. The metal knocks the hard wood, thumping with a brief bounce before coming to a rest on a pile of old, coffee and scotch-stained papers.

"I don't know if I report to you or your successor, but whoever it is, I'm sure that you'll pass on the message that I quit," She says, turning toward the door again.

"You quit? You win, get what you've wanted, see me thrown from my position, and you quit?" Weaver asks.The judgement is harsh in her voice, like it always is, but Adora isn't having it.

She doesn't have to take this shit anymore.

Adora whips around, glaring daggers, "I wanted everyone safe. I wanted to do right by these people. So make no mistake, if I had gotten what I wanted, that little boy who died on the beach, and those countless fishermen, would still be alive. So no, for once, I

am taking what I want. You? You got what you deserved," She says, walking out without another word.

Weaver shouts to her, but it doesn't matter any more.

Adora doesn't need her approval, or her job, or her town.

All Adora needs is sitting on her living room couch watching the Land Before Time and eating popcorn.

That was all Adora needed.

Things would be awkward around town in the months after she quit, while she was still finishing her degree and looking for opportunities and places to move. As long as she got to spend it with her family, it didn't matter.

Adora had finally learned that she was worth more than that, worth something to the people she loved. She was worth something to Bow and Glimmer and Catra and Finn.

That was all that mattered. And she'd be damned if she let one single thing that didn't matter hold her back.

***

It was sunny, a hot day in late August. The end of the summer and Catra's return to the university for the start of the fall semester was fast approaching, but they were trying not to let it get to them that there would soon be a thousand miles between them. Catra had already made arrangements to visit for the week of her birthday in October, and Adora had booked tickets for herself and Finn to visit for the week of Thanksgiving in November. That would double as a trip around town to check out possible locations for apartments and houses. It would get them through until she finished her degree and the lease was up in December and they could finally be reunited permanently.

Bow and Glimmer offered to pay out the rest of the lease so they could move sooner, but Catra's salary and Adora's savings weren't

quite enough to get a place of their own right now, and realistically they still had only been seeing each other in person for two months.

They'd decided that the responsible thing to do would be for Adora and Finn to stay here, while slowly looking for a new place to move into. If they didn't find somewhere by the time Adora and Finn were ready to move? Catra had already envisioned how to clean out her second bedroom turned office to make a bedroom for Finn.

For now, though, they were spending one last day on the beach relaxing. They were sitting on the sand at the pond, just off the inlet, right in the spot where Glimmer had looked frantically out to the water for Bow and Finn last month.

Adora sat on her beach chair, bare feet dug into the warm sand. Her shorts hugged her thighs, muscular quads stretching the red and white fabric dimpled with the specks of condensation from the cool bottle in her hand. The obsessive work and unending course work hadn't previously left a lot of time for her to just sit on the beach with the simple pleasure of an ice cold bottle of coke and a cooler full of snacks. She had sorely missed the relaxation. It took a while for her to get used to the idea of slowing down, but once she had, she realized how much she needed it.

Although that was the main goal, it wasn't entirely why they were here.

Catra sat next to Adora in her own chair, black bikini top exposing her muscular abs and back all the way down to her own pair of board shorts. She was leaning over to help Finn with the sandcastle where they needed it, holding a stick in place while they packed sand around it or helping them with the more intricate shapes. The two adults had done the initial construction of the larger structure, heaping piles of sand and buckets full of water with Finn shouting instructions for it's height and width. Catra helped them collect seashells so that their little castle had

windows and doors. Other than that, they'd insisted on doing the detail work themself.

Adora had been watching them build their sandcastle for a while now. The care that they put into each detail they carved into the mountain of sand with their tongue poking out in concentration had her enraptured. They were just so *smart* and inquisitive and special. They even wanted to wear their swimsuit today in case their pants got wet or sandy, which was the newest development in their feelings toward the beach.

After the incident in the pond, they'd been seeing someone to help talk through their feelings. A few sessions in, after Adora and Catra had come back and they'd all had a chance to calm down and settle back into a routine, Finn had come to them.

"I don't want to be scared anymore," They said.

So, with some suggestions from Finn's counsellor and their nod that it was a good idea, they'd begun the long and careful process of introducing them to the beach again.

At first they'd made it as far as the parking lot in the car before Finn shook their head and asked to go home; a request that they'd promptly honored. A quick stop for ice cream on the way home to lighten their spirits helped tremendously, and they spent the remainder of the day cuddled up watching a movie with all the reassurance that there was no shame in not being ready yet.

But over the weeks they'd gotten Finn out of the car for a walk along the expanse of the pavement of the parking lot that met the sand, out to the edge of the water, and even sticking their little toes in before they'd asked to go home.

Today was special though, monumental in it's importance, because Finn had come up to them this morning and asked to build sandcastles. They all jumped to action to get ready, excitement palpable as they threw dishes in the sink and rushed to get ready. Adora picked out their green and blue striped swim

shorts and the matching rash guard. Catra had rubbed sunscreen on their face and packed the picnic lunch while Adora put the chairs, umbrella, and every sandcastle making tool imaginable into the back of the car.

Finn hadn't wanted to spend more than a few minutes on the beach before today, but they'd been content to build their sandcastle for hours. After the help with the initial construction, Finn insisted that they had to do the rest themself.

They lean back, rubbing their hands together to brush some of the sand off, and look at Adora.

"Mommy? I need more water for the castle," They say shyly.

Adora stands up, grabbing the empty bucket from the ground next to Finn.

She holds out her hand and asks, "Do you want to come with me baby?"

They hesitate, looking at Adora's hand and down to the water. They hadn't spent a lot of time close to an open body of water, but it was their natural childhood curiosity getting them to consider it. They know that their mommy wouldn't make them do anything they weren't comfortable with, but the breeze was calling out for them to take it, to take the offered hand and get back to their life before.

Then they turn to Catra.

"You'll come too?" They ask.

Catra grins at them standing and ruffling their hair.

"Of course! We've gotta get this castle built. There's a princess that needs a castle!" She says, grabbing Finn under the arms and heaving them into the air.

It sprays sand everywhere, but she couldn't be bothered to care when they let out a giggle.

"Yeah! Princess Mommy needs a castle!" They shout.

So that's why I'm not allowed to help, Adora thinks, smiling at how sweet it was that Finn and Catra conspired against her.

To build her a *castle*

Because she's a *princess*

Catra places them back down on the sand, holding one of their hands. They reach the other hand up to take Adora's and the three start walking down toward the water together.

When they're almost there, Finn stops short.

Adora and Catra look at them.

"It's ok if this is as far as you can go honey," Adora says.

Finn looks determined, though.

"There's no sharks?" They ask, foot tapping in the sand.

Catra kneels down, putting her hands on their shoulders.

"Finn? There's always going to be sharks in the ocean. That's where they live, it's where they belong. And you should always be careful. But the likelihood that there are sharks in the pond right now that are going to hurt you? Is very, very low. Mommy and I wouldn't let you in the water if we thought there were sharks in there that could hurt you."

Finn contemplates that, but stays quiet. They'd been told that before, but logic and fear fought hard against each other, and they were still just a kid.

"Sweetheart, if you still don't want to, that's ok. It's whatever you need. There doesn't have to be any rushing this if you're not

ready," Adora chimes in.

They nod slowly, looking at the water. The trepidation, the hesitation, was still there.

Still, Finn takes that step closer. The waves are serene, washing up over their feet and then retreating in the gentle swell. They take a minute there, splashing their feet a little bit, hands still engulfed in two protective grasps.

They take another step, shivering at the cool water on their ankles.

"It's safe?" Finn asks again, fidgeting.

"Yeah baby, it's safe," Adora says, never letting go of their hand but using the other to pat at their back encouragingly.

They walk out for another few steps, and Catra lets go of their hand to kneel a few feet in front of them. She's waist deep, the water licking at her ribs. It's still daunting, unpredictable and murky with only the faintest outline of their feet on the bottom.

Suddenly, with a grin, Finn starts splashing water at Adora and Catra, giggling while they try to wrestle away from them and jump from their own splashing. They play in the surf, tackling each other into the waves and running back and forth in the shallow water. Finn runs out and up the beach, turning around and sprinting back to splash into the surf while they laugh, Adora and Catra both always there to catch them. They'd always be there to catch them.

The carefree way they just enjoy themself when they couldn't even look at the water a month ago makes Adora happier than she thinks she's ever been.

Catra stands up out of the water, absolutely dripping after Finn tackled her and both of them end up dunked under. Finn is hanging off of her back, and both of them are laughing so hard

their eyes are closed. But then Catra opens her eyes and they land on Adora, both of them sharing a tearful smile.

Catra is thankful that she doesn't have to leave before seeing Finn getting comfortable and recovering again. She’s happy that she gets to see them happy, mirroring her childhood self running into the surf with her own parents there to catch her.

It makes Catra feel so special that she gets to be here for a child the way her mother and father were, that she gets to watch over them with the same joy and careful vigilance that her own mother and father did.

It isn’t the first time since meeting them that she saw herself through that lens.

It’s much later than they’d even planned on staying when they head up to eat their picnic lunch. Adora helps Finn out of their rash guard, hanging the shirt on the back of her chair to dry a little bit in the sun, and wraps the towel around them. Catra grabs the packed sandwiches, fruit, and bottles of water out of the cooler. Once she closes the lid, Adora puts Finn on top of it so they have somewhere to sit while they eat, sandy feet kicking back and forth against the molded plastic.

They were ok, Finn was ok, and soon enough they would be starting their lives together. Just a few short months from now they’d be moving in together, and leaving the memories of the trauma they went through where they belonged, on this island.

But for now, they were content to share their last day together before Catra had to leave as a family.

***

No one wants to get out of bed the morning of Catra’s flight.

In fact, when Adora, Finn, and Catra wake up, they spend more time than they should in bed snuggling. Finn is just too cute in their pajamas with their unruly, curly hair and their sleepy smile

for either of them to try to nudge them away. They lay in a pile, wrapped up in blankets, until it's really time to get a move on.

The ferry ride is quite exciting, Finn having only been on it once on the way to the island.

They stand up near the bow, watching the water while they eat their breakfast sandwich. Catra points out all the dolphins she sees, swimming through the water and jumping out alongside the vessel. Finn looks at the buildings in the distance, asking what city it is, and Catra does her best to answer though she's not brushed up on her geography of the region. She pulls out a fan favorite, her trusty compass, along with a map of the area she got from the harbour master, and they try to decipher where they are and where they're headed.

When they get tired of the map, they walk along the deck, Finn pointing at hooks and ropes and circular floatation devices, asking what they're all for. They were still a little quiet, timid in their questions, and they clung close to her hand when they were walking and her leg when they were still. The activities do well enough to distract them, but in the back of their mind, they still dread arriving at the airport.

Adora rests her forearms on the railings, the sea breeze ruffling her hair. She tries not to think negative thoughts, like how Catra was returning home and they wouldn't see each other every day anymore, how Finn was going to be sad that their new favorite adult wasn't going to be around as much. It was insane how quickly Catra came into their lives and solidified herself as a permanent fixture, but really? There wasn't anything Adora would change about all of it. She wasn't delusional enough to think that fate would take care of it, knowing that it would take work just like any relationship, but she knew that Catra was going to be it for her.

They'd spoken early on about the possibility of a break up, and Catra agreed that once she was in Finn's life she was in it for good, regardless of how this went for the two of them.

Adora shakes the thoughts from her head, because there was no way Catra and her would go more than a day without calling each other. They would see each other in a couple of months, and then the very next for holidays, and after that they'd be moving in together. It still didn't feel right, that she would suddenly have to wake up in an empty bed again when she got so used to spending her time with someone.

When they get to the airport in Adora's Jeep, Finn has gone almost completely silent. They're clearly sad, and it breaks Adora's heart to see them like that after all they'd been through that summer. Catra feels equally as bad, running through her account balances and savings to see if she could afford a compulsive and complete resignation from her job to stay on the island with her family before ultimately deciding that she couldn't.

They both knew that the kid would take Catra having to leave hard, but the sudden silence and their inability to get excited at the trip was torture to both Adora and Catra.

They don't say anything as Adora parks, they grab Catra's stuff out of the car, and they walk to security hand in hand. Finn is attached to Catra's hip while she checks her luggage and prints her boarding pass, and when they get to the line where they'd finally have to part, they look close to tears.

"Hey baby? I'm gonna be back before you know it! And I'm going to call you and facetime you all the time, ok?" Catra says, down on one knee with her hands on their shoulders.

They nod, sniffling with their eyes cast toward the stoic white tile. She cups the side of their face, running her thumb under their eye to wipe away the tear that had fallen.

"I know, I'm just sad. I'm gonna miss you," They whisper.

She squeezes her eyes shut, biting her lip, and takes a breath to calm her own racing heart and threatening tears.

“I’m gonna miss you so much. It’s ok to be sad, I’m sad too. But I gotta go, you know?”

They nod, eyes still focused on the floor.

“Hey, you know something?” She asks, trying to lighten her voice.

They look up at her. “Yeah?”

She grins.

“We’re gonna *live* together, for real this time, as soon as you and your mommy can move. Isn’t that cool?” She says, excitement dripping from her voice.

It gets Finn to perk up, but it has the added effect of making Adora feel better too.

“Yeah kiddo, this isn’t forever. Catra has to go back to work, and I don’t want to move us until I have a job lined up. Ok? Think you can wait? We’ll call and facetime all the time,” Adora says, ruffling their hair.

They nod, reaching forward for a long hug. Catra hugs them tight, kisses the side of their head, and then they both pull back so she can stand up.

She turns toward Adora and loops her arms around her neck, bumping their foreheads.

“You gonna be ok without me dummy?” She whispers.

Adora snorts a laugh, clutching Catra’s hips tightly in her hands.

“Oh I’m gonna be fine… Yeah totally fine. Psh. What are you gonna miss me?” She says.

Catra leans up and kisses her, their lips slanting together gently.

They both relax, holding each other for a moment longer.

With a great sigh, Catra pulls away, leaning up to kiss Adora once more. She reaches for her carry on bag where it sits on the ground, and pats Finn on the head with her other hand as she picks it up.

"You're sure you have everything? Boarding pass? Phone? Keys?" Adora asks.

"Yes, yes, and yes," Catra responds.

"And you have your phone charger? I can get mine out of the car for you if you forgot yours."

"Yep, got my phone charger."

"And-"

"Adora?" Catra cuts her off softly.

Adora stops, "Yeah?"

Catra smiles at her, "Four months."

Adora's lips pull tight into a tense smile.

"Four months," She repeats, "Alright, text me when you get through security ok? And let me know when you board? And oh! Then I guess when you land so I know your flight went well, and then I want to make sure you got back to your apartment safe," Adora rattles off.

Catra understands, she really does, and nods.

"I'll text you every step of the way until I get home tonight. You do the same, ok? I want to know that you both got back to the island safely."

With that, Catra turns toward security, looking back over her shoulder to wave at Adora and Finn. She passes the translucent

barricade and they just see the outline of her disappearing into the line of people waiting.

Adora waits a few seconds before grabbing Finn's hand and the two walk slowly back to the car. While they're on the mainland, Adora takes them to the mall to grab a few new shirts and pairs of shorts. They even stop for lunch and ice cream on the way back to the ferry.

It's nearly dark by the time they pull back into the driveway at the house, and Adora looks in the rear view mirror to see Finn sleeping soundly in the back. She taps her fingers on the worn leather steering wheel, watching their eyelids flutter and their hands clutch at their stuffed animal. It was the one that Catra had won for them at the fair in town, a bright purple lion with a blue mane.

She feels her phone vibrate in her pocket, pulling it out to see a text from Catra. Adora had last heard from her when they were on the ferry, Catra having just arrived back at her apartment.

Hey, love you is the short message. Catra was probably exhausted from the traveling, and Adora smiles at the short reminder.

She types a quick, *We love you too* to her, and pockets her phone.

Four months she thinks as she gets out of the car, grabbing Finn out of the back seat and walking into the house. It's quiet, the hum of the wind and the chirp of crickets carrying her inside, the glow of fireflies lighting her way on the hot summer night.

Instead of thinking about how much she misses her already, how she longs to have Catra in her arms, she instead thinks of the summer they spent together. She thinks of the way it felt to look up at the stars and listen to Catra's heart beat against her ear. She thinks of the knot tying lessons on the porch with Finn, the fish she caught and taught the two of them how to filet. She thinks of the parts of herself she's shared, and the parts she can't wait to.

But mostly, she thinks about how lucky she is that she moved to this shitty town, and got this shitty job for the shittiest mayor of all time, who was just incompetent enough to make Adora reach out to a marine biologist at an acclaimed university a thousand miles away.

She'd wanted this life for herself for so long, to have someone that loved her and her kid unconditionally, someone that was willing to do anything to be with them, to make them happy.

Everyone asked her what she wanted, what would make her happy, because she was so used to bearing the burden no matter what. When it really came down to it? Though she was months from seeing Catra again, this is exactly what she wanted.

December

Chapter Notes

Well well well, how the turntables

I made another epilogue because I wanted to and thats what it's all about I guess

Here we goooooooooo

Thanks for reading!

November

Catra's departure marked the slow descent into Autumn, pleasant cool temperatures and colorful changing leaves arriving in her wake. It wasn't long to stay, winter's biting edge nosing it's way between the threads of sweatshirts and over pebbled skin. The buzz around town of the shark attacks, the disaster that befell them when Adora and, unsurprisingly Kyle, quit, were swept away as the vacation season ended and those who lived on the island for the summer returned home with the tourists.

Town was left nearly empty, except for the few that lived there year-round. Salineas was barely more populous than a ghost town, empty parking lots and ill swept sidewalks left undisturbed in the phantom footsteps of summer beach goers. The tavern at the center of town and the restaurant next to it were the most frequented businesses by the local population, but a certain spectre spent most of its time there.

Adora didn't often visit the types of bars that the disgraced former mayor haunted, but the one time she had, she'd been privy to a view of the disheveled disaster of a woman, ruined with her family name and rotting with her old wealth.

There was nothing more to be said about her, to her, or in her presence. Adora had taken what she needed from this town, given

it her all and nearly her life, and she didn't owe a soul more.

Bare branches scrape vinyl siding and metal gutters, wind whipping across the yard and barren beach front. The heat was on, but a chill still seeped through the gaps under doorways, the drafty seal of the windows. Extra blankets found their way to the couch from the linen closet.

The house is quiet, Finn snuggled down in bed next door and Glimmer and Bow sleeping soundly in their room on the other side of the house. One light stays on, the lamp on Adora's side of the bed in the primary bedroom. A pair of headphones lay on the table, a box of tissues and an empty box of cookies next to it.

Adora holds the phone to her ear, fingers gripping tightly while her sweaty palm tries to loosen her grip. Quiet tears stream down her face, the weight of every emotion she'd ever felt seemingly bearing down on her. The loneliness, the emptiness of her bed, had been normal for years.

Then, Catra had fallen into her life by chance, and suddenly the bed had sides, and the one belonging to Catra had been empty for entirely too long. August faded into September, slipping away and into the semester, occupying much of Adora's time. But then Catra's birthday visit in October had come, and while they needed the time together, it was a reminder of just how much they were missing. Their visit to Catra's apartment a few weeks later made it even worse.

Distance made the heart grow fonder, but it also wore a hole in her chest, dampened her mood late at night where all she wanted was to feel her partner's body against hers.

Those thoughts started to spiral, crushing weight on her chest, and before she knew it Adora had been laying there with rapidly falling tears.

The phone rings a few times, long enough that she considers if it's appropriate to be calling at this time of night, before a groggy

voice picks up.

“Dora?” Catra mumbles on the other line.

Adora winces. She wasn’t used to being allowed to be needy. The guilt even now of waking Catra up made regret flash across her mind.

Sometimes she needed to hear her partner’s voice.

“Hey baby, I’m sorry to wake you,” She says. Try as she might to hide it, her voice betrays the ragged loneliness, the crushing desperation to see or hear or feel anything about Catra.

“What’s up? Are you ok? Is Finn ok?” Catra asks, shuffling on the other end and her voice clearing up indicating that she was now sitting up in bed.

“We’re fine! We’re fine I just…” She trails off.

Catra waits patiently.

This wasn’t the first time over the last few months that one of them had longed for the other, for a touch that wouldn’t come or a kiss that hung in the air. It certainly wasn’t the first late night phone call or the first that sought validation and the gentle caress of a voice across ears. The shiver that runs down Adora’s spine when she can practically feel lips gracing her warm skin or a tongue on the shell of her ear racks her body when Catra goes silent and all she can hear is her breathing.

“I miss you so fucking much,” Adora chokes, squeezing her eyes shut as the edges continue to sting. She sniffs, flexing the fingers that lay across her pillow. “I shouldn’t have woken you up. I know you have work tomorrow. I can just-” She starts, but Catra interrupts her in a soothing tone.

“You should always call me when you’re upset. You don’t have to spiral with your thoughts alone, baby. And I miss you too, so bad.

I can’t believe we still have another month and a half. But we can do this, right?” Catra responds, not sounding so sure herself.

When Adora had dropped Catra back at the airport after her birthday visit, she almost hadn’t gotten out of the car. She’d almost called her boss and quit on the spot, the thought of letting go of Adora’s hand was torture. But she’d gotten out of the car and walked inside, unable to turn around, and she’d try to occupy her time before her flight so she couldn’t call an uber back to the ferry.

So she understood the feeling, the need that arose when they thought of each other.

“Why are we doing this? Why didn’t I just come with you?” Adora asks, laughing a little bit at herself. It felt ridiculous to be this attached, to feel like she couldn’t breathe without Catra, when they hadn’t been together that long. But it also felt so incredibly *real* that she had a hard time trying to take it slower.

They didn’t exactly think that the time would fly, but they were both hoping it would stop feeling so paralyzing.

On the other end of the line, Catra hums, thumping back down on her pillow.

“Because our relationship started fast and never slowed down. And then all of a sudden we thought we were about to die and confessed our undying love for each other. And even though we both meant it, we owed it to ourselves to have a chance at a normal, not life threatening environment to let our relationship progress in a healthy manner. We had lives to get back to, and goals that we shouldn’t put off for the other. Plus, Finn,” Catra says, rattling off the explanation she had to tell herself almost every day when she thought about flying back to the island and never returning to work again.

Adora sighs, hating the logic they’d come up with and wishing she could just run to Catra.

"Finn knows we are going to move when I graduate, but they don't need to get ripped away from the people they've lived with their entire life to move to a tiny apartment in a new city months ahead of when they were preparing to move," Adora finishes.

They both exhale, breath hanging in the airspace between them. The passion, the desire and desperation, were flames that couldn't be doused. But the distance, the struggle of wishing so badly that they were together, made the logic of the decision more offensive.

The fact that this was the right step for the *three* of them, was the worst part.

"Month and a half, baby. End of December and you'll have your degree, your lease will be up, you'll be applying for jobs. But more importantly? You and Finn will be *ready* to move."

"I know I just… I want you to come back. I want you to be *here* . Or I could be *there* , honestly I have no preference. But I know you can't and I know I can't make Finn change that fast. It just sucks that this is the right decision," Adora concedes, turning on her back and pulling her quilt up over her chest.

Catra, on the other line and a thousand miles away, squeezes her eyes shut and clutches her pillow to her chest.

"It will be worth it. I swear I'll make it worth it for you," She whispers.

A beat of silence, a sigh.

"Catra? You've always been worth it. You're everything Finn and I could have wanted."

Adora never doubted that Catra would be worth it. All she had to do was wait for December.

December

Catra stands at the exit to the terminal, crowds of travelers rushing past in all directions, pulling suitcases and holding their kids' hands on their way downstairs to baggage claim or in the opposite direction to security. Sneakers and rubber boots scuff the floor, loudly squeaking on the sparkling white tile. The ceiling, a sweeping expanse of glass, shines with glittering, refracting sunlight on raindrops while a clear blue sky blankets them above. The midmorning sun hasn't warmed anything enough to dry last night's rain yet.

She waits to the side, leaned against the wall with her hands in the pockets of her denim jacket. Her arms looked thicker, the bulk of the grey hoodie beneath padding and insulating her against the chill outside.

They were significantly farther south than Salineas, but that didn't mean Catra wasn't *freezing* in the winter as it slowly drew in. Now, a few weeks until the New Year, the temperature change was starting to feel very permanent.

Busying herself with an article on her phone only takes up a little bit of her time, but she's content to wait in quiet contemplation while she thinks of the people she was waiting for, and what was finally happening.

Balancing work with the new relationship she'd found herself in, with both Adora and Finn, had been no easy task. Spending most of the summer together, getting used to being in her partner's bed, sharing her life with the two of them, and working on her own research in her off time, had soured Catra's willingness to return to her life a thousand miles away. Now that she reflected back on it, she's sure that her colleagues noticed, and it's with a pang of guilt that she acknowledges that her students probably noticed too. She'd never grade anyone unfairly or harshly. She just might not have been as nice as she normally was.

The distance was torture, something she'd never wanted, but it grew more routine in that first month back.

Routine, but not easy. It was never easy.

Facetime dates with Adora and Finn, long calls and all day text conversations had made their connection stronger, and Catra's will to stay away weak. They'd laughed, cried, shared more of themselves every day with each other, and as time moved ever slowly toward the date that they'd been desperate for, things got better and harder at the same time.

Still, she'd upheld her end of the bargain. She did what they agreed to, to make this as healthy a transition for themselves and for Finn as they could.

But all bets were off the moment they stepped off of that plane.

Glancing up at the wall of screens, a blue background with multi-colored text, her eyes zeroed in on the line.

Arrivals | SAL | 8:45 AM | Landed

Catra puts her foot down, planting it forward in a stride as she pushes off from the wall and makes her way closer to the terminal. Caution signs line the doorway, warning travelers that once they'd passed it, there would be no re-entry without heading back around through security. It's as close as she can get to Adora and Finn while they're still getting off of the plane.

A few stragglers from the last round of arrivals wander through, pulling sweaters and coats around themselves in preparation for their foray out into the cold. It's a group from a previous flight, but seeing passengers exit from their gates ahead was starting to make her heart hammer in her chest and her hands sweaty.

Moments later, when Catra is sure that she isn't breathing, couldn't speak if she wanted to, another wave of this most recent arrival starts to barrel toward the doorway at a brisk walk. The chattering of the crowd, partners pointing each other toward

baggage claim, children talking excitedly at their parents, business people on the phone with their ride shares, all turned to a dull thrum against her eardrums.

And then she sees them.

Adora's head, hair ruffled from her headphones, is turned down and to the side. A backpack is strapped to her back, smaller one, Finn's bright blue My Little Pony backpack, is over one shoulder, held there by a fisted hand. The other extends down, likely ushering the child down the hall as they talk to each other.

Catra can feel her breath slip away, what little remains of her coherence escaping her as she takes in the sight of Adora in person, for the first time in over a month. She looks radiant, and happy, something she'd wanted to see in person so much since they parted last.

And they're *all* matching this time.

Adora and Finn approach, twin sandy blonde heads and bright smiles on their faces, with grey sweaters, light blue denim jackets, and navy joggers. They'd matched Catra's outfit perfectly, down to the jacket.

So they had room for a third musketeer after all.

Before she knows it, before she can smile at them or raise a hand to wave, they've spotted her.

"CAT!" Finn shouts, Adora releasing her grip as the child lets go and runs for Catra.

She grins, stooping down and grabbing them when they slam into her, sinking to her knees on the floor with their head tucked under her chin and arms wrapped around her neck. One hand holds them to her, stroking up and down their back, while the other holds the back of their head to press them closer. They hug her just as tight.

A presence, large and imposing but also warm and soothing, makes its presence known next to her for the split second it takes for Adora to drop her bags and then drop to her knees as well. She drags Catra toward her, gripping desperately to her as they squish Finn between them in a hug.

And Catra feels whole again.

“Missed you,” She whispers, planting three kisses in quick succession on Finn's hair while they giggle.

Then she looks up and sees Adora, a tear trailing down her face. Adora reaches up, grabbing Catra’s chin in her hand, and kisses her.

It’s everything she’d been missing, everything Catra had wanted; to be here with Adora and Finn, to be *anywhere* with Adora and Finn. And now that she finally was, all the tears started to fall, her heart started to mend, and the warmth she’d been missing was returning to her.

They pull away, Finn wiggling between them restlessly to be let go from the tight hold. It’s with reluctance that they stand, hugging again before each taking one of Finn’s hands and heading down to baggage claim to get their luggage.

Walking in the door is surreal, different in so many ways since the last time they were here, because now, it wasn’t just Catra’s apartment.

It was *theirs* . The *three* of them.

As soon as they cross the threshold, rolling suitcases in with them and dropping backpacks to the floor, the early morning and late, excited night before are plastered across Finn’s face. They yawn, leaning a little harder into Adora, which makes her bend down and pick them up.

“Need a nap, baby?” She asks, rocking back and forth in the small hallway.

Catra lurks in the entryway, staring at her two *non-guests* .

“You can just put them in bed,” She says, a mischievous grin on her face.

Adora looks back at her.

“Well I was hoping *we* could hop in your bed for… a nap,” She mumbles.

“We can. But… they can go to bed in *their* room,” She says, biting her lip.

Adora gapes.

Over the course of the last couple of months, Adora had been shipping both hers and Finn’s belongings to Catra’s apartment. Boxes piled around the living room was evidence enough of that. It was easier than moving in a truck all at once, especially with the distance, and by the time last week had rolled around, everything they could fit into suitcases and backpacks stayed with them and the last round of boxes was sent to Catra’s.

They had plans to spend the first week that they lived together rearranging the apartment, making room for Finn and Adora in the small space. While they figured out what to do with the office, Finn would sleep with them.

Once the office was cleared out, they’d buy a bedroom set for Finn.

But, evidently, Catra had other plans.

She nods down the hall, shuffling quietly in the direction of the bedrooms and her office, turning into the smaller room when she hears that Adora is following her.

Because it wasn't Catra's office anymore at all.

A twin size bed, four posts wrapped with artificial ivy and twinkle lights, sits in the corner. It's already made, fresh purple linens with a dark blue checkered flannel blanket folded neatly at the end. A few stuffed animals sit up against the pillows.

Along the far wall is a white, cubby style shelf with translucent pink and blue bins filled with toys, craft, and school supplies. A small desk sits next to it, wedged into the other corner with two kids sized, bright pink plastic chairs. The barbie dream house sits on top, hotwheels track running through it and exiting into a bin on the floor.

Looking along the wall to the right is the closet. While the sliding door is open, a rainbow beaded curtain hangs from the frame. Finn's shirts, sweaters, and coats are already hanging up, shoes arranged on the rack on the floor. The last piece of furniture, a chest of drawers, is likely where the rest of their clothes are folded.

The walls, once the stark white of Catra's office, unpainted from the builder selected color, were now pale pink, blue half moons and yellow star decals spread around the room.

Finn's old drawings are in a folder on the little table, ready for them to help hang up in any order they see fit.

Adora sniffs.

"Hey, baby? We're in your room," She chokes a little as she whispers down to Finn, patting them on the back as they stir against her shoulder.

The few minutes weren't enough to knock them out, but it's with lethargic, slow movements that they lift their head from her shoulder and turn to look.

Sleepy, drooping eyes peer around the room in wonder, smile on their face as the twinkling lights on the bed and the pedestal lamp

in the corner glow in their glassy eyes. Adora slowly puts them down, and they walk over to play with the beads hanging from the closet.

Catra is practically terrified, rooted to the spot with an irrational fear. The entire time she'd picked out the paint, put together the new bed, strung up the lights and ivy and beads, she'd wanted Finn to feel safe and welcome in this new place. Now, with them scrutinizing her efforts, her heart was beating out of her chest while her stance remained rigid.

They quietly survey the room. They open a couple of drawers in the chest where they find carefully folded clothes, look through the clear bins of toys in the cubbies, run their fingers over the hard plastic of the doll house, and then crawls up onto the bed to sit next to the three stuffed animals that were placed there. They reach out, threading their fingers through the hair of the lion's mane, poking at the shiny eyes, and squeezing a cotton filled foot.

"For me?" They ask, fingers still tracing the seam that ran down the belly of the lion.

Catra softens, "Yeah bud, this is your room. Do… Do you like it?" She asks.

They look at her, grinning, and she smiles back.

"Yeah! 'S not the same. But it's better, cuz…" They trail off.

Adora makes it to the bed as well, leaning with an arm on one of the posts, and says, "Cuz what?"

"Cuz we get to live with Cat now. For real."

December, 2 years later

"I'm home!" Catra shouts, pulling the front door closed behind her with her elbow around the handle, a tray of coffee and several

grocery bags balanced in her hands. She toes off her wet boots and kicks them to the side, sock feet landing on the cool hardwood floor. It's nearing evening, sun already retreating below the trees on the shortened winter day.

Catra had decided already that moving in just before the new year was a terrible idea. The difference in temperature between the warm house and the freezing outside had made everyone a sweaty, cold mess, and she was thankful that they weren't beholden to a landlord with a short contract anymore.

The house is quiet, all of them losing steam as the day wore on. She'd run out to grab coffee and sandwiches from the deli for dinner, but feared that it was coming a little late for them to get back momentum.

That was ok, though. They had time.

Feet pad up behind her, landing softly on the tile of the kitchen as she sets down coffee and dinner on the counter. Arms wrap around her from behind, a kiss landing on the back of her exposed neck with a smack.

"God I love you," Adora whispers, reaching forward to grab a coffee out of the tray. Catra snorts, batting her hand toward the latte that she knows to be Adora's so that she can pick it up and take a sip.

The ring on her finger is a heavy weight that draws her hand to Adora's, threading their fingers so twin bands rub against each other. The way Adora's long, thin fingers flex against her skin, makes her shiver.

"How's everyone doing? It's getting quiet in here. Hope I'm not too late," She asks as she and Adora rock back and forth together.

Adora squeezes tighter, breathing in the way it feels to stand in her kitchen holding her wife.

“Finn’s fighting through it. Their room is pretty much done, but they’re organizing their toys. I have a feeling they’re on borrowed time as far as sleep goes. Bow and Glimmer are making the guest bed so when we actually *do* call it for the day we can just collapse without having to get ready. But we got the whole kitchen put away while you were out!” Adora says, groggy but with a renewed excitement.

Catra thinks it's cute, but she’d be lying if she said she wasn’t just as excited.

She’d never owned a house before, so this was just as new to her as it was to Adora.

The fortune she found when she met Adora, the love and family that she never knew she was missing, had filled a part of her heart that she wasn’t sure could be filled. But there was a person holding her that loved her more than she thought anyone could love her. And there was a child down the hall that looked to her as a mother, something else she didn’t think she’d have.

Light footsteps shuffle down the hall and Catra turns just in time to see Finn walk through the threshold into the kitchen, rubbing one eye as they stumble forward.

“Hey baby,” She says as they walk up and hug her legs. She ruffles their hair and runs her hand down their back while they stand there attached to her.

“Hi mama,” They whisper.

She grins, pulling away from Adora to take their cup out of the tray and kneel down to hand it to them.

“I got you some hot cider,” She says, and their eyes light up as they take the drink and bring it to their lips to sip.

“Thank you!” They say, taking a gulp that makes Catra happy that she thought to add some ice to the cup.

"Lets go sit in the living room and eat," Adora says, picking up the bag of sandwiches and patting Finn's hair, turning them around gently by the shoulder and nudging them out of the kitchen.

When Catra follows, she stands in the doorway watching. She sees the vein that runs up Adora's flexing bicep, the sharp line of her jaw and the rounded muscles of her shoulders. She observes the curve of her smile, the laugh lines around her eyes, the few grey streaks that had popped up one by one on her head.

Catra looks at Finn, her *child,* and thinks how much they've grown since she's known them. She remembers the little person they'd been the first time she'd met them, in that godforsaken town during the summer that changed her life.

As she walks to the couch, her eyes catch the photos Adora had already placed along the fireplace mantel. The few pictures that Catra has of her parents; herself and her father with her first fish, standing next to her mother in the kitchen, the three of them with heads poking out of a tent at a campsite, sit there on display.

Then it transitions to photos of their little family; a polaroid of the three of them on the couch from their second date, Catra still in her tie and a vase of roses in the background, Catra and Finn on their first fishing trip together, sharing something that Catra had held dear for so many years.

Catra makes eye contact with her father, twenty years younger on cracked and faded photo paper, and smiles.

I miss you both, but I have what you'd always wanted for me.

December, 3 years later

Adora waves goodbye to her webcam and, with a closing remark, ends the teams video call. She pushes back from her desk, gripping the grain of the wood as her chair rolls back a few feet. The wheels catch slightly on the familiar notch where one

floorboard sticks up a little higher, the worn dip that had been there since before they bought the house.

Golden, glowing sunlight streams through the vining plants crawling across the ceiling, shadows speckling the sage green walls.

Twin desks on opposite walls mark Adora and Catra's separate workstations, pedestal lamps in opposite corners point at the ceiling, diffusing crisp light around the room. Floating shelves hold several more plants, long vines draping between displayed pictures.

A single photo sits in an antique brass frame on both of their desks. It's from their wedding day. Adora stands in a white dress, the skirt coming down to her knees, sleeveless and coming up with a collar neck and a long tie. Catra wears a maroon tux, bow tie undone, with her hair slicked back. She's holding Finn, wearing a white skirt, but a dress shirt and suit jacket that matches Catra's perfectly. It was a cherished photo, from one of their happiest days. Neither would dare declare it the happiest, because they found that, as the years went on, every day they spent together was their happiest.

Just below the window was a small table with mahogany legs and a marble top. It had the important job of holding an electric kettle, a box each of Adora and Catra's favorite teas, and a set of matching mugs. Adora, preferring lemon in her tea, would usually cut a few slices in the morning to sit next to her mug. Moving the tea kettle to the office had been a game changer, especially as the colder months set in and the wood of the old house contracted, gaps allowing a draft to seep in.

Adora places a hand on her growing stomach, rubbing over the shifting form below her skin.

"Feel like an afternoon nap?" She whispers, tapping her thumb fondly as she feels them settle down.

They were all excited to meet the newest member of their family, but Catra and Finn had a certain nervousness that was just too cute for Adora to ignore. Finn had never been an older sibling, and while Catra was Finn's mama, she hadn't had the experience of raising a child from infancy.

Adora would be there to guide her, and they would both learn what it was like to have an infant and a nine year old under the same roof.

Her company was generous with their maternity leave, and her last major project before the baby arrived was wrapping up. They'd been accommodating her request for breaks, and were okay with the time she spent away from desk so long as she returned before the day was out to answer any emails and updates from her team.

Before getting up, she decides on another cup of tea to take with her for her nap. She sets the water leftover in the kettle to boil, places a teabag in her mug, and turns to her computer to pull up something to browse, absentmindedly rubbing her fingers over her baby bump. The weather report for the following week, when Glimmer and Bow would be flying in for the holidays, crosses her page, along with a few local headlines.

A strange one catches her eye, and she reads it with ever growing dread.

Salineas; Shark Central. Two more bodies found after reports of recent shark attacks-

Adora squeezes her eyes shut, and suddenly, she's back on that boat. Water laps at her feet as she grips the gun in one hand and the phone in the other. Seeing Catra disappear into the water, promises of love and a future fresh on their lips, for her to never resurface. A last phone call, what she thought would be her last time speaking to Finn. It all felt like a lifetime ago, years pushing it further and further into the past.

She opens her eyes, moves the cursor to the corner of her screen, and closes the window.

When the kettle is hot, she pours it carefully over the cloth bag, squeezes a slice of lemon into it, and heads across the hall to her bedroom.

Because what happened on that island?

Wasn’t any of her fucking problem anymore.

AN: Fic to be deleted from AO3 on Tuesday August 13th at 8 pm EDT

Chapter Summary

> Fic to be deleted from AO3 on Tuesday August 13th at 8 pm EDT

Hey everyone.

I've been thinking about doing this for a while, and its probably past time to just do something about it instead of thinking about it.

Thank you to everyone who read and enjoyed and commented. I really appreciate that you took the time to read my fic and you all have said some really wonderful things to me about it.

At the time, I thought of the AU and wanted to write it because Jaws is a movie I really like, it was summer time, the fashion is impeccable. The main character is a cop, which is not something I wanted to ignore, so I thought I could write it and acknowledge that. It reads like a noncommittal, middle of the road sympathy piece about Adora's feelings when I somehow thought I was making a criticism of the system, but I ultimately failed by making excuses about why Adora decided to be a part of it and how that's affected *her* life and *her* feelings. Oh no, if it isn't the consequences of her own actions. For that, I've kind of resented this fic for a while.

I'm not like... delusional to think that a fic I wrote 3 years ago might take up any kind of space in someone's mind, let alone them giving it enough energy to bother them. I'm really not trying to be dramatic about it or seem like I think what I'm doing is impressive or I'm so much better of a person now than I was then. But when we all say that people should stop turning characters into cops, saying "but this person did it well" is like... okay but they didn't need to do it at all. And I know that a way

bigger part of the story is... pretty much everything else, but its there, I don't like it, and ACAB including Adora. Catra would not have dated her. 0% chance she'd even hang out with her outside of an uncomfortable and strictly professional work relationship where she'd interact with Adora as little as possible.

Deleting the fic might seem extreme and out of nowhere, but honestly, I've been thinking of what to do for so long. There could be multiple right things to do depending on individual opinion.

I'm embarrassed that I made excuses for even a fictional cop. For that, I just am not going to leave the fic up the way it is. I know I can't do a rewrite, I'm not writing like I was years ago and I know I can't commit to that. I might, MIGHT, post the family fluff and gender parts as a multi chapter outtakes sort of situation. No promises. I know that there are parts that were meaningful to some people, I just haven't decided if I should repost what people liked, reuse those ideas in any future fics, or just have them be dead with the rest of it. I downloaded it to have the final draft incase I decided to do any of that, but I may not.

This post ended up longer than I intended, but if you made it this far, thank you for reading and hearing me out. I'm probably overreacting. I'm probably not explaining it well. It doesn't change that people had to see "police chief Adora" pop up on their feed for 11 chapters, but it will make it so no one else can scroll past it and think that its in any way okay to sympathize with class traitors who exist to protect the interests and property of the rich while protecting each other from accountability and doing active harm to people and communities they 'serve.' No matter how good of a fic it is, if I even did the topic justice (which I don't think I did), I think that not making Adora a cop would always have been a better decision.

I am going to take the fic off AO3 on **Tuesday August 13th at 8 pm EDT**. I think a couple of days is enough time to see the new post or get the email if you're still subscribed, read it, and not be completely confused that the fic is gone

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!